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Happening today

●**CHIEF NEGOTIATORS** of India and Canada will begin the fifth round of five-day negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement in Ottawa.

●**SWISS PRESIDENT** Guy Parmelin will visit India and hold talks with PM Narendra Modi on trade, technology and regional and global developments. He is also scheduled to meet President Droupadi Murmu.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Forget libraries. You just need the literacy to rename roads and buildings. I will manage the rest.



Top court will hear today matter on relocating 135-yr-old government library

Takes suo motu cognizance of *Express* report on lack of space for CSL's 8.5 lakh books



The *Indian Express* report published on September 30

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 4

TAKING SUO motu cognizance of a September 30 report in *The Indian Express*, the Supreme Court will hear Monday the matter relating to the relocation of the 135-year-old Central Secretariat Library (CSL) in Shastri Bhavan which is set to be torn down as part of the Central Vista revamp plan.

The *Indian Express* reported that the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and Central Public Works Department are yet to find space for the library which houses more than 8.5 lakh books.

The matter, registered

SAYS INDIA'S AGE-OLD TIES WITH RUSSIA REFRESHED

A little more involved: Jaishankar on ending Russia-Ukraine war

‘We have now gone beyond advocacy, in conversations with both countries’

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, October 4

DISCLOSING THAT India has gone “beyond advocacy” to be a “little more involved” in the efforts to end the Russia-Ukraine war raging since February 2022, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said Sunday that Delhi has been in conversations with both Moscow and Kyiv, trying to be “helpful” on the safety of shipping in the Black Sea, grain and energy exports and on “non-attack possibilities”.

His remarks, at the Munich Leaders’ Meeting in New Delhi, came days after Ukraine’s Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said India had put forward a “comprehensive” and “broad” proposal to end the war for the



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar meets US Indo-Pacific Command Commander, Admiral Samuel J Paparo, and US Ambassador Sergio Gor in New Delhi, Sunday. PTI

first time.

Jaishankar said, “We are seeing today an unfortunate conflict. Our position on that conflict has been very clear, which is that we would like to see an end to this conflict, and we believe that this will require dialogue and diplomacy. There has to be negotiations in this regard. We have been advocating

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Autonomy over ties

Jaishankar’s remarks on the age-old India-Russia ties underline Delhi’s resolve to maintain strategic autonomy despite Western scrutiny and US tariff threats over Indian purchase of Russian energy.

Russia drones hit pharma warehouse owned by Indians, 1 killed: Ukraine

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, October 4

UKRAINE’S PRESIDENT Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Sunday that Russia attacked a pharmaceutical warehouse in Sumy with drones. The Ukrainian embassy in Delhi identified it as belonging to Indian owners.

A report in Ukrainian news outlet, Kyiv Independent, said, “In Sumy Oblast, at least three people were killed and 16 others injured in a series of Russian attacks, according to local authorities. On October 4, a Russian drone attack on a warehouse storing medical supplies in Sumy killed a 52-year-old employee and injured three others, local authorities said.”

Zelenskyy, in a post on X, condemned the “Russian at-

THE WORLD P 14



MERZ UNVEILS NEW MILITARY AID FOR UKRAINE: ‘WILL NOT BE INTIMIDATED’

tack” and offered condolences to the family of the person who was killed.

“This morning, the Russians once again struck the Pivnichnyi »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



The Indian contingent during the Asian Games closing ceremony in Nagoya, Japan, Sunday. AP

RELATED REPORTS, PAGE 19

Team depth to individual gaps: India’s Asian Games report card for LA 2028



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, October 4

●BETWEEN THE 2022 Asian Games in China’s Hangzhou and the latest edition that wound up Sunday in Japan’s Nagoya, the Government spent Rs 97.84 crore under the Target Olympic Podium Scheme

Talent spotting, investment under lens; officials say performance ‘encouraging’

(TOPS). Only two per cent of it, approximately, translated to gold medals this time.

●Teenager Kumkum Mohod won arguably India’s biggest individual gold despite not being in the flagship scheme; Suruchi Singh, the shooter, was added only recently, while her mixed team partner, Kamaljeet Singh, isn’t on the list; Neeru Dhandu, who won a trap gold in shooting, remains outside the TOPS core

group, too.

●Thirteen of India’s 21 golds came in team events, some of which aren’t in the Olympics, while 19 of its 27 silvers came in individual events.

These numbers present different stories from Nagoya: the first about talent identification, the second on allocation of considerable investment in elite sport, and the third offering encouragement and a warning —

there is growing depth in team events but athletes are struggling in individual events to make that final push from silver to gold.

India finished fourth at the Asian Games with 21 gold, 27 silver and 37 bronze medals, 85 in all. It fell short of the 100-medal target and finished 21 medals behind its record haul in Hangzhou.

“We may have lost a few medals compared to (Hangzhou) but individual performances were satisfying,” Adille Sumariwala, the »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

ADDRESS AT NALSAR, HYDERABAD

Disenfranchisement of millions arbitrary, no whataboutery can justify it, says SC judge

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, October 4

AMID THE row over the SIR of electoral rolls against which petitions have been filed in the Supreme Court, Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, a judge of the top court, said Sunday that any process that leads to wholesale disenfranchisement of Indian citizens, making them citizens without voting rights, would be violative of the Constitution. No amount of whataboutery can justify it, he said.

Justice Bhuyan said detaching an Indian citizen from the right to vote would be akin to “taking out the soul from the body.”

Speaking at the valedictory ceremony of Justice Bodh Raj Sawhney Memorial Moot Court competition at Nalsar University of Law, Hyderabad, he said, “If any process results in disenfranchising millions and millions of Indian citizens, making them second-class citizens in their own country, in the sense of being citizens without voting rights, such a process is intrinsic-



Supreme Court Judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

sically arbitrary. No amount of whataboutery can justify it.” “It strikes at the very heart of the Constitution and I would go to the extent of saying that it is a negation of the constitutional order, which we have adopted under the Constitution of India,” he said.

Speaking on the significance of universal adult suffrage, especially in the context of India, Justice Bhuyan said, “From the persona of an Indian citizen, the right to vote or right to be included in the voters’ list cannot be detached. It will be like taking out the soul from the body.”

He said the earliest articulation of adult franchise in India »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

IDEA EXCHANGE

‘Maybe it’s a new generation that will find their own Gandhi, which will be different from mine and yours’

RAMACHANDRA GUHA, HISTORIAN, PAGE 16



Held in Ethiopia on ‘dunki’ route to US, cousins freed as police reach out to ‘kidnapper’



Police station in Langhnaj, Mehsana, where the release was negotiated

Brendan Dabhi
Ahmedabad, October 4

WHEN COUSINS Mamta (30), Rutvik (23), and Mayuri (27) reached Langhnaj in Gujarat’s Mehsana district on October 1, their first stop, even before they went home, was the local police station.

This was a procedural requirement — but the cousins also wanted to meet the officers whose “remarkable negotiating skills” over phone had extricated them from the clutches of

a gang of abductors in Ethiopia.

The cousins, from a farming family in Vadasma village in North Gujarat, had hoped to travel to the United States. However, given the severe restrictions on migration by the Trump administration, they had allegedly chosen to take an illegal, circuitous “dunki” route. They never made it.

The cousins were allegedly waylaid in Ethiopia, in eastern Africa, not far from the theatre of hostilities between the US »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

●MADHYA PRADESH GOVT HAS APPROVED 128 PROJECTS — FROM NEW HIGHWAYS TO BRIDGES, GHATS TO FIVE-STAR HOTELS

Hotels, roads and the race against time: Inside Ujjain’s Simhashta 2028 makeover

Anand Mohan J
Ujjain, October 4

UJJAIN HAS always resisted the march of time, clinging to its ancient city of temples, ghats, bazaars and British-era offices. Now, as Ujjain prepares for Simhashta 2028, its maps are being redrawn, hurtling the sleepy temple town towards a new modernity — carved through its old streets with bulldozers, widened roads and concrete.

On September 27, a crowd gathered outside the Shahi Masjid, where the administration was preparing to remove

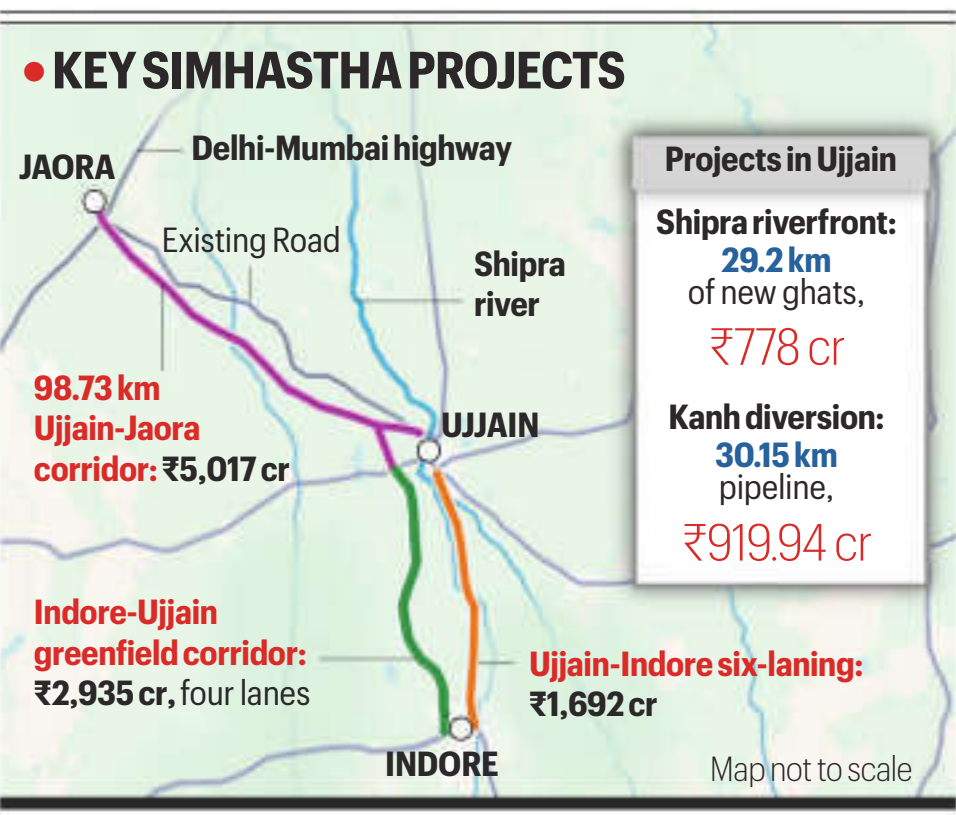
the portion of the mosque within the proposed road alignment, as protests raged over road-widening projects in Ujjain ahead of the 2028 Simhashta. Hours later, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav took an ax to his grandfather’s ancestral home in Abdulpura.

The demolitions came as the administration raced against time for the Simhashta Mela 2028, for which the government has approved 128 projects worth about Rs 13,851 crore across 10 departments. For Yadav, Simhashta has become his government’s defining project,

with the administration effectively mobilised around a single task: transforming the ancient temple town before pilgrims arrive.

On the ground, the transformation is unfolding on a scale rarely seen in Ujjain’s modern history. Highways are being carved into the city’s approaches, railway lines and by-passes are being built, roads and bridges widened, kilometres of new ghats taking shape along the Shipra, and water and sewerage networks being laid underground.

What is taking shape is not simply a city preparing for a festival, but a centuries-old temple



Officials inspect construction of an underpass at Hari Phatak, aimed at providing an alternative route to Mahakal Lok. EXPRESS

town being physically remade into a modern pilgrimage city. Simhashta Mela Authority director Jagdish Aggarwal’s office in Kothi Road, a leafy neigh-

bourhood, is less a conventional government chamber these days than a control room for one of Madhya Pradesh’s biggest infrastructure exercises. Project officers come in with updates, meetings are held with swamis and other stakeholders, and meetings with the chief minister are woven into a schedule dominated by Simhashta.

Every Thursday, Aggarwal sits with the collector and deputy collector for a review devoted to the same question: how to get Ujjain ready for 2028?

“We are preparing keeping in mind the possibility of

around 40 crore people coming to Ujjain,” Aggarwal said, explaining why projects that would otherwise appear excessive for Ujjain are being taken up simultaneously.

But there’s also a human cost involved: the eroding trust among residents. Yasin Khan, a local, welcomed the road-widening project but frowned upon the speed at which the administration proceeded.

“When the houses were marked in my neighbourhood, both Hindu and Muslim families came out and demolished portions of the houses ourselves. But the administration »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Newborn girl found strangled inside MP hospital, family under suspicion

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, October 4

A NEWBORN girl was allegedly strangled to death, within 16 hours of her birth, at a hospital in Madhya Pradesh's Ashoknagar district, with police now probing the family members.

The baby, born to a couple from the Chanderi area, was admitted to the hospital shortly after birth and was being kept under medical observation. By Saturday afternoon, she was dead.

What initially appeared to be a sudden deterioration in the newborn's condition became a suspected murder after doctors noticed marks around her neck and blood coming from her mouth.

"An initial medical investigation showed that there were some marks on the infant's neck. Furthermore, blood was also spotted on her face. We are questioning the infant's family members," said a police officer.

Police said the examination subsequently found "ligature or compression marks around the baby's neck, indicating that she could have been strangled," the officer said.

The finding prompted investigators to reconstruct the few hours between her admission and her death, including

who had handled the baby, who had entered the ward and when she was last seen alive.

The baby was born late on Friday night, around 11.50 pm, and was admitted to the Special Newborn Care Unit (SNCU) soon after. She was found dead between about 3 pm and 4 pm on Saturday, less than 16 hours after her birth.

A health official from the district said hospital staff immediately took the newborn to the SNCU after she was found unresponsive.

"Doctors examined the child and found that she had already died. The baby had blood coming from her mouth and marks resembling pressure around her neck. Given these circumstances, the hospital treated the death as suspicious and informed the police, following which the body was sent for post-mortem examination," the official said.

The newborn was the second daughter of her parents. Investigators are, therefore, examining whether the baby's gender and the family's circumstances could have played a role in her killing.

The absence of CCTV cameras inside the SNCU has also made it difficult to immediately ascertain how she was killed.

Bihar: Gandak recedes, 7 engineers suspended over flood response negligence

Press Trust of India
Patna, October 4

WATER LEVEL of the Gandak River in Bihar has started receding rapidly, even as the state government on Sunday suspended seven engineers and initiated departmental proceedings against another official for alleged negligence in handling the recent floods, an official statement said.

At Rewaghat in Saran, the water level of Gandak has fallen 177 cm from its record high and is now 50 cm below the danger mark, the statement by Water Resources Department (WRD) on Sunday evening said.

The Gandak had registered

unprecedented water levels following heavy rain in adjoining Nepal and UP. The department said inspections found laxity and delays in the emergency response by some engineers, including inadequate mobilisation of manpower and materials and poor coordination with locals and elected representatives.

"Seven engineers, including two executive engineers, have been suspended with immediate effect. Departmental proceedings have also been ordered against Muzaffarpur chief engineer Kumar Manoj Gupta over alleged negligence following damage to the Champaran embankment," the statement said.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

A little more involved: Jaishankar on ending Russia-Ukraine war

it for many years, and in recent months, we have got a little bit more involved beyond advocacy. So we have conversations with both Russia and Ukraine in this regard."

"We are trying to be helpful, starting with the Black Sea safety of shipping issue, but going beyond that to cover some immediate concerns which both of them have on grain exports, on energy exports, on non-attack possibilities. So those are ongoing conversations right now."

He said India and Russia have historically had very good relations, particularly since the 1950s, and that history is not forgotten.

"For us, Russia and the Soviet Union before that was a country that stood by us in many ways

when our security, when our territorial integrity was under threat. And at a time when, you know, much of the world preferred backing a military regime next to us, Russia was a country with which our relations were very good, and... we are obviously shaped in many ways by that legacy. Today, the relationship has widened beyond that. You know, it is again, the world has changed. We have changed. Our own relationships are not what they were in the '70s and '80s. Neither is the case with Russia's," he said.

"So, like any relationship, it is refreshed. It undergoes a change. New issues come. Old issues sometimes get rebalanced. So it is very much more today an economic relationship as well.

So there is a military component. There's a nuclear component. There are space issues, but there is a significant amount of trade and investment between the two countries, and of course, energy and resources as well. So, any country would, when you view another country, you judge it from our experiences..."

"I can't expect Europe, for example, to look at the world and say, okay, what does India think? And my view should be based on India's experience. Europe will base its judgement on Europe's experience. India will base its judgment on India's experience. So India's experience has been, frankly, quite positive and consistently positive," he said.

On October 1, Russian Presi-

but there have been some incredible results."

The official said TOPS "follows a dynamic and continuous evaluation process". "The TOPS team closely monitors emerging and established elite athletes, with regular assessments to ensure that deserving athletes are inducted into the Development and Core Groups based on their performance, potential and medal prospects," the official said.

Nagoya also confronted some of India's traditional strongholds with reality checks.

● In badminton, India failed to win an individual medal for the first time in 12 years. The sport had already returned empty-handed from the Paris Olympics, its first medal-less Olympic campaign since 2012.

● In weightlifting, Mirabai Chanu's silver was India's first Asian Games medal in the sport since 1998. At 32, she remains the country's most established name, but the only one doing the heavy lifting, with no obvious successor.

● Athletics and shooting, which won 51 medals combined in Hangzhou, contributed 39 this time (athletics 24, shooting 15).

According to the Sports Ministry official, there will now be a review of the performance. "Where performance has been below expectations, a thorough assessment will be undertaken to identify gaps, draw lessons and strengthen preparations, with a clear focus on the Los Angeles 2028 Olympic Games," the official said, adding that the review would have been com-

dent Vladimir Putin said Prime Minister Narendra Modi "constantly raises the question about putting an end to the conflict" and has "very good ideas".

Later that day, speaking to reporters in Kyiv, Ukraine's Foreign Minister Sybiha said, "We have four proposals. The most comprehensive is India's proposal. For the first time, India has signalled its willingness to play a role." He said Ukraine is prepared to agree to an energy and agricultural truce in the Black Sea, and is also considering an unconditional ceasefire along the line of contact.

Besides India, Ukraine has received proposals for a possible ceasefire from Turkey, Egypt and the United States.

According to Sybiha, Ukraine will agree to a ceasefire on the condition that it covers not only combat operations, but also an end to attacks on energy and port infrastructure, as well as the situation in the Black Sea.

ducted "irrespective of whether performance exceeds expectations or falls short of targets".

Archery provided one of the clearest signs of what is possible. India's women's recurve team ended South Korea's 28-year Asian Games reign before Kumkum won the individual title, evidence that a younger generation is now capable of challenging a programme that has dominated the event for decades.

Women's hockey offered another example of how quickly a programme can change. After missing the Paris Olympics, the players went through specialised penalty-corner and goal-keeping clinics with foreign experts, while 11 injured players received rehabilitation support. In Nagoya, they beat China for gold and secured qualification for Los Angeles.

Men's wrestling produced Aman Sehrawat and Sujet Kalkal as gold medalists. Ankush Panghal, Lovlina Borgohain and Parveen Hooda helped return boxing to the top of the Asian Games podium. Women's pistol shooting, where India has considerable depth, continued to produce results.

These are the reasons Nagoya can offer encouragement ahead of Los Angeles.

The Asian Games are a mid-term examination before the Olympics. India has shown depth in several team events, new names have emerged in individual sports and established athletes remain capable of providing a foundation for the next cycle.

The gaps are clear, too.

Disenfranchisement of millions arbitrary: SC judge

can be traced to the Constitution of India Bill, 1895, also known as the Swaraj Bill.

Speaking about the debate in the Constituent Assembly on universal adult suffrage, he said, "In the draft Constitution, which was debated by the Constituent Assembly, there were two articles of relevance, though included subsequently. These were Articles 289A and 289B... Draft Article 289A became Article 325 and draft Article 289B became Article 326 of the Constitution of India..."

"Article 325 of the Constitution of India declares that there shall be one general electoral roll for every territorial constituency for election to the Lok Sabha or to the Legislature of a State; no person shall be ineligible for inclusion in any such roll or claim to be included in any electoral roll for any such constituency on grounds only of religion, race, caste, sex or any of them."

"As per Article 326 of the Constitution, election to the Lok Sabha and to the Legislative Assembly of every State shall be on the basis of adult suffrage. In other words, every person who is a citizen of India and who is not less than 18 years of age (prior to March 28, 1989, it was 21 years) and who is not disqualified under the Constitution of India or by any law made by the appropriate legislature on the ground of non-residence, unsoundness of mind, crime or corrupt or illegal practice, shall be entitled to be registered as a voter at any such election," he said.

Quoting Dr B R Ambedkar,

Justice Bhuyan said, "Justifying universal adult suffrage, Dr Ambedkar said since we have taken a very important decision, which practically nullifies the past, it is better that the Constitution should, in express terms, state it is the basis for insertion of Articles 289A and 289B in the draft Constitution, which are now Articles 325 and 326."

"Dr Ambedkar's closing speech warned that the right to vote and the Indian citizen's entitlement to adult suffrage should be written into the Constitution of India, instead of being left to the whims of parliamentary legislation," he said.

Justice Bhuyan said, "Adoption of universal adult franchise reflects the determined opinion of the Constituent Assembly that years of freedom struggle and the revolt against foreign rule made the adoption of universal adult franchise a natural choice and an essential ingredient of democracy, which we have adopted as the form of governance."

"Therefore, it was an act of faith for our founding fathers in the common man of India and in his pragmatism and wisdom. It was the first step taken to achieve equality in India."

"One may be a billionaire, and one may be a rickshaw-puller. Yet both will have their votes, and the value of their votes would be equal. Likewise, a socially high-placed temple priest on the one hand and a person belonging to the lowest strata of the society compelled to work as a manual scavenger have an equal vote with equal value. This is the transformational vision of the Indian Constitution," he said.

SC to hear today matter on relocating library

books including rare books, official records and gazetteers, and continues to receive a steady stream of visitors including government officials and students preparing for competitive examinations.

The oldest book, in a separate section of rare books in the library, is the compilation of a French traveller's writings, dating back to 1702.

On September 17, the CPWD wrote to all ministries and departments situated in Shastri Bhavan, saying the complex be vacated, including

all furniture, electronic items and other belongings, "at the earliest" as it "needs to be handed over... by the end of September 2026 for the commencement of the construction work".

Sources said that in January, the Directorate of Estates allotted two rooms, with an area of 300 square metres, at Kartavya Bhavan-2 for the CSL. The Ministry of Culture, which administers the CSL, rejected this, replying that the space allotted was far from sufficient, the sources said.

Russia drones hit pharma warehouse owned by Indians

Bridge in Kyiv with a drone. They attacked an ordinary pharmaceutical warehouse in Sumy with drones. Tragically, one person was killed. My condolences to the family and loved ones. In Dnipro, they struck a communications facility. Six people were injured as a result of these attacks," he said.

The Ukrainian embassy in Delhi said, "The aggressor does not care that this is not a mili-

tary target. It does not care that this is a pharmaceutical factory producing critically needed medicines."

"The barbarians do not care that the factory belongs to Indian owners. The hypocrites continue talking about the 'historic friendship' between India and Muscovy. In reality, death and destruction are the true face of Russian fascism, hidden behind the mask," it said in a

post on X.

"Our deepest condolences go to the family of the person who was killed. We also express our sincere sympathy to the Indian owners over the destruction of their factory," it said.

"Punishment will be inevitable. And for now, what is needed are tough sanctions and the isolation of these criminals, not pushpa mala," the embassy said.

Russia escalated its attacks on Ukrainian cities, and the aerial war has intensified, with Moscow menacing cities across Ukraine with hard-to-intercept ballistic missiles and jet-powered drones, while Kyiv has been striking Russia's oil industry and businesses.

Russian attacks damaged Kyiv's northern bridge over the Dnipro river again Sunday. Video circulating on social

media showed a drone striking the bridge and exploding as vehicles crossed. Kyiv Mayor Vitali Klitschko said two persons were wounded.

Russian assaults since Thursday have forced the full or partial closure of three of Kyiv's six road bridges, suspending traffic and causing tailbacks in Moscow's latest effort to disrupt life in the Ukrainian capital. (WITH AGENCY REPORTS)

Police, the Gujarat Police headquarters at Gandhinagar, and the MEA in New Delhi, the sources said. They said that Langhnaj police decided to take Aditya Panchal into confidence, and get him to engage with the alleged abductor in their presence.

"Panchal, a member of the cousins' family, and two police personnel spoke to Baba Khan continuously over several calls. They tried to convince Baba Khan that the middle-class family was engaged in farming, and couldn't afford to pay the huge ransom, especially as they had already paid Rs 60 lakh to the network – at Rs 20 lakh per person – to ferry them to the US," Inspector Gehlot said.

"Following the negotiations, the kidnappers brought their demand down to Rs 15 lakh. They said this was the lowest they were willing to go, at Rs 15 lakh per person," Gehlot said.

By then, investigators had begun to suspect that 'Baba Khan' was only an alias. The man on the other end would speak on WhatsApp voice calls, and would never agree to come on video, which might offer police clues as to his identity, sources said. "At one point, on September 30, the family representative told Baba Khan they could not afford to pay him even Rs 5 lakh, let alone the Rs 15 lakh that he was demanding," Gehlot said. This was followed by some tense moments. The abductor

seemed very angry, and he "swore and hung up", police sources said.

But later that day, the family got a video call from an unknown number. "When they answered, they saw Mamta, Rutvik, and Mayuri on the screen. The cousins told them they had borrowed someone's phone to make the call. They said that the abductors had dropped them 2 km from the airport and had booked their tickets back to India," the sources said.

The three landed in Mumbai around 2 am on October 1, and headed to Gujarat.

The cousins told police that in Addis Ababa, they were taken to an isolated residence, tied and blindfolded. Rutvik was beaten but "there was no mistreatment with the two women", Gehlot said. The three also told police they did not know Vansh, the youth whose tip-off allegedly helped police get on their trail.

According to sources, the family had decided to send the cousins via the 'dunki' route after the US government rejected Mamta's visa application. "Since they were sending Mamta, they thought the two younger cousins could also start new lives in the US, and decided to send all the three together," Gehlot said.

Police are now trying to trace Bhargav Patel, the alleged travel agent who is suspected to be part of Baba Khan's network.

Held in Ethiopia, cousins freed

and Iran, abducted, and held hostage for a week, sources in the Mehsana Police said.

When they were finally able to board Ethiopian Airlines Flight ET 640 to Mumbai from Addis Ababa on September 30 evening, all that the cousins had with them were their passports — everything else had allegedly been kept by their abductors. The cousins told the police that the abductors had, however, booked the tickets for the flight back and released them without extracting a ransom.

For this unexpected turn of events, the cousins have Inspector A M Gehlot to thank — and his long negotiations with the suspected leader of the kidnapers, a man who police sources said spoke in Hindi and identified himself as "Baba Khan". This, in essence, is the story of an alleged attempt at illegal entry into the US by two women and a man, their abduction and, ultimately, their extraordinary escape back to India, according to Mehsana Police and Inspector Gehlot.

Mehsana SP Himanshu Solanki and Collector S K Prajapati were not available for comment. Sources in the MEA told *The Indian Express* that three Indian nationals had been kidnapped in Ethiopia, and rescued by the local authorities there.

"They were rescued by Ethiopian authorities in Addis Ababa. Our Embassy in Addis Ababa was constantly in touch with the local authorities on this matter. Indian law enforcement authorities also contributed to the efforts. The three Indian nationals returned home on October 1," MEA sources said.

Mehsana district is known for its residents' desire to migrate to the United States, with locked homes across several villages in this region bearing testimony to this trend. Vadasma lies about halfway between Gandhinagar and Mehsana cities, and about 4.5 km from Langhnaj, which is on the main road.

On September 29, members of the cousins' family filed a missing persons' report at Langhnaj police station, saying they had not heard from the three since their last call on September 22. The cousins had allegedly told their relatives that they were in Canada. "They told their families that they would now contact them from the US. But then they went into communication," Inspector Gehlot said.

In fact, the cousins were allegedly already in the custody of Baba Khan at the time, and had been coerced to lie to their families and not disclose that they had been abducted and were in Ethiopia.

According to police sources, the three had left India on different flights from Jaipur and Delhi on September 21, and reached the Bole International Airport in Addis Ababa via the Middle East. Thereafter, investigations revealed, the "agent" who had booked their tickets abducted them, stole their belongings, and demanded a ransom of Rs 1 crore (USD 1,05,000) for their release.

The cousins' extended family and police were alerted about the abduction by a youth from Kadi town in Mehsana, identified as Vansh, police sources said. This youth had returned home after being kidnapped in Ethiopia, and after having allegedly paid a ransom of Rs 40 lakh, the sources said.

Officers from the Langhnaj police station immediately persuaded the families of the three cousins to file missing persons' complaints. By then, Baba Khan too had reached out to a "contact" in Dangarva village, whom police sources identified as Aditya Panchal.

This person directed the cousins' family to an agent from Vadodara, identified as Bhargav Patel. But police found that Patel had already gone underground. Information on the case was shared with the Local Intelligence Branch (LJB) of Mehsana

Ujjain's Simhashtha 2028 makeover

barely took us into confidence. It's better to demolish on your own than wait for the administration to come with a bulldozer."

Changing Ujjain

The most visible changes are on Ujjain's roads. The Ujjain-Indore six-laning project, estimated at Rs 1,692 crore, is under construction, while a separate Indore-Ujjain greenfield four-lane corridor, estimated at Rs 2,935 crore, is also being developed, SMA officials said.

A 98.73-km Ujjain-Jaora greenfield four-lane corridor, costing about Rs 5,017 crore, received its foundation stone in July. Planned with seven flyovers, three railway overbridges, eight major bridges, 22 medium bridges, 36 underpasses and 430 culverts, it is targeted for completion by December 2027. It is intended to provide an east-west connection towards Jaora and the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway while taking long-distance traffic away from the city, SMA officials said.

"More than 80 percent of road and connectivity works had reached the ground, with the road component around 70 percent complete. Around 15 bridges are under construction, and we expect five or six to be ready for inauguration by December," Aggarwal said.

More than 10 five-star hotels are either coming up or planned in Ujjain. Aggarwal said, alongside smaller hotels and guest houses.

Along the Shipra, the government is building approximately 29.2 km of new ghats and associated works, stretching from the Shani temple area towards the Nagda bypass. The Rs 778-crore project is intended to spread bathing and pilgrim movement over a longer stretch of the river, officials said.

At Gaughat, Akram Khan, a project supervisor for a private company, said they would meet

the deadline for the restored ghat by December. The restoration is taking place against an old British water works department office, built in the 1930s. Only the old English chimney remains as the Madhya Pradesh government races ahead with the modern ghat.

"We began work in May and employed over 100 workers per day, paying them at least Rs 800 per day to finish this work. The reason we can race through the project is that the government's fully focused on this. From making roads to providing us with electricity and water connections, they raced through all that to help our project," Akram said.

The second major riverfront project is the Rs 919.94-crore Kanh closed-duct diversion scheme, intended to prevent polluted water carried by the Kanh River from entering the Shipra. The scheme involves a 30.15-km diversion system, including an 18.15-km cut-and-cover section and a 12-km tunnel.

Inside Ujjain, the road programme is being executed through municipal packages, with roads widened around the old city and Mahakal area. One of the most contentious stretches is the road from Kharjuwall Masjid towards Ganesh Chowk, where widening work has now moved to the ground and brought the Shahi Masjid within the road alignment.

Protests — and race against time

Across Ujjain's old neighbourhoods, the transformation is not happening only behind construction-site barricades. It is happening at people's front doors. Hindu and Muslim families alike have been taking hammers and pickaxes to portions of homes, shops and religious structures marked for demolition under the new road alignments.

Lokendra Nigam, a cloth

merchant from Chattri Chowk, lamented the removal of a small portion of his shop. "We are doing it for the Simhashtha. Of course, we understand the devotees need space to move. But we should be adequately compensated. We feel the authorities don't listen to us."

At the Simhashtha division of the Madhya Pradesh Public Works Department, Executive Engineer Praful Jain studies the map of Ujjain on his computer, tracking projects for Simhashtha 2028.

The PWD's Simhashtha division has 20 works underway, Jain said, including an underpass, a bridge and road and connectivity projects. Among the most significant is the 629-metre Hari Phatak underpass, intended to provide an alternative route towards Mahakal Lok.

"More than 100 structures, on average, have been identified for impact across the underpass and elevated-corridor projects," Jain said.

The focus, he said, is on "resource and manpower planning, machinery planning and resolving issues on multiple fronts simultaneously, so that construction can begin at the appropriate time rather than waiting for one project to finish before another starts."

Jain said the department is increasingly relying on precast technology to compress timelines. Beams, columns and girders can be prepared in advance and brought to sites for assembly. The road network is also intended to create capacity beyond the festival. "Four-lane and six-lane interconnected roads are being developed at different locations," Jain said. "The Simhashtha works, in that sense, are being designed as infrastructure that can continue to serve the city after the festival. We want to develop international-level infrastructure across the world, like the Temple Mount in Israel or Mecca in Saudi Arabia."

PROTEST TO DEMAND CEC GYANESH KUMAR’S REMOVAL

Journalists allege sexual assault by cops; Crime Branch to probe



At the protest site near Jantar Mantar. ABHINAV SAHA

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 4

A DAY after three female journalists — who were covering protests demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, near Jantar Mantar — accused Delhi Police officers of sexual harassment, the Crime Branch has been tasked with investigating into the matter, officers said on Sunday.

Officers said statements of the women were recorded on Sunday. CCTV footage from the protest site will be examined, they added.

DCP Neha Yadav said the protesters were informed about the implementation of Section 163 of the BNSS in the New Delhi area, under which public gatherings of five or more people, demonstrations and other activities without prior written permission are prohibited. She said police personnel on Saturday acted only after the protesters, who were directed to leave the spot, refused to do so.

“Later in the day (Saturday), three women, who identified themselves as journalists, filed a complaint alleging manhandling by Delhi Police officials and staff during the detention. Their complaints were taken; they underwent medical examinations and all the complaints were sent to the Crime Branch. I request all of you... that if you have any video footage related to this, please share it with the Crime Branch,” she said.

A statement issued by the Delhi Police that was posted on X read: “On October 3, during the protest in the New Delhi area, while in a law-and-order situation, allegations of sexual harassment were made by three female journalists against police officers. New Delhi District has received their complaints, and the same have been transferred to the Crime Branch for a fair and impartial enquiry.”

Sources said the three fe-

male journalists run news portals and work as freelancers.

On Saturday, over 150 people, including AISA president Neha Bora, activist Yogendra Yadav, and senior advocate Prashant Bhushan, were detained for allegedly attempting to return to Jantar Mantar after being held a day earlier while demanding the resignation of CEC Kumar.

As per a complaint filed by one of the journalists, she had spotted Bora and other female protesters being detained. She alleged there was no female police officer present. She alleged that when she pointed this out an officer “pushed” and “shoved” her. According to the complaint, when she confronted him, the officer fled the scene.

Another journalist said she was covering the protest on Ashoka Road at 3 pm. “I was recording the detention of Yogendra Yadav and Prashant Bhushan when I felt someone touching my back,” she alleged in her complaint, adding that she turned to find an officer “standing very close” to her. According to the complaint, when she confronted him about the alleged “inappropriate touching,” he dismissed her claim.

On Saturday evening, several freelance journalists and representatives of news portals had gathered outside the Parliament Street police station, demanding action against the officers involved in the alleged incidents of sexual assault. Around midnight, Cockroach Janta Party leaders Saurav Das and Ratna Singh also reached the spot and demanded action against the officers.

“The FIR is a must,” Dass said. To press for their demands — the CEC’s resignation and the registration of an FIR over the alleged assault on female journalists — members of AISA and other activists had called for another protest on Sunday.

On Sunday, the two CJP leaders reached the spot again. They were later joined by SPJ leader Aishe Ghosh and CPI(M) leader Brinda Karat.

AISA chief among 120 detained on Day 3



A protester being detained, Sunday. GAJENDRA YADAV

Drishiti Jain
New Delhi, October 4

AROUND 120 protesters, including All India Students’ Association (AISA) president Neha Bora, Yogendra Yadav, were detained for several hours on Sunday as the protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar entered its third consecutive day.

The protest came a day after three women journalists accused Delhi Police officers of alleged sexual harassment while covering the stir near Jantar Mantar.

On Sunday, while some protested against CEC Kumar, others attempted to march towards Jantar Mantar to demand a probe into the journalists’ allegations of sexual assault.

Bora was detained while leading a march from Andhra Bhavan Canteen towards Jantar Mantar. The march saw participation from civil society activists such as Yadav, student protesters and political parties like the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) and AAP.

“This has just started and many organisations are now joining, we won’t stop. Even though the Jantar Mantar is closed, we’re on the streets... This is the power of common people. *Jab tak Gyanesh Kumar ki chhutti nahi hoti, hum chhutti nahi karnege* (Until Gyanesh Kumar takes a leave, we will not take a leave),” Yadav said.

Flags waved and slogans of ‘Gyanesh has to go’ pierced the air as the crowd split into groups and moved towards Ashoka Road.

Concerns over women’s

safety were also raised by the protesters. Ayushi (20), a DU student from Champawat, Uttarakhand, who attended the march, said, “Even in 2026, we have to fight for our basic rights. Crimes are committed against women, but they are ultimately the ones who suffer...”

On Sunday, the Lutyens’ Delhi was heavily fortified, with elaborate security arrangements in place. A large fleet of buses and riot action vehicles had been deployed on multiple lanes, and movement on several roads leading to Jantar Mantar and the Parliament Street police station was restricted. According to police, around half a dozen of officers sustained injuries.

The stretch between Ashoka Road and Parliament Street near Jantar Mantar were closed.

Around 4 pm, as the march progressed towards Jantar Mantar, barricades were put up. When a few protesters tried to cross them, the police began detaining them.

Bora was detained in a carby officers, but the vehicle remained stuck for over 20 minutes as protesters stood around it to prevent it from moving. Bora was taken to Narela police station, police said, adding that all of the protesters were later released.

Ashoka Road remained shut and traffic was halted until 6.30 pm. Amid the chaos, police kept detaining protesters.

As one police bus filled with detainees pulled away, the next quickly took its place.

Traffic resumed briefly on the roundabout, but police carried on detaining protesters as their numbers grew.

EXPRESSspecial

Govt nod for reserved forest status for 112 ha of Ridge, 2,073 ha still unprotected

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, October 4

TO BOLSTER formal legal protection granted to one of the Capital’s most ecologically sensitive zones, the Delhi government on Friday approved the Phase-I notification to declare 112.3 hectares of the Northern Ridge — an extension of the Aravalli range — as a reserved forest under Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act, 1927. However, the government excluded 8.61 hectares of demarcated land from the reserved forest status.

The move assumes significance as records show that over 2,073 hectares of encroached forest land in the Capital will remain unprotected even after this first set of notifications came into effect.

This is despite the government making many announcements in recent months to notify several parts of the Ridge as reserved forest. In May, the government declared 673.32 hectares of the Central Ridge as reserved forest. Then, in September, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced the approval of a draft notification to declare 400.541 hectares across 15 villages in the Southern Ridge as Reserved Forest.

Weeks later, on October 2, a similar Phase-I notification was approved for 112.328 hectares of the Northern Ridge.

The exclusions

Despite this push, land parcels that were earlier demarcated remain left out from the notifications. For instance, in the Northern Ridge, the Delhi Forest department’s approved Working Plan, which was formally sanctioned by the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF&CC), records the Northern Ridge area under Delhi Development Authority (DDA) jurisdiction at 138 hectares. Yet, only 121 hectares were brought to the table for demarcation, and barely 112.3 hectares would make it into the final ‘Phase-I’ Section 20 notification and be designated as a reserved forest.

Similarly, when the Delhi government issued its May 2026 gazette notification for the 991.9-hectare expanse of demarcated land at Central Ridge, it only approved 673.32 hectares under Section 20. Specifically, four pockets within a block were excluded from the

IN NUMBERS

Ridge	Area as per Sec 4 Notification	Area after demarcation	Area already notified under Section 20	Proposed area under Section 20	Remaining area
Southern	6,200	6,012.32	4,176.98	400.541	1,434.799
Central	864	991.9	673.32	—	318.58
South Central	626	640	—	330.015	309.985
Northern	87	121	—	112.328	8.672
Nanakpura	7	7.08	—	5.885	1.19
Total	7,784	7,772.3	4,850.3	848.769	2,073.226

SOURCE: JUNE 2026 DELHI RIDGE MANAGEMENT BOARD MEETING MINUTES. (FIGURES IN HECTARES)

notification: the President’s Bodyguard Ground (12.6 ha), an ISRO Earth Station (0.68 ha), the 14th-century Malcha Mahal monument (0.09 ha) and a water pump station (0.15 ha). The gazette recorded that these were excluded from Phase-I and “will be taken in subsequent phases of notification.”

Meanwhile, in an affidavit submitted last month to the National Green Tribunal (NGT) by the Deputy Conservator of Forests (P&M), defending its “phase-wise” approach, the Forest department admitted that final notifications under Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act, 1927 are being delayed by a combination of encroachments, pending litigation and incomplete revenue (Tatima) proceedings.

While the 400.541-hectare Phase-II (A) of the Southern Ridge currently awaits the Lieutenant Governor’s approval, vast tracts under Phase-II (Part B) remain entirely unnoticed. According to the NGT submission, these excluded land parcels are heavily compromised by village abadis, unauthorized colonies, jhuggi jhopri (JJ) clusters and religious structures. Furthermore, it stated that these Phase-II (B) areas are undergoing “joint ground re-verification” with the Revenue department to determine their legal status.

Further, the Delhi Ridge Management Board’s meeting minutes from June 29 this year also reveal that, out of 7772.3 demarcated hectares across all Ridge zones, 2073.226 hectares remain out of the proposed land for notification as it “consists of khasras under Government allotments, Min Khasras (parts of khasras) pending Tatima Pro-

ceedings), khasras under stay due to Court Cases, FSO Matters, private khasras etc are under process of settlement.”

Although Delhi’s Ridge areas were first notified under Section 4 of the Indian Forest Act on May 24, 1994, statutory protection is only finalised through Section 20 of the Indian Forest Act, 1927, which gives the area its enforceable reserved forest status after the claims and settlement process is completed.

The legal contention

Over the years, the pending matter of reserved forest status has been repeatedly flagged by courts. For instance, the SC-enabled Central Empowered Committee, in a May 2024 report, flagged that at least five per cent of Delhi’s Ridge area is under encroachment and four per cent has been diverted, while only 1.33 per cent had been notified under Section 20.

In November 2025, in a judgement, Chief Justice B R Gavai and Justice K Vinod Chandran had observed: “It cannot be said that the effect of non-notification of Ridge as Reserve Forest deprives the said area of any protection. We are, therefore, of the view that without proper statutory protection, it would not be possible to properly preserve the integrity of the Ridge. We find that the GNCTD has not acted with swiftness in protecting the Ridge...”

In May this year, the NGT directed the Delhi Forest department to submit an update regarding the Central Ridge notification status and urged that the Delhi Ridge Management Board expedite its clearing of large-scale encroachments across the Ridge.

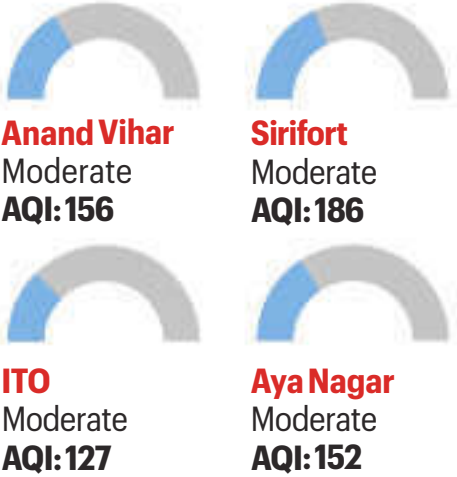
• Skywatch



Forecast:
October 5, 2026
Mainly clear sky. No rain.
MAX: 35-37
2.8°C above normal

MIN: 22-24
1.7°C below normal
• **Sunrise:** 6:16 AM (October 6)
• **Sunset:** 6:04 PM (October 5)
• **Moonrise:** 1:43 AM (October 6)
• **Moonset:** 2:02 PM (October 5)

• AQI Tracker



AQI at 187, Capital’s air quality marks 83-day low

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, October 4

DELHI’S AIR quality deteriorated to an AQI of 187 on Sunday, the highest in 83 days and in the ‘moderate’ category, while the maximum temperature was recorded at 36.4 degrees Celsius, 2.2 notches above normal.

The minimum temperature stood at 24.1 degrees Celsius, 1.8 notches above normal.

The air quality had last reached a higher level on July 13, when the city recorded an AQI of 246. As per the Sameer app, 16 monitoring stations in Delhi recorded air quality in the ‘poor’ category, with Mundka recording the highest AQI of 273, followed by Narela at 257. As many as 26 stations saw AQIs in the ‘moderate’ category, while Burari was the only station where the air quality was in the ‘satisfactory’ category.

Delhi recorded the highest maximum temperature of 37 degrees Celsius at Ayanagar, followed by 36.4 degrees at Safdarjung, 36.3 degrees at Lodi Road, 35.8 degrees at Ridge, and 34.6 degrees at Palam. Relative humidity was recorded at 51 per cent at 5.30 pm.

IIT scholar dies weeks after being found injured in rented room, FIR registered

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 4

DELHI POLICE has registered a case of abetment to suicide after an IIT-Delhi PhD scholar, who was allegedly found in an injured and unconscious state inside his rented room in South East Delhi on August 18, died during treatment on Saturday, an officer said on Sunday.

Police said that prima facie, the scholar, identified as Manish Anand who lived in Kishangarh’s Munirka village, attempted to die by suicide.

According to the police, the door of his room was locked from the inside. They said his neighbours had to break it

open. The police were subsequently informed and Anand was rushed to the AIIMS Trauma Centre, where he remained under treatment.

“Anand died on Saturday while undergoing treatment. An FIR was registered at Kishangarh police station under BNS Section 108 on Sunday,” a police officer said. The FIR was registered on directions from the Supreme Court-led National Task Force, formed last March to address mental health concerns and prevent suicides in higher educational institutions, police said. The task force was formed after students and family members of deceased students filed a peti-

tion in the Supreme Court seeking inquiries into incidents of suspicious deaths.

Police said that neither Anand’s family nor anyone else had, during the course of the initial inquiry, raised suspicion or levelled any allegation against anyone in connection with the incident.

Police said they also examined CCTV footage from cameras installed outside the rented accommodation Anand lived in. The footage did not indicate the presence of any suspicious person entering or leaving the premises around the time of the incident, they said.

“An investigation is underway,” the officer said.

Trees ‘damaged’ due to Metro project:DMRC, DDA told to reply

New Delhi: The Delhi High Court has sought response of the DDA and DMRC on a plea to direct the authorities to stop damaging trees on a land where construction of an underground Metro is underway in Karol Bagh.

The petition alleged that large-scale construction is going unabated in the area which is damaging the fully grown trees. Justice Jasmeed Singh issued notice to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) and Delhi government and asked them to file their replies to the petition. “You can’t turn a blind eye. Remove only what is necessary,” the judge orally told the authorities.

PTI

Shri Ramnath Goenka

April 18, 1904 - October 5, 1991

Be forthright, be frank, Be fearless, whatever the odds. Never hesitate to take a stand if you believe in it. Never hesitate to speak out boldly against the wrongs. And always, ensure that you illuminate the truth behind the events.

ONE MORNING last month, primary-class children in a Noida school revised true/false question-answers ahead of their half-yearly Environmental Studies (EVS) examination.

“Fries, cola, burgers make you healthy,” announced their teacher, walking past desks. “False!” a dozen-odd young voices responded in unison.

One little boy did not join the chorus. He sat hunched in his seat, eyes fixed on a smart TV next to a whiteboard. The screen was dark, the TV was off – it seemed he wished it wasn’t.

The teacher stopped close to him. She repeated, her voice slightly raised: “Fries, cola, burgers make you healthy!” The boy came back to the classroom. “False”, he murmured.

Until a few weeks ago, classroom screens such as these would be alive at nearly all times, running animated slides, popping questions to the class, and with “True” and “False” options floating inside bubbles.

On August 13, the Gautam Buddha Nagar district administration shut them down – schools in Noida and Greater Noida were directed to cap daily screen time at 30 minutes for primary-school children and 60 minutes for upper-primary kids.

For teachers, the order meant going back six years – to unlearn ways of teaching they first adopted in online classes during the Covid-19 pandemic, but which they never gave up entirely even after the virus receded.

For older students, it meant returning to classroom habits and practices they had all but forgotten. And for younger children, it meant saying hello to a set of entirely new experiences – listening, focusing, and using pencil and paper more than they had ever done before.

The administration said it had heard parents who felt aspects of students’ mental and physical health suffered in ‘smart’ classes. “Teaching”, the order noted, “is being conducted by directly displaying text-books or pre-loaded smart boards and screens are being used frequently for question-answer sessions and homework”. This, the administration felt, needed to stop.

Digital clampdown and its context

Government officials and school administrators agree there is a strong rationale for the order.

An official who was involved in drafting the order said an estimated 50% of children in Class 1 had begun to report problems with their vision because smartboards had

For teachers, the order meant going back six years – to unlearn ways of teaching they adopted in online classes during Covid-19. For older students, it meant returning to habits they had all but forgotten. For younger children, it meant saying hello to a set of entirely new experiences

replaced textbooks and teachers were using remotes to flip through pages.

“Smartboards were meant to only explain a few complex concepts. But schools have uploaded pre-text on them. Many parents have complained that their children have developed dryness in their eyes because they have been staring at smartboards all day,” the officer said.

Aditi Basu Roy, principal of Grads International School in Greater Noida, said that the dependence on digital tools was not a new phenomenon, but had increased greatly in recent years.

Her school, Basu Roy said, was among the first to transition to ‘smart’ teaching following the pandemic. Teaching through screens was a great help, but once in-person classes resumed, she noticed changes in her students, including a clear difficulty in paying attention.

“We found that smaller children had forgotten how to write... The small ‘r’ or the small ‘j’, for example,” she said. “Also, they were finding it difficult to focus and to concentrate.”

Basu Roy also found that teachers were continuing to depend on the digital tools they had adopted during the pandemic. “They were communicating through WhatsApp groups, homework was being given on phones, attendance, notes and daily tasks were being managed on software such as Learning Management System (LMS) and Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP),” she said.

Parents too had noticed the change, and had begun to complain.

Dr Gayathri, a student counsellor at Basu Roy’s school, recalled her experience with the parents of a Class 3 student. “They said their child’s behaviour had changed. He would throw things if they refused to give him a phone or switch on the TV. It had become difficult for them to get him to sit still even for half an hour,” she said. Teachers of the child told Dr Gayathri that he was unable to focus in class as well.

The mother of a Class 8 student of a Noida school who is a teacher herself, said the continued dependence on Covid-time digital tools had changed teaching and learning in ways that she found



GAJENDRA YADAV

SMART CLASSROOMS, CONTESTED IDEA

Noida and Greater Noida schools have been asked to switch off smart TVs in classrooms after the district administration capped daily screen time for students. **DRISHTI JAIN** and **TABSHIR SHAMS** report on how teachers and students are adapting.



(Top and above) A classroom at a Greater Noida school. AMIT MEHRA



Students study from a projector screen. GAJENDRA YADAV

uncomfortable.

“If a student can’t complete his homework, the teacher, instead of engaging with the child directly, simply clicks a picture of the work of a student who has completed the work, and puts it on the classroom screen. So my son is glued to the screen to keep up with the rest of the class,” she said.

“One day I asked him what he had learnt in school, and he said they had watched a science video on YouTube. He asks ChatGPT for answers to questions. He says their teacher does the same,” she said.

Her son’s school WhatsApp group is open “all the time”, the woman, who did not want her name published, said. “It started during Covid and it has increased a lot. *Unki saari baatein hi digital hain* (All their conversation is online).”

At one point, she was scared and frustrated enough to consider giving up her career just to focus on her son, the woman also said.

Devyani Vohra, a 46-year-old mother of two girls studying in Classes 9 and 12 in an International Baccalaureate (IB) school in the city, said there’s “a little bit of not wanting to leave the screen” in her younger daughter.

But despite being acutely conscious of the problems of too much screen time, Vohra and her husband had no choice.

“The children are doing all their homework online, everything is communicated online. In IB, especially in senior school, everything is online, even exams,” she said. “When you try to restrict their (children’s) screen time, they don’t like it. We can’t change anything in school, so we try to limit screen time at home.”

Vohra said she tries to ensure her children shut down their devices two hours before bedtime. “Sometimes it works, sometimes it doesn’t,” she added.

2022 study by AIIMS

‘LIFESTYLE MODIFICATION in school-going children before and after COVID-19 lockdown’, published in Indian Journal of Ophthalmology, followed 1,237 children in 9-14 age group from schools across Delhi.

IT FOUND that time spent on outdoor activity fell from 8.5 hours a week in pre-Covid years to 1.6 hours a week during lockdown.

SCREEN TIME climbed from 6.2 hours to 19.8 hours a week. Researchers flagged this shift as a predisposing factor for ocular ill-health, warning it could drive up rates of myopia in children

Basu Roy agreed that the ceiling on screen time imposed by the Gautam Buddha Nagar administration has forced a change in this situation.

The large screens in her school’s classrooms are now switched on only on Wednesdays and Fridays, but for no more than half an hour.

Whiteboards and pink, red, blue, and black markers have returned. The school’s portable projector is largely confined to her room. “The students are back to learning outside the screens,” she said.

The visible impact on children

The direct impact of heightened screen time on children, documented in several studies around the world, is visible in hospitals and doctors’ chambers across the National Capital Region.

The Indian Express met 42-year-old Senthil outside the OPD building at AIIMS with his daughter, a Class 2 student at a prominent South Delhi school. She was wearing a pair of glasses that looked enormous on her face.

“She gets hyperactive, she can’t focus on her studies. Her homework has started suffering, and her class performance is slipping. I have brought her to consult a doctor,” Senthil said.

Since joining the UKG class in 2024, the child’s homework and assignments have come through digital platforms, apps, and portals. The family bought her an iPad. Soon, the homework began sliding into YouTube — first Peppa Pig, then CoComelon, then an endless scroll of unboxing videos and cartoon shorts that no one in Senthil’s house could quite keep track of.

“In the last six months, her mood has deteriorated so much that we could no longer explain it away as a ‘phase,’” Senthil said.

Shalini, the mother of a 9-year-old Class 3 student at another South Delhi school, told *The Indian Express* that her daughter has been suffering from “anxiety” for almost a year now.

“She simply stopped talking much. Her friendships, once effortless, began to thin out. She started having mood swings which were sudden, disproportionate, and alarming. One evening, when she got really angry, my husband said we need to get her checked,” Shalini said.

The couple had gone to their child’s school counsellor earlier. This time, they decided it had to be AIIMS.

Dr Rajesh Sagar, child psychiatrist at AIIMS, Delhi, said cases like these, once seen only occasionally in his OPD, had become more common in recent years, “especially as children’s screen time has increased considerably”.

“We are seeing a rise in ADHD-like presentations and anxiety issues tied to this,” Dr Sagar said. The signs, he explained, can look deceptively ordinary at first — a child who speaks too loudly, forgets frequently, struggles to hold a peer group together, seems perpetually restless. But layered against excessive screen use, these signs become harder to gloss over.

A study by the National Council of CBSE Schools found that nearly 74% of students nationwide now spend more than two hours a day on screens for purely non-academic purposes, with around 21% crossing four hours daily.

A recent AIIMS study found that Indian children average roughly 2.2 hours of screen time a day — more than double what paediatric guidelines consider safe. In urban India, nearly half of all parents surveyed said their children spent more than three hours daily across social media, video-streaming platforms, and

online gaming.

According to the World Health Organization, screen time is not recommended at all for children under the age of 1, and no more than an hour is advised for children between the ages of 2 and 4.

The American Academy of Paediatrics recommends tighter time limits and, where screens are unavoidable, a conscious push toward high-quality, educational content. This is a far cry from the algorithm-driven autoplay that most children actually encounter.

Dr Sagar said increased screen times can reshape developing brains, undermining attention and concentration, and impacting core executive functions such as planning, focus, multitasking, working memory, cognitive flexibility, problem-solving, and self-regulation.

The prefrontal cortex, which governs these skills, is vulnerable, as a result of which reading ability declines, and creative, unstructured play of the kind that nurtures imagination and independent thought gradually disappears and is replaced by passive consumption.

Schools play a pivotal role in shaping healthier digital habits for children, as classrooms are often the first structured environment in which screen use is normalised, Dr Sagar said.

Beyond limiting device-based homework, schools can actively reintroduce handwriting practice, physical books, and project-based learning that requires collaboration and creativity away from screens, he said.

According to experts, scheduled outdoor play, art, and sports periods help restore balance, while teachers can model mindful digital use by encouraging students to pause autoplay features and engage with educational content deliberately. Schools can partner with parents through workshops and awareness sessions, ensuring that strategies to reduce screen dependence are consistent both at home and in the classroom, the experts said.

Dr Sagar emphasised that excessive screen use in children should not be seen simply as “addiction”; they often mask deeper issues such as anxiety, emotional distress, or social isolation. A significant number of children he sees carry underlying vulnerabilities such as anxiety disorders or ADHD, which screen exposure tends to worsen, the doctor said.

According to Dr Sagar, treatment, if needed, rarely begins with medication. “Psychological measures come first — we talk to them, use creative activities, customise the approach to the child, engage them, involve them,” he said. And parental counselling is often as important as anything done directly with the child, he said.

For Senthil’s daughter, who gets her homework on a digital device, the doctor had old-fashioned advice. “Print it out. Hand her a highlighter, coloured pens. Let her hold a physical page again.”

‘We have no wajood and aukaat outside Punjab & Congress’

AMID THE raging factionalism and infighting within the Punjab Congress, the party leadership has appointed three-time Jalandhar Cantonment MLA and former India hockey captain **Pargat Singh**, as its state unit president. In an interview with **Anju Agnihotri Chaba**, Singh, 62, speaks about a range of issues, including the state Congress's internal dynamics, his predecessor Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, and his plans for the Assembly polls due in February 2027. Excerpts:

The rift between Warring and former CM Charanjit Singh Channi has been out in the open. Now that you have taken over, how will you ensure that you do not appear inclined to one side, and what would be Warring's role now?

Differences of opinion must exist in democracies and political parties. In a democracy, there is no place for dictatorship. I have taken everything positive as our target is much bigger. There are no factions. The organisation is united and there is a single target (of winning the Assembly polls).

One thing is clear for us as party workers: we have no *wajood* (existence) and *aukaat* (standing) outside Punjab and without the Congress. When there is no existence without the party and state, where does the question of factionalism arise from? It is just a narrative that has been created. In the Congress, everyone has the right to speak their mind.

Can anyone in the BJP or AAP speak openly against their leadership? Recently, the AAP suspended its Maur MLA Sukhveer Singh Maiserkhana after he publicly raised the issue of teacher shortage. Is that democracy?

Everyone is important and has a role to play according to his or her strength. We have to



PARGAT SINGH
PUNJAB CONGRESS PRESIDENT

work together with Punjab as our focus and bring back the glory of “brand Punjab”.

You describe yourself as a “full-back” who intends to take everyone along. What does this mean?

I have always been a team player. As a hockey player, I played as a full-back. Like anyone else in the team, the full-back has a particular role.

We need to identify where every player fits and give them a role accordingly. At the end of the day, the goal is to ensure victory for the team. Keeping that aim in mind, I will take everyone along.

While the Congress has said it will fight the Assembly polls under a collective leadership, several leaders are seen as contenders to the CM's post. How do you plan to handle the situation?

The decision on the chief minister is the prerogative of the legislators. Winning the election matters before that. Candidates will be selected based on merit, surveys, winnability and character. Apart from these criteria, there must not be any other consideration.

Our priority is to build a strong organisation and win a majority of (the 117 seats). All senior leaders have agreed that

victory is paramount in the first place.

On what plank would the Congress contest the 2027 Assembly polls?

Our focus is to revive “brand Punjab”, which means every issue related to the state like the law-and-order situation, drugs, economy, Punjab's mounting debt, farming, women's safety come into the picture. Like they (BJP) ask the Congress for “hisaab-kitaab (accountability)” for our 70-year rule, we will ask them about the 12 years they were in power. Also, we will ask for accountability from the AAP.

We are not here to make illogical allegations. Our focus is to present the Congress's clear Punjab-centric narrative. The state has its own identity and concerns. We need to make Punjab the centre of our politics.

Punjab is likely to see a multi-cornered contest with the BJP, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD), Akali Dal (Waris Punjab De) and Congress taking on the AAP. How do you view the WPD (Waris Punjab De)?

The WPD is like any other political party in the state. I see it just like that. Everyone has a right to float a party and contest elections. I wish them good luck. For me, what matters is to make the Congress victorious.

Rajya Sabha elections: BJP fields Dinesh Arya from Uttarakhand, Koel Mallick from West Bengal

Jatin Anand & Lalmani Verma
New Delhi, Lucknow, Oct 4

THE BJP on Sunday announced the names of Dinesh Arya and former TMC leader Rukmini alias Koel Mallick as its candidates for the upcoming Rajya Sabha polls from Uttarakhand and West Bengal, respectively.

Biennial elections to 11 Rajya Sabha seats, 10 from Uttar Pradesh and one from Uttarakhand, are scheduled for October 16, alongside a bypoll in Bengal. Mallick will contest the Bengal bypoll to retain the seat after joining the BJP after the TMC's defeat in the Assembly polls.

Arya, an organisational leader with ties to the RSS and Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, currently serves as vice-chairperson of the state's Water Resources Manage-



Dinesh Arya, a Dalit leader; and former TMC leader Koel Mallick



ment and Regulatory Commission, a position equivalent to a state Cabinet minister.

The BJP's move to select Arya, a Dalit leader from Nainital district, for the Rajya Sabha polls came days after the Congress targeted the ruling BJP and the RSS over an alleged “*shuddhikaran havan* (purification ritual)” held at Ramliila Maidan in Uttarakhand's Haldwani after a rally by Congress president Mallikarjun

Kharge in August. Arya will be replacing BJP MP Naresh Bansal, an upper caste leader.

Haldwani falls in Nainital where Arya has served as BJP district president. After Haldwani's alleged purification incident escalated political tensions in the state, both the BJP and the Congress intensified their outreach to the Scheduled Caste groups in the state in the run-up to the Assembly polls

slated for February 2027.

However, Uttarakhand BJP media in-charge Manveer Singh Chauhan denied any connection between Arya's selection for the Rajya Sabha seat and the Haldwani incident. “The BJP has given its Rajya Sabha ticket to a dedicated and hardworking grassroots worker,” he said.

BJP's Uttarakhand unit chief Mahendra Bhatt, who is also a Rajya Sabha member, on Sunday asked the Congress to support Arya in the election and perform a “*prayaschit* of sins” that the grand old party allegedly committed by spreading “false propaganda of Dalit apmaan (insult to Dalits)” against the BJP.

Mallick—a prominent figure in Bengali cinema—was nominated to the Rajya Sabha by the TMC in April. She subsequently resigned and joined the BJP in

July as part of the split within the TMC ranks, during which 18 MPs rebelled against the party and merged with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. The NCPI has extended support to the BJP-led NDA government.

Party sources said the BJP is prioritising women candidates and experienced organisational workers as it seeks to expand its current tally of 116 seats in the 245-member House. In UP, 10 seats are falling vacant, eight of which are held by the BJP, while the Samajwadi Party and the Bahujan Samaj Party hold one each. The single seat falling vacant in Uttarakhand is held by BJP MP Naresh Bansal.

Currently, the BJP-led NDA holds 150 seats in the 245-member Rajya Sabha, while non-NDA parties account for just over 100 seats.

CM Adityanath renames Bhadohi after Sant Ravidas

Press Trust of India
Bhadohi, October 4

UTTAR PRADESH Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday announced that Bhadohi district has now been renamed Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi.

“Now our Bhadohi district will be called Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi,” Adityanath said after inaugurating as well as laying foundation stones for 112 projects, worth over Rs 1,340 crore, in Bhadohi. “Bhadohi district, currently known for its carpet industry, would in the future be known by the name of Satguru Ravidasji Maharaj, a medieval saint who united society through his spiritual devotion.”

“Under the leadership of PM Narendra Modi, over 80 crore people in India are receiving free ration. In this context, it is truly fitting that this district bears the name ‘Sant Ravidas Nagar Bhadohi,’” he said.

Bhadohi was a part of Varanasi district before it became the 65th district of the state on June 30, 1994.

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Dated: 03-10-2026

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Details of post may be downloaded from the University website- **www.nduat.org**. Applications on prescribed Proforma must reach to the office of the undersigned on or before 5.00 PM of 05 November, 2026 through Registered /Speed post only.

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Chinmay Vardhman's *No Map. No Mentor. No Problem* explores the uncertainties of finding direction without having all the answers. Drawing from personal experiences and practical observations, Vardhman keeps the narrative relatable and reflective. “Life’s dots connect in unexpected ways” captures the book’s central thought. The journey leaves readers considering how setbacks, choices and persistence shape the path ahead.

Abhishek Bhatt's *The World Needs More of* reads as a thoughtful collection of reflections on fear, stress, resilience and the choices people make in difficult moments. Drawing from personal experiences, Bhatt keeps the writing simple and relatable. Its emphasis on gratitude, hope and self-belief gives the book a reflective quality, encouraging readers to look at life's challenges differently.

Nitish Sharma's *The Last Hindu King of Delhi* offers a personal exploration of its central themes through an accessible and reflective narrative. The writing keeps the focus on human experiences, emotions and the situations that shape individual perspectives. Its relatable approach allows readers to connect with the story while leaving room for reflection on the ideas and experiences presented.

Sagarkumar Ramaniklal's *Vo Raate Jab Main Soya Nahi* Meenal presents its subject through a straightforward and engaging narrative, bringing together personal experiences, observations and reflections. The writing feels grounded rather than overly elaborate, allowing the central ideas to emerge naturally. It's strength lies in the way everyday experiences are connected with broader thoughts, giving readers something to consider beyond the narrative itself.

Dr. Sushrut Almast's *Bollywood Outsider* A Success Story reads like a candid account of pursuing filmmaking without industry connections. Drawing from his own journey, the author recounts the long road from the shelved Vyakul to the eventual release of Nirnayak The Decider. The narrative offers an insider's view of persistence, setbacks and the uncertainties of building a career outside established circles.

Durga Shakti: Indian Women from Down Under by **Dr. Shailja Chaturvedi and**

Sheba Nandkeolyar brings together the stories of Indian women who have made their mark across Australia. The personal narratives span medicine, business, politics, arts and community leadership. Written with warmth and purpose, the book explores identity, resilience and belonging while showing how these women have shaped lives across two cultures.

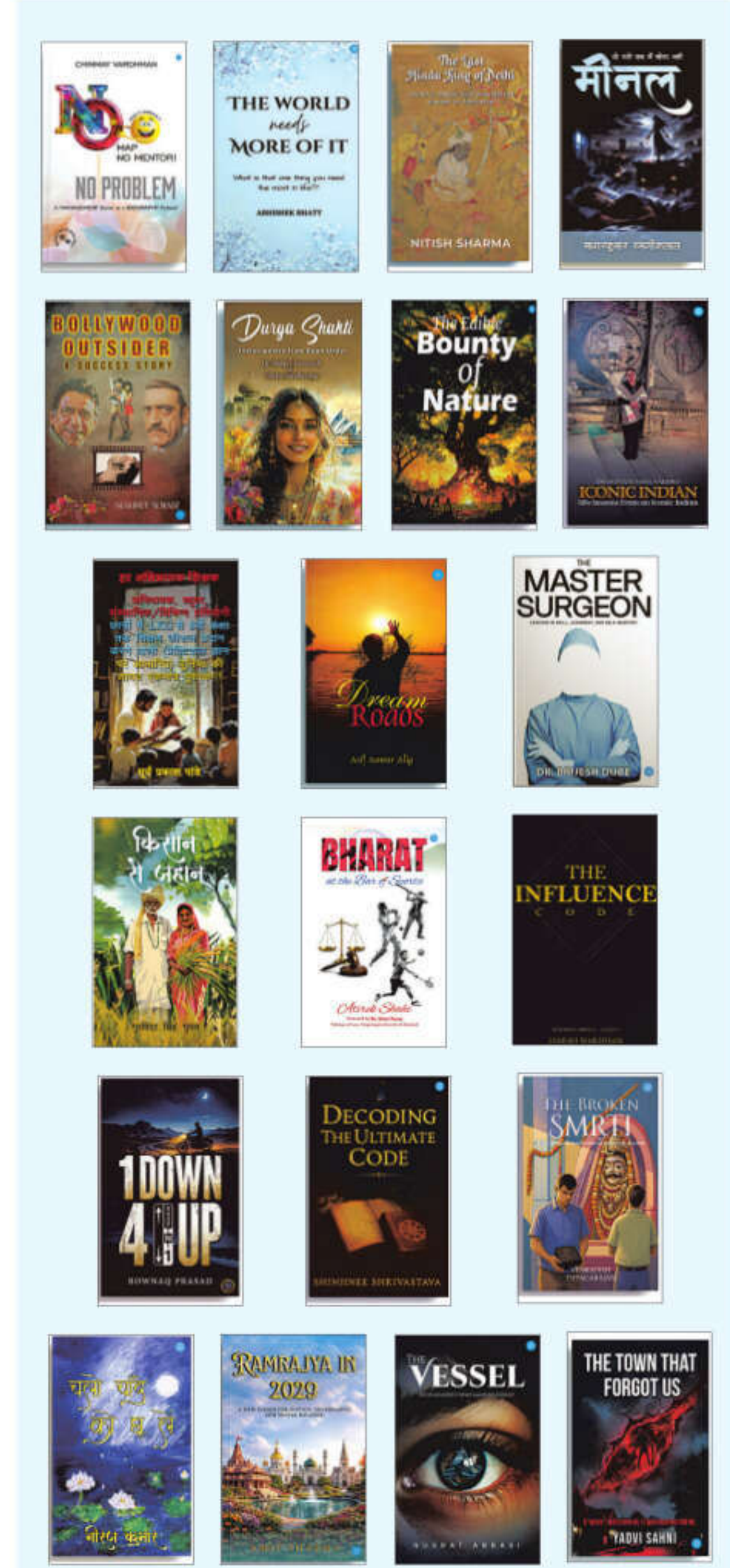
Er. T.K. Tagin's *The Edible Bounty of Nature* explores the traditional food knowledge of Arunachal Pradesh and its connection with the natural world. Drawing on village practices, field observations and contemporary research, the book documents indigenous fruits, leaves, roots and herbs. Its strength lies in preserving everyday ecological wisdom while reflecting on sustainable food traditions and biodiversity.

Dr. Sravani Saha Nakhro's *Iconic Indian* presents a collection of concise reflections on navigating everyday challenges and living with greater purpose. Drawing on years of observation and experience, the book offers 612 practical insights covering stress, relationships, personal growth and ambition. Its brief, accessible format makes the ideas easy to absorb, while the emphasis on mindful living gives the book a reflective quality.

Surya Prakash Pandey's *Har Abhikhawak Shikshak* focuses on the role parents and guardians can play in supporting children's education beyond the classroom. Drawing on the author's teaching experience, the book offers practical guidance for helping students from LKG to Class 8 with learning and homework. Its accessible approach makes the subject relevant to families seeking a more active role in basic education.

Asif Anwar Ali's *Dream Roads* reads like a personal account of growing up with limited means while holding on to ambitions that seemed distant. Drawing from his own journey, Ali reflects on education, family, mentorship and the choices that shaped his career. The narrative remains grounded and accessible, with resilience and purpose at its heart.

Dr. Brijesh Dube's *The Master Surgeon* looks beyond technical skill to examine what shapes excellence in surgical practice. Drawing on years of experience, Dube reflects on judgment, decision-making, resilience, mentorship and professional identity. The book combines practical frameworks with personal insights, offering a



grounded look at the pressures of surgery and the gradual journey from technical competence to mature professional mastery.

Gurvinder Singh Ghuman's *Kisaan se Jahaan* looks at the challenges confronting farmers in a changing agricultural economy. Drawing on his experience in farming and trade, Ghuman discusses market disparities, modern farming practices and the need for institutional reform. The book argues for greater cooperation, scientific approaches and constructive engagement with policymakers, while keeping farmers' livelihoods at the centre of its discussion.

Atirek Shahi's *Bharat at the Bar of Sports* examines the legal and regulatory structures shaping Indian sport. Drawing on his experience in law and sports, Shahi explores athlete rights, governance, gender equality, anti-doping, intellectual property and corruption. The book's comparative approach brings attention to existing gaps and the reforms needed for a more accountable sporting system.

Harsh Wardhan's *The Influence Code* draws on decades of corporate leadership to examine what helps professionals move forward in competitive workplaces. Blending experience with practical observations, Wardhan explores influence, trust, communication, timing and emotional intelligence. The book offers a grounded look at why hard work alone may not translate into recognition, and how leadership is shaped by impact.

Rownaq Prasad's *1Down4Up* follows Adil, a Mumbai writer rebuilding his life after a suicide attempt through a motorcycle journey across India. The road becomes a space for confronting guilt, addiction, failed relationships and identity. Moving from Mumbai to Goa, Rajasthan and the Himalayas, the novel combines introspection with gritty realism, making its central journey as emotional as it is physical.

Shininee Shrivastava's *Decoding The Ultimate Code* explores the intersection of Indian spiritual traditions, science and human consciousness. Drawing from the Vedas, Puranas and Upanishads, the book connects cosmic timelines, mythology, karma and evolution with questions about faith and inner growth. Its reflective approach encourages readers to reconsider familiar ideas and view belief as an evolving conversation rather than a fixed certainty.

Venkatesh Thyagarajan's *The Broken Smriti* unfolds as a fast-moving thriller set against the historic ghats of Varanasi. The story follows Dr. Hari and R&AW officer Arjun as they race to prevent a series of killings linked to the mysterious Seal of Manu. Blending suspense with Indian history, tradition and questions of identity, the novel keeps its central mystery moving through rituals, revelations and a tightly compressed timeline.

Niraj Kumar's *Chalo Chand Ko Chhu Len* is a reflective poetry collection that moves through loss, trauma, memory and healing. Drawing on nature, relationships and cultural traditions, the poems combine simple language with vivid imagery and occasional wit. References to migration and the Ramayana add another layer, while the collection's quiet, introspective tone leaves space for readers to pause and reflect.

Amit Sharma's *Ramrajya in 2029* reimagines the idea of Ram Rajya through the lens of modern governance. Drawing on his experience in banking and observations of social challenges, Sharma proposes a framework centred on welfare, growth, security and problem-solving. The book discusses reforms across finance, agriculture, education and administration, presenting its ideas as a practical vision for India's future.

Nusrat Abbasi, former advertising professional turned entrepreneur and novelist, debuts with *The Vessel*, first in the Navah Series. The thriller follows curator Ada Mirza drawn into an ancient mystery of lost civilisations, espionage and ancestral memory, spanning Cambodia, London and Mount Kailash, blending science fiction, identity, belief and destiny.

Yadvi Sahni's *The Town That Forgot Us* is a mystery built around forgotten memories, disappearances and secrets buried beneath an abandoned town. Through Scarlett's search for answers, the story moves between fear, grief and unsettling discoveries. Sahni's writing draws on emotional themes as much as suspense, giving the narrative a darker, introspective edge. The result is a haunting exploration of how the past can shape the present.

You can also buy the books from Amazon, Flipkart and the BlueRose Store

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Double Pride

THE HISTORIC gold medal-winning performance by Indian golfer Pranavi Urs at the Asian Games 2026 was a moment of double pride for Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia. Lauding the 23-year-old's achievement, the BJP leader shared on social media that he had golfed with her years ago when she was in school. He also expressed pride in the fact that the Madhavrao Scindia Foundation had played a role in her journey. Pranavi and fellow golfer Diksha Dagar have been associated with the Foundation's sporting initiatives, he said.

Ready to March

INDIA BLOC leaders have started preparations for the march on Tuesday from Parliament's Makar Dwar to the Nirvachan Sadan, the office of the Election Commission of India. The Opposition parties have conveyed to their MPs to mark their presence at Makar Dwar at 10 am, with sources saying that more than 150 members are likely to walk together demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. Even the elderly MPs have conveyed their willingness to join the march, and arrangements are being made to accommodate them. TMC MP Saugata Roy, 79, has already informed his party he will be present despite some of his colleagues suggesting that he could sit this one out.

No 'Fake' Faces

RECENTLY, THE JD(U) issued an unusual notification to TV channels, asking them to ensure that only its authorised spokespersons are invited to represent the party in debates. Along with the advisory came a list of 10 names — national spokesperson Rajiv Ranjan Prasad, Bihar chief spokesperson Neeraj Kumar and eight state spokespersons. The directive, it turns out, was prompted by some unwanted enthusiasm on the airwaves. The party learnt that several people only peripherally associated with the JD(U) were turning up on television debates and presenting themselves as its representatives — and, more worryingly, presenting their views as the party line. The notification makes the leadership's displeasure clear, describing this as “fake representation” that had hurt party workers.

Case against Udhayanidhi for involving minor in campaign

Dharapuram (TN): Tiruppur police have filed a case against DMK leader Udhayanidhi Stalin for allegedly involving a minor in a poll campaign, officials said on Sunday. The case was filed under the Representation of the People Act and Juvenile Justice Act. Police said the incident occurred during a campaign rally near Periyar statue in Dharapuram on Saturday. Udhayanidhi allegedly brought a minor boy onto a campaign van. The boy reportedly made disparaging remarks against Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay. Authorities said the involvement of a child in campaign activities is in direct violation of ECI guidelines, which prohibit children from participating in poll-related events. Udhayanidhi was in town seeking votes for DMK candidate S Suganya ahead of October 6 Dharapuram by-polls. PTI

MALAYSIAN ENGINEER HAD DIED BY SUICIDE

Keralam reopens probe against Gyanesh Kumar in '06 graft case

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram,
October 4

THE KERALAM Home Department has ordered the reopening of a Vigilance probe into alleged corruption in a road-related project from 2006 — when Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar served as the secretary of the state Public Works Department (PWD).

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala ordered a reinvestigation in the case, wherein a probe was launched against Kumar following the suicide of a Malaysian engineer — Lee See Been — who was then chief project manager of a major road work undertaken by PATI-BEL, an Indo-Malaysian venture, in the state.

Kumar's name had allegedly figured in two notes he purportedly left behind before dying by suicide in Kuala Lumpur. Kumar was sent to central deputation soon after.



Gyanesh Kumar was the then PWD secretary in Keralam

The road project — known as Kerala State Transport Project (KSTP) — was funded by the World Bank.

Chennithala told the media on Sunday that he received a complaint alleging the 2006 Vigilance probe had been compromised under external pressure. “I have directed the Vigilance to probe into the matter thoroughly. Gyanesh Kumar's name had figured in the suicide note that the Malaysian engineer addressed to his wife and

the company director.”

He said, “Vigilance had examined the matter in 2006. However, the probe did not go ahead, although Kumar was transferred out of the PWD. Now, I have got a complaint from Congress leader Malayankkeshu Venugopal regarding the issue. I had discussed the matter with Chief Minister V D Satheesan and decided to order a comprehensive probe in this regard.”

The Indian Express reached out to the CEC and the EC spokesperson through email but did not receive a response.

Senior CPI(M) leader M Vijayakumar, who had served as law minister in 2006 under the then V S Achuthanandan government, said Vigilance had begun probe into the matter, but no FIR was registered as the purported suicide notes were not made available in Keralam.

Senior IUML leader M K Muneer, who was the state PWD minister from 2001 to

2006, said, “It was being said that the engineer had left behind a suicide note. Nobody had seen it and what it contained. We do not know what he had written.”

Speaking to the media in Kozhikode, he said, “A comprehensive probe is required into the entire issue. The then government [led by the CPI(M)] did not take the probe forward. I welcome it.”

Chennithala said that the 2006 probe was “abandoned midway” but “Vigilance is capable of taking the probe ahead after two decades”. “When I get a complaint as the minister in charge of the Vigilance, I am duty-bound to order a probe,” he said.

PATI-BEL had undertaken the renovation of a few stretches of major roads in the state at a cost of Rs 216 crore. However, construction of the assigned roads got delayed due to alleged laxity in land acquisition from 2001 to 2006.



NIRMALA SITHARAMAN

INDIA'S AMBITION to become a Viksit Bharat requires an economy in which enterprises of every size can grow, wherever they begin. Over the past 12 years, our government has worked to create those conditions. GST's introduction in 2017 established a common national framework for indirect taxation. Next-Gen GST carries that effort forward, drawing on nine years of implementation and the experience of taxpayers and states.

Under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision, Next-Gen GST was conceived with two connected purposes: to reduce and rationalise rates, and to make compliance easier. The rate

changes took effect on September 22, 2025. The next phase of process reforms will come before the GST Council shortly. Together, these efforts seek to give households relief, businesses greater certainty and taxpayers a system in which they can fulfil their obligations without avoidable difficulty.

The states have been partners throughout. They brought their priorities and experience to the Council, helped shape the decisions and undertook their implementation. I thank them for that commitment. GST's progress rests on this willingness to pursue a shared national purpose while respecting each government's responsibilities.

The results provide grounds for confidence. Between October 2025 and July 2026, the value of reported taxable supplies grew by 25.8% over the corresponding period a year earlier. A lighter rate structure has been accompanied by a substantial expansion in reported economic activity. This is an encouraging foundation for a reform intended to support both enterprise and public finances.

That resilience is visible in the latest revenue figures. Gross GST collections reached Rs 12.46 lakh crore during April-September 2026, up 11.6% over the corresponding period last year. Every month from June through September recorded double-digit annual growth; together, collections for these four months accelerated by nearly 15%. Net collections, after refunds, also grew by 10.4% over the half-year. Taxpayer relief has coexisted with growth in the resources available for development.

The breadth of the expansion matters as much as its scale. Reported taxable supplies grew across all 11 sector groups and all major states. In an economy as diverse as India's, this spread is significant. Growth across sectors and regions creates opportunities for more businesses to participate in expanding markets, and for more communities to benefit from the demand, investment and employment that follow.



'For small & medium enterprises, national market is valuable when it opens a practical route beyond customers' immediate surroundings'

Reported sales to consumers (B2C) also rose by 26.7% in the post-reform comparison. When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: the purchasing power of households sustains demand for the

goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the producer.

For small and medium enterprises, a national market is valuable when it opens a practical route to customers beyond their immediate surroundings. Businesses in Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns should be able to build those relationships while continuing to invest and employ people locally. Enterprises expanding into these towns, in turn, can create opportunities for local suppliers and distributors. GST's common framework supports these connections; simpler administration must make them easier to sustain.

Participation in that framework is substantial. GST registrations across central and state jurisdictions stood at approximately 1.71 crore at the end of August, up nearly 15% from a year ago. For the April-July 2026 tax periods, GSTR-3B returns filed by their due dates were 12.6% higher than for the same periods last year. These improvements place a corresponding responsibility on the administration: regular compliance must be supported by reliable service, clear guidance and timely resolution of difficulties.

The functioning of input tax credit is another important part of this experience. The post-reform figures show that the share of tax liability discharged

When tax relief is reflected in prices, families have more room to meet other needs or save. Consumer relief and enterprise growth are closely connected: the purchasing power of households sustains demand for the goods and services that businesses provide. The benefits can extend from the household to the retailer, the supplier and the producer

through credits rose, while accumulated credit declined relative to taxable supplies. This is encouraging for businesses that depend on the effective use of eligible credit. For a smaller firm, working capital determines how readily it can purchase inputs, fulfil an order and take on the next one.

Refunds are equally relevant. Approximately Rs 1.80 lakh crore was refunded during April-September. Returning amounts due to businesses is part of a well-functioning tax system. Greater predictability in this process would help enterprises plan purchases and production with more confidence. The taxpayer's experience of receiving an eligible refund is an important measure of administrative performance.

The states also have a stronger revenue position. Their aggregate SGST receipts, including their share of IGST settlements, grew by about 16% during April-September this year. These resources support investment in infrastructure and public services, which improve the conditions in which families and enterprises pursue their aspirations.

The states also have a stronger revenue position. Their aggregate SGST receipts, including their share of IGST settlements, grew by about 16% during April-September this year. These resources support investment in infrastructure and public services, which improve the conditions in which families and enterprises pursue their aspirations. The gains can therefore reinforce one another: household relief supports demand, enterprise strengthens economic activity, and public revenues help sustain development.

The experience also points to the work ahead. A growing system must remain attentive to the costs it imposes on smaller participants. Their time and resources are limited. Each improvement in filing, credit or refunds should allow more of those resources to be devoted to running and expanding a business. The proposals before the Council on 7 October have been developed through sustained work with the states. They address registration, returns, refunds, disputes and improved flow of input tax credit, with the aim of reducing the time and cost of compliance. Taxpayer experience must continue to guide implementation.

GST's growing maturity gives us a stronger foundation for the next stage of reform. The same commitment to clarity, certainty and respect for the taxpayer guides our work on direct taxes. A dependable tax system enables enterprises to plan beyond their immediate obligations and invest in opportunities that take time to mature. Giving them that confidence, wherever they operate, helps build the economic strength of a Viksit Bharat as envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Nirmala Sitharaman is the Union Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs

SC to hear today two pleas against CEC's functioning, SIR

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 4

THE SUPREME Court will hear on Monday two petitions questioning the functioning of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, calling for an SIT probe against him and others and seeking to declare the nationwide SIR of electoral rolls illegal. A bench of CJI Surya Kant and Justices Joy-malya Bagchi and V Mohana will hear the matter.

The petitions were filed days after *The Indian Express* reported that ECs Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had recorded objections at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions and orders concerning the SIR of electoral rolls. The two commissioners said some of the decisions were issued without their knowledge or recommendation. The two ECs separately wrote to the country's top bureaucrat, Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan, flagging concerns over the integrity of voter software.

The ECI said the letters sent by Sandhu and Joshi to the Cabinet Secretary concerned an officer on deputation and were not related to policy or IT division matters. One of the petitions by Patna resident Rakesh Kumar Singh referred to the alleged differences between CEC Kumar and Sandhu and Joshi and the objections raised by them. “Article 324(1) of the Constitution does not vest the superintendence, direction and control of elections in an individual Chief Election Commissioner. It vests those powers in a Commission,” said the plea.

Singh pointed out that Article 324(2) provides that the ECI comprises the CEC and such number of other ECs as the President may determine from time to time. Article 324(3)

further stipulates that, when other ECs are appointed, the CEC shall serve as the Commission's chairperson. “The constitutional text therefore deliberately separates membership of the Commission from the chairmanship of the Commission, and separates the chairmanship of the Commission from the Commission's power.”

Singh said his grievance is not that Kumar exercised the CEC's powers improperly, “but that he has... held out as entitled to exercise a power, the collective decision-making authority of the Commission under Article 324 and Section 18 of the 2023 Act [Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act], to which Article 324(3) gives him no individual title, he being Chairman of the Commission and not the Commission itself.”

The petitioner urged the court to declare SIR, and all actions, decisions, directions, and measures taken under it, invalid from the very beginning and without legal authority. The petitioner argued that the SIR was undertaken without the necessary statutory or constitutional authority and without following the procedure required by law.

The other petition by Delhi-based lawyer Shailendra Mani Tripathi has sought a probe by an independent, high-powered judicial inquiry commission or an SIT headed by a retired judge of the top court. The petition refers to “unprecedented constitutional fractures and illegalities committed within the ECI under the CEC as exposed by documentary records published on September 23, 2026”. The plea said the alleged “act of... CEC Kumar... falls squarely outside the ambit of official immunity and constitutes distinct, personal criminal liability”.



Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray, MNS chief Raj Thackeray and others stage a protest in Mumbai's CSMT on Sunday. AKASH PATIL

Thackerays demand CEC's removal; Raj says restore ballot paper

Express News Service
Mumbai, October 4

SHIV SENA (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief Raj Thackeray led a joint protest march in Mumbai on Sunday against CEC Gyanesh Kumar, demanding his resignation and the scrapping of the SIR of voter lists in Maharashtra.

At the concluding meeting of the Virat Garjana Morcha, Raj also demanded that EVMs be replaced with ballot papers in polls. The march began from Metro Cinema and proceeded towards the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation headquarters. State leaders of the Congress and NCP (SP) also participated. Organisers had asked participants to carry only the Tricolour and not party flags. As per police's estimate, nearly 6,000 people attended the protest march from Metro Cinema Chowk to the BMC headquarters building in front of CSMT.

Police said that since the organisers had not obtained permission for the protest march, they were in the process of registering an FIR for unlawful assembly, among other BNS sections.

Referring to a letter by former Union Home Secretary

R K Singh, Raj said, “According to former Union Home Secretary R K Singh, the special revision can be done in exceptional circumstances by recording the reasons in writing and for a specific constituency. It is illegal to conduct SIR across India. There is no provision in the law in this regard.”

Thackeray said such circumstances could include a major natural disaster, migration, large-scale duplication of names or complaints regarding the voter list. Calling for an end to voting through EVMs, he said, “The voting machines in this country should be shut down and voters should vote on ballot papers. If these two things happen, it will be clear who is right and who is wrong. It doesn't matter who comes to power tomorrow.”

Uddhav, meanwhile, questioned the centralisation of decisions relating to voter verification. He questioned Kumar's appointment as the CEC, alleging bias in the selection process. Targeting the government, Uddhav said, “Gyanesh Kumar is their weapon. Using him, they are taking away the right to vote also. You can control institutions, but the streets belong to us. The SIR must be scrapped...”

● A VIDEO OF THIS BLO REJECTING THE FORM 7s WENT VIRAL AFTER TELANGANA PRADESH CONGRESS COMMITTEE RAISED THE MATTER LAST WEEK

'Was doing my duty': BLO who stopped bulk submission of Form 7

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, October 4

HIS VOICE may have gained unlikely attention, with Telangana Congress sharing a now-viral video of him rejecting a bunch of Form 7 allegedly filed by a BJP booth level agent (BLA), but this BLO from Hyderabad chooses not to make much of it, simply saying, “I was just doing my duty.”

He was posted at Booth 173 in Goshamahal constituency of Telangana Capital when the said Form 7s of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) were filed by a BLA in September-end. “It's not possible to accept these Form 7s,” he is heard saying.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, the BLO, who works as a Junior Assistant at Osmania Medical College, said, “The forms had printed EPIC

numbers. There were no names on them. I had no instructions to receive such forms from my superior officers. Hence, I decided not to accept these.”

The video of this BLO rejecting the Form 7 went viral three days later, when Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) on Saturday released the video of pre-printed Form 7 of SIR surfacing in Hyderabad.

“I don't know how that video went viral. I was only stating my point of view,” the BLO said. When asked whether he was scared to reject the forms, he said, “No, I was not. I was doing my duty.”

He, however, did not want to be identified as he did not want “publicity for an act which was done as part of the BLO duty”.

TPCC released the video two days after they complained to the Chief Electoral Officer



Form 7s are used by electors if they want to delete their own name or if to object to any other elector in their constituency. FILE

(CEO) “about apprehensions of a larger conspiracy to bulk delete voters” as part of the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls 2026.

The forms, which the TPCC had accessed, had no names. “They were in the last stages of

being filed by the BJP BLA,” a Congress source alleged.

In a press conference on Sunday, BJP state president N Ramchander Rao said his party's BLAs have not submitted bulk Form 7. “The Con-

gress is spreading malicious propaganda against constitutional institutions like the Election Commission,” he added.

Form 7 are used by electors if they want to delete their own name or if to object to any other elector in their constituency.

The first instance of bulk Form 7 in Hyderabad surfaced on October 1, 2026, in Musheerabad constituency. Pre-printed applications were allegedly filed by a BLA of the BJP, seeking deletion of a total 31 electors, who included a Congress BLA and his family members. In another case, a pre-printed Form 7 surfaced in Bahadurpura constituency. This, too, was flagged by the TPCC.

“In the Goshamahal case, the BLO refused to accept the bulk pre-printed forms,” a TPCC leader told *The Indian Express*.

When asked about the

complaints, Chief Electoral Officer Sudarshan Reddy's office told *The Indian Express* that an inquiry into the matter is on. “If some are targeting people by filing bulk Form 7s, we will take strict action,” the CEO's office said.

According to TPCC, as per the original plan of BJP BLAs, the forms were to be submitted only after October 1, to inundate the election authorities who are already under the weight of lakhs of pending hearings from the notice phase. The period for filing claims and objections comes to an end on October 7.

A TPCC source said, “If the CEO does not take action, we will approach the police. This is a matter of protecting people's right to vote”.

Telangana BJP's chief spokesperson NV Subhash told *The Indian Express* that bulk

Form 7s are being submitted against “Rohingyas who are not citizens of the country”. He said, “Political parties, including the AIMIM, the Congress and the BRS are supporting enrolment of Rohingyas. There is nothing wrong in filing Form 7s to deny them voting rights.”

He said AIMIM's Asaduddin Owaisi should personally ensure that the Rohingyas don't get voting rights in India. “If he is a true Indian, he should see to it,” Subhash said.

Earlier in the day, Owaisi, the MP from Hyderabad, said, “If false Form 7s are being filed, we appeal to the Election Commission to take action against those responsible for it. If this drama does not stop, remember: protests bigger than those at Delhi's Jantar Mantar will take place on the roads and streets of Hyderabad...”

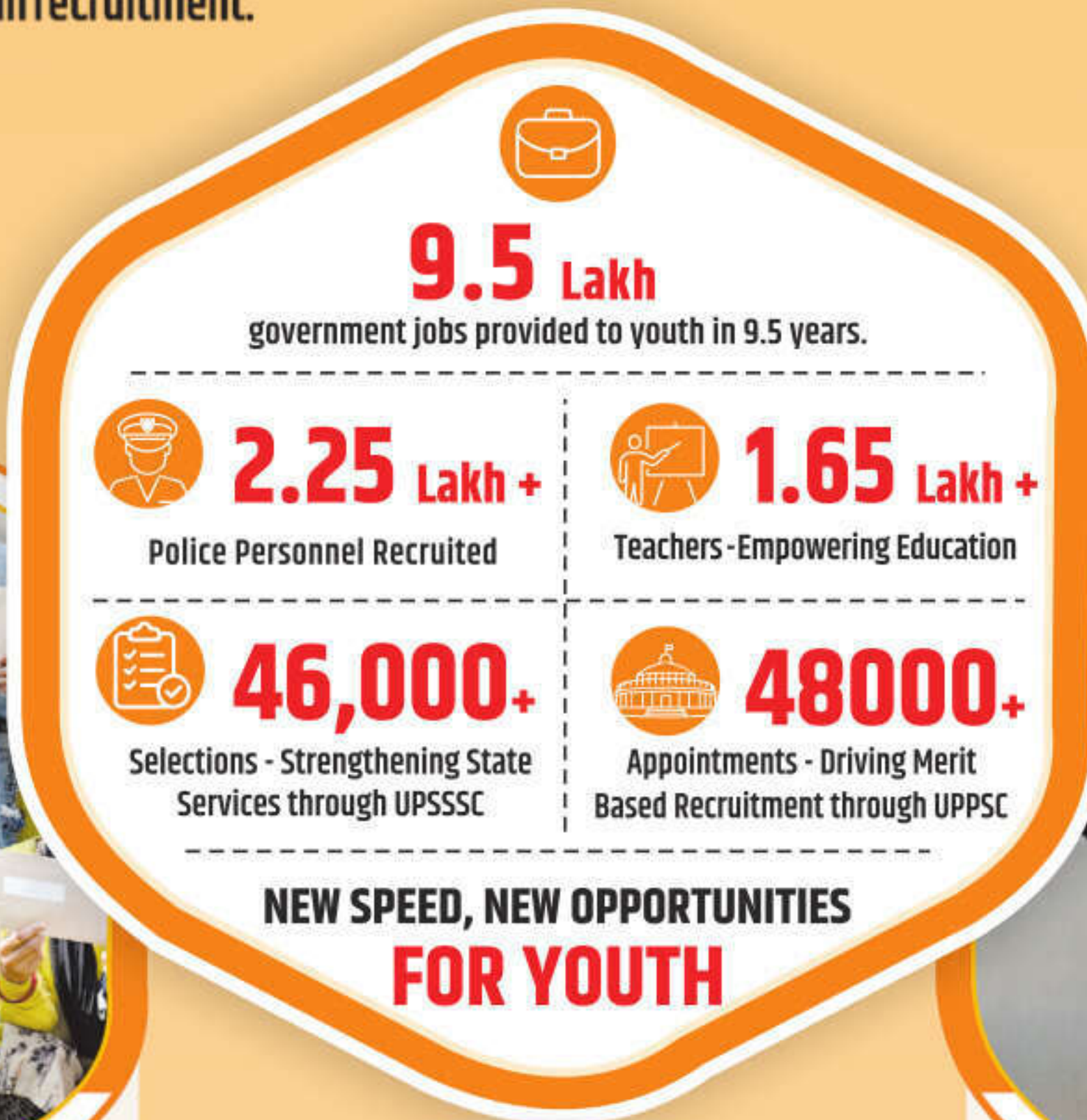


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2.25 Lakh+ Recruits: UP Police Gets Stronger

- 2.25 lakh+ police personnel recruited in Uttar Pradesh.
- Recruiting Constables, Sub-Inspectors & Women Police Personnel
- Strengthening the Police Force with Enhanced Training Capacity
- Expanding Manpower for a Stronger & More Responsive Policing System

1.65 Lakh+ Teachers: Strengthening Government Education

- 1.65 lakh+ teachers and assistant teachers appointed.
- Recruitment strengthened human resources across government schools.
- Women and candidates from diverse social backgrounds received greater opportunities.
- Expansion of the education workforce supports improved delivery of public education.

46,000+ Selections Through Subordinate Services

- 46,000+ selections through the Uttar Pradesh Subordinate Services Selection Commission.
- Merit-Based Recruitment Expanding Opportunities

Health Sector: Thousands of New Appointments



- Recruitment undertaken across critical healthcare positions.
- Appointments include Staff Nurses, ANMs, Lab Technicians, Pharmacists, Nursing Officers, Dental Hygienists & Junior Analysts.
- Expansion of medical colleges accompanied by large-scale recruitment in Medical Education.
- Strengthening the healthcare workforce across the state.

48,000+ Appointments Through UPPSC

- Over 48,000 Appointments through UPPSC
- Recruitment across PCS, Medical Officers, Assistant Engineers, Lecturers and other administrative & technical services.
- Strengthening Talent for Better Governance & Public Services

2 killed, 3 injured in mob attack in Bengal over cattle theft suspicion

Sweety Kumari
Kolkata, October 4

TWO MEN were lynched and three others sustained injuries after a mob attacked a group on suspicion of cattle theft in the Matigara and Bagdogra areas near Siliguri in West Bengal, police said, adding no arrest has been made so far.

According to police, the incident took place around 2.30am on Saturday when the mob intercepted a van, alleging the group was stealing cattle. The driver, identified as 45-year-old Md Shahid Akhtar, a resident of Chopra in West Bengal, was dragged out and beaten to death at the spot, police said.

The second victim, 28-year-old Sajjad Mohammad from Haryana, later succumbed to multiple injuries while undergoing treatment at the North Bengal Medical College and Hospital, police said, adding the van was also set ablaze.

While police rescued three injured persons and rushed them to the hospital, one individual managed to escape the assault and sought shelter in

side a nearby police station.

“A case has been registered under section 103 (2) (murder committed by a group of five or more people based on identity-driven hate or discrimination), section 117 (voluntarily causing grievous hurt), section 324 (wrongful mischief), and section 326 (mischief by fire or explosive substance) of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). We are trying to trace the accused. So far no one has been arrested,” Commissioner of Police, Siliguri, Syed Waquar Raza, said.

The case has been filed on the basis of a complaint filed by Akhtar’s wife, police said.

According to police, seven other people from the group have been arrested in another case.

“There was a group of cattle smugglers from Haryana. After the attack, few of them entered an area of an army camp office nearby. Based on a complaint from army personnel, we have arrested seven people. They were produced in court and sent to four-day police custody. The vehicle that was torched had cattle,” an official from Bagdogra police station said.

IN CONVERSATION WITH NETANYAHU

‘Had one last fight left in me’: Pilot recounts cockpit horror

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, October 4

INDIAN PILOT Smit Machchhar, who survived a violent assault by his Omani co-pilot, identified as Hamam al-Hammami, inside a flydubai cockpit and averted a catastrophic crash on September 30, revealed harrowing details of the incident during a phone conversation with Israel’s Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Saturday night.

Recovering at a hospital in Abu Dhabi, Machchhar recounted how he fought through blurred vision and severe disorientation to unlock the cockpit door from the inside, allowing crew members to intervene.

Co-pilot asks to pray

“It was just a normal flight, and the co-pilot wanted to pray, which a lot of locals do pray, and which is not out of the ordinary. But while he was praying, out of respect, I was just looking at the front and not at the back.”

“And suddenly, after I think I would say about 4-5 minutes, there was a big blow to the back of my head. My first thought



Captain Smit Machchhar is recovering at a hospital in Abu Dhabi. ANI

was that there was catastrophic damage to the aircraft, and something is not right. But then after that, the blows kept coming one after the other, and that’s when I realised that it’s not the aircraft; it’s the other guy who was in the cockpit with me,” Machchhar said.

“I did try to stop him, but because of his initial blows, my vision was almost like nothing, and I was completely blurred out, and at that point, the next thought I had was that the aircraft was sharply going down. So my memory is

still in bits and pieces right now, but this is what I remember from that time.”

Machchhar tries to open the door

“And I did try to; I did try and manage to open the door once, but I think he shut it back. And at this point, I remember I was lying down on the cockpit floor, and I felt the aircraft and the whooshing sound and people screaming. And as I was telling the ambassador here that I had that one last fight left in me. That, you know, call it personal or call it for people. But let’s say I did it. That if I don’t do it, I’m gonna die,” he said.

“And that’s when I pushed against everything. I gave everything that I had, and just went for the door and opened the door. And thankfully, people were waiting to pounce back and take over the control, and the rest is what you know, sir,” he told Netanyahu.

“The door from the inside has a twist-to-open mechanism, and from the outside it cannot. It can only be opened with a code. So my colleagues from outside were trying to... but the guy was not allowing...”

“And the only way to open the door was to reach the knob, and like any other knob, just to twist it open, and it opens on its own. So there is no pin, but yes, the door. It was a short, quick twist, but the point was to reach that place, and once I had my hand on the knob, I guess I twisted it, and I opened it.”

Flight FZ1073 left Dubai for Tel Aviv on September 30 with 174 people on board, most of them Israelis. Midway through the flight, the Boeing 737 Max dropped sharply after co-pilot Hamam al-Hammami attacked the captain.

Passengers and other crew took back control of the cockpit, and the plane landed in Tabuk, in northwest Saudi Arabia. Authorities in the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Israel are now investigating.

Netanyahu has invited Machchhar and Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Israel for the country’s Independence Day, and called the pilot a “hero of Israel, India and the world”.

He also said the co-pilot went through “Islamist radical indoctrination”. The UAE is looking into the facts, the motive and whether the attack was planned or linked to terrorism.

• BRIEFLY



Mangled remains of the ambulance. PTI

UTTAR PRADESH

Ambulance carrying Army officer's remains ‘hits truck’, 3 of his kin die

THREE OF an Army officer’s family members died after the ambulance carrying his body met with an accident on the Purvanchal Expressway in Sultanpur district early on Sunday. The ambulance driver also died in the accident. The police suspect that the ambulance hit a parked truck on the expressway. They added that the ambulance was carrying the body of Subedar Major Satyawan Singh, 50, of Rudrapur in Deoria who was posted in Meerut. The deceased are Singh’s brother Ram Samujh, son Gaurav Singh, nephew Rajan Singh, and the ambulance driver, Jaspal. Other family members of the officer were travelling in a separate vehicle that was following the ambulance. ENS

Man killed over paying Rs 20 for mending slippers

A DISPUTE over paying Rs 20 for repairing slippers turned fatal after a 76-year-old man was attacked with an iron cobbler’s tool in Butibori area in Nagpur, police said on Sunday. The accused, Dilip Pawar (35), was arrested on the same day, Saturday. The dead is Jaysingh Rajaram Bhaiswar. Police said, Pawar had gone to a cobbler’s shop to get his slippers repaired, but refused to pay the charge of Rs 20. Pawar allegedly abused Bhaiswar and struck his head with an iron anvil used for cobbling work, police said. Bhaiswar died undergoing treatment. PTI

2 die in hospital, families claim ‘negligence’

TWO WOMEN died at Jamui Sadar Hospital in Bihar on Sunday, following which their family members staged a protest on the premises with the bodies, alleging negligence on the part of the establishment’s authorities, officials said. One of the women had undergone a caesarean section on Saturday night, and another was due for delivery on Sunday. Jamui Sadar Sub-divisional Police Officer (SDPO) Deepti Monali said the deaths occurred in a gap of a few hours. Kin of the women protested by placing the dead bodies at the hospital gates. PTI

Political intent necessary: Bangladesh on Hasina extradition

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, October 4

BANGLADESH ON Sunday said it expected India to expedite the extradition of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, saying that besides the legal process, “political intent” was also necessary for her return.

The remarks came a day after Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi said India could not give a timeframe for Hasina’s return as Dhaka’s extradition request was being examined through a legal process involving the courts.

“There is certainly a legal process involved, but political intent is also necessary,” State Minister for Foreign Affairs Shama Obaed Islam told a media briefing at her office.

She expressed hope that India would take steps to expedite the extradition process.

Responding to whether former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina could be repatriated under the active extradition treaty between New Delhi and Dhaka, the state minister said “certainly”. “The accused (Hasina) can be brought back under the treaty, and that process is being taken forward,” she said, though some legal experts have questioned whether the treaty applies in her case.

“Nobody can give you a timeframe (over Hasina’s return).” Trivedi had said on Saturday. Hasina, 79, has been living in India since fleeing Dhaka in 2024, after a student-led agitation toppled her government.

Trees in Dindori forests saw a major infestation of the sal heartwood borer this year

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, October 4

AT FIRST light, the most noticeable sound in the sal forests off the Dindori-Mandla road in Madhya Pradesh these days is of feet on dry leaves.

Villagers fan out toward trees that were felled and stripped of bark three days earlier, its sap drawn out. And there it lies, exposed on the trunks, their culprit — the sal heartwood borer, a longhorn beetle that has been a bane for these trees for over a century.

The villagers pick them by hand, drop them into bags or jars, and later turn them into necklaces — the beetle’s long feelers aiding the braiding process. The necklaces are not for any ornamental reason but to make it convenient for the villagers to carry them to eight collection centres in the district.

Each beetle is worth Rs 2. So far, this season, 19,25,118 of them have been collected, generating a bill of Rs 38.5 lakh for the state’s forest department.

Hoplocerambyx spinicornis, commonly known as the sal heartwood borer, is a destruc-



Villagers collect the beetles and turn them into necklaces. These are sold to collection centres at Rs. 2/beetle. The bill stands at Rs 38.5 lakh so far. EXPRESS

tive pest first recorded as a threat to the trees in 1897. Now, it is at the centre of one of the largest sal-tree felling operations in Dindori in recent years following a major infestation. A couple of weeks ago, Centre approved the felling of 1.47 lakh infected sal trees.

Sal, or Shorea robusta, is among the dominant tree species of central India’s dry deciduous forests, forming the backbone of tracts that run across Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Jharkhand and parts of Uttar Pradesh. Its can-

opy makes up much of the habitat inside tiger reserves, such as Kanha and Pench.

Sal timber has historically been prized for construction and for railway sleepers because of its strength and resistance to decay. The tree continues to support a range of non-timber produce on which forest-dwelling and tribal communities depend — sal seed, pressed for oil and used in cooking and in the soap and confectionery industries; sal leaves, stitched into plates and bowls sold in local markets; and resin tapped from the trunk, used as *dhoop* in religious offerings.

In much of central India, sal groves also carry cultural and religious significance for tribal communities. It is this combination of ecological weight and economic dependence that gives a sal-borer epidemic consequences beyond the forest department’s felling ledger.

Over 21 epidemics recorded so far

The insect does not attack indiscriminately; it tends to target weaker, less vigorous trees, though it becomes capable of killing sal of varying ages once a tree’s girth exceeds 20 cm. Mortality is largely concentrated among trees between 91 and 150 cm in girth, and the highest losses recorded is in the 121-150 cm range — precisely the mature, canopy-forming trees that anchor a sal forest’s structure and constitute the greatest share of its timber and

non-timber yield.

More than 21 sal-borer epidemics have been documented across India to date. MP and neighbouring Chhattisgarh experienced a major outbreak between 1997 and 2000, during which roughly 3 lakh hectares of sal forest were affected out of the region’s 16.84 lakh hectare cover.

Mandla — the district adjoining Dindori, and part of the same forest landscape now under felling orders — was the worst-hit at the time, with around 8 lakh trees damaged.

Dindori Divisional Forest Officer Ashok Solanki said, “We are dealing with a substantial number of affected trees.”

Working in tandem

The trapping and the felling are two distinct interventions running in tandem. The insect-collection campaign, carried out through what the department calls trap trees, is organised to pull adult borers out of the population before they can lay eggs and multiply. The felling of already-infected standing trees is a separate, larger sanitation operation, aimed at removing wood that is beyond saving and could otherwise seed further infestation.

Dindori SDO Forest Surendra Jatav said, “When the rains start, we start the trapping operation.” Selected trees are felled and debarked to draw the insect out. “It comes and feeds on the sap and becomes exposed at night,” Jatav said.

The trees are left for three days before villagers return to collect the insects that have surfaced. “When they come out after sunrise, around 5-6 in the morning, we go and catch them by hand and put them in a bag,” he said. The felling of infected standing trees, Jatav said, is being carried out with axes, through an agency, with villagers doing the actual cutting. The operation is expected to take around four months. The felled wood goes to the timber market, said Jatav.

The scale of the current outbreak, according to Jatav, is unusual but not without precedent. “It is an epidemic-type cycle. It repeats every 30 years,” he said, describing how infestation levels can swing sharply from one year to the next. “Last year it was very low,” he said.

Dr Uday Homkar, Senior Research Officer and in-charge of the Conservation Division at the State Forest Research Institute (SFRI), Jabalpur, has tracked sal borer outbreaks in MP for over a decade. He pointed to weather as a factor behind this year’s spike. He said that unusually high rain in the Dindori-Mandla region last year had helped create conditions favourable to the insect.

According to Homkar, the first and most decisive step in controlling an outbreak is catching it early. “As soon as the infection develops, it has to be detected,” he said. “We practice this detection.”

CBI arrests DGCA official, firm director in bribery case

Express News Service
New Delhi, October 4

THE CBI has arrested Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) Deputy Director (Airworthiness) Sushil Kumar Garg, posted in Chennai, and Director of Ekvi Air Training Organisation Pvt Ltd Sushil Kumar Garg in connection with an alleged bribery case.

The agency has alleged that Garg demanded and accepted a bribe of Rs 2.5 lakh for extending undue favours in the airworthiness certification of the aircraft operated by the private firm.

According to sources, the payment was linked to regulatory clearances concerning the airworthiness of aircraft operated by Ekvi Air Training Organisation Pvt. Ltd.

Airworthiness certification is a key regulatory process intended to ensure that aircraft

meet prescribed safety and operational standards.

Besides Garg and Bhane, the CBI has also named the company and other unknown persons in the case, officials said.

Further investigation is underway to ascertain the role of other individuals in the case and to examine whether the purported exchange of money was part of wider arrangement involving aviation-related approvals, the agency said.

The CBI had received inputs about the alleged bribe demand, following which an FIR was registered and a raid was conducted, sources said. According to officials, Garg accepted the Rs 2.5 lakh bribe, after which he and Bhane were arrested. The agency will move court seeking transit remand of the accused officer to bring him to the national capital for questioning, they said.

• AGENCY’S FOCUS PREDATES CHANDRA’S CASE; OVER THE PAST 2 YRS, ED HAS INVESTIGATED AROUND A DOZEN CASES IN WHICH IT HAS ALLEGED DIFFERENT FORMS OF MANIPULATION

Subhash Chandra’s IBC deal: ED probe focuses on big haircuts, proxy bidders

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, October 4

THE Rs 6.5-CRORE settlement by Zee founder Subhash Chandra against admitted claims of over Rs 22,000 crore by banks has once again put the spotlight on the sharp haircuts creditors can suffer under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

An emerging concern for investigators is whether, in some cases, the insolvency process is being manipulated to determine who gets to acquire the distressed company, at what price and how much control is retained by erstwhile promoters.

The concern found an echo at an internal conference of Enforcement Directorate (ED) officers in Bengaluru this week, where “unearthing frauds under IBC and PMLA” was identified as the agency’s first operational thrust area. The ED said it would specifically examine “collusive

resolution cases involving disproportionately large haircuts through which promoters re-acquire assets”.

The agency’s focus predates the Chandra case. Over the past two years, it has investigated close to a dozen cases in which it has alleged different forms of manipulation — promoter-linked entities dominating creditor committees, proxy bidders being used to regain companies, compromised resolution professionals (RPs), assets being moved out before or during the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) and bids allegedly being suppressed.

The Alchemist case is among the clearest examples. The group, founded by former Rajya Sabha member K D Singh, was already under ED investigation for alleged money laundering of more than Rs 1,840 crore when Alchemist Ltd entered CIRP in 2021. The Committee of Credi-

tors (CoC), ED alleged, was subsequently dominated by three group companies — Technology Parks held 97% of the voting rights, while Alchemist Townships and Alchemist Realty held 1.74% and 0.61% respectively. The RP, Gaurav Misra, was also a former group employee, the agency said.

The ED alleged that the arrangement was designed to enable the group to reclaim assets attached by the agency and eventually seek immunity under Section 32A of the IBC. The NCLT later held that the CIRP had been vitiated by “fraud and collusion” and “fraudulent and malicious intent”, recalled the process and nullified the RP’s appointment and actions. The Calcutta High Court subsequently asked the CBI to probe the CIRP.

In Sunstar Overseas, the allegation was that the company was effectively used to finance



Subhash Chandra

its own takeover. Against admitted claims of Rs 1,274.14 crore, Sunstar was taken over for Rs 196 crore — an almost 85% haircut — by Umaiza Infracon LLP, which the ED described as a shell entity without funds of its own. The agency alleged that money was siphoned from Sunstar to the entity, which was then

projected as an independent resolution applicant.

A similar allegation of using a proxy to influence the CoC surfaced in Richa Industries. The ED alleged that promoters created Saariga Constructions through a former Richa employee acting as a *benamidar*. Saariga allegedly acquired voting rights in the CoC and subsequently submitted a plan to re-acquire Richa. The agency also alleged collusion by the RP in relation to fraudulent transactions and diversion of nearly Rs 40 crore during the insolvency period. When Richa was eventually sold as a going concern in October 2025, public sector banks received Rs 40.29 crore against admitted claims of Rs 696 crore — about 94% haircut.

The ED has also turned its attention to the valuation and sale of assets during CIRP. In the Universal Buildwell case, it alleged “predetermined and artificially

suppressed bids” and proposed illicit consideration outside the formal IBC process. In the Krirsh Florence Estate and Angle Infrastructure matter, it flagged the alleged sale of two acres for Rs 31 crore against a CIRP valuation of Rs 160 crore. Angle Infra RP Sarvesh Kashyap denied the allegations “in toto”, saying he had acted strictly within the IBC framework and that the matter was sub judice.

The scale becomes apparent in the Amtek Auto investigation. Fifteen group companies underwent insolvency, with lenders having claims of over Rs 34,000 crore. According to ED, they were resolved with an average haircut of about 81%. The agency has alleged that promoters moved assets to front entities and *benami* persons even before insolvency proceedings began, and identified about 500 shell companies allegedly holding properties worth over Rs 6,000

crore from siphoned funds.

In Bhasin Infotech, ED alleged that 384 commercial units valued at Rs 203 crore were transferred through “sham” and “backdated” agreements to move them beyond the CIRP. In Kohinoor Power, only about Rs 7 crore was recovered against a bank default of over Rs 280 crore, while the agency alleged diversion of funds through related entities.

In Best Foods, Homestead Infrastructure and Golden Peacock cases, ED alleged that RP Jitesh Gupta re-admitted claims he had earlier rejected as “spurious and fraudulent”, altered the CoC and facilitated a resolution plan allegedly linked to the former promoter. The NCLT had earlier recorded adverse findings against him and directed his replacement. Early September, Gupta secured bail in the case, with the court observing that he was not an accused in the

primary offence and ED could not directly link him to the main accused.

Other investigations show how assets can allegedly be dissipated before or during insolvency. ED has alleged that proceeds of the Rs 40,000-crore-plus bank fraud in the Reliance Communications case were used to acquire a Manhattan property that was later sold during CIRP without the RP’s knowledge. In JVL Agro, it alleged the use of trusts and shell companies to move shares and properties ahead of insolvency.

And in Bhushan Power and Steel, against an alleged bank fraud of Rs 47,204 crore, the company was resolved for about Rs 19,350 crore. ED has attached about Rs 4,938 crore in assets allegedly dissipated by former promoters.

Emails sent to some of these companies did not elicit any response.

Manipur: Kuki man found dead a day after abduction

Jimmy Leivon
Imphal, October 4

A DAY after he was allegedly abducted from his field in Kangpokpi district of Manipur, a 71-year-old Kuki man was on Sunday found dead – with his hands tied behind his back – in a nearby forest, sources said.

The man, Hemjang Haokip of Khunkho Kuki village near Leimakhong, was reported missing after his field hut was set ablaze on Saturday. Haokip's farm trousers, shirt and sweater were found during a search on Sunday, following which security forces deployed sniffer dogs and intensified the operation to trace him. His body was subsequently found in a nearby forest.

According to initial reports, heavy rainfall on Saturday had kept many villagers away from their fields, and the incident came to light in the evening. Haokip was known to frequently spend the night at his hut. After learning that the hut had been burnt and Haokip was missing, villagers launched a search that continued until dark but failed to locate him.

The Kuki Youth Organisation (KYO), Leimakhong block, had earlier demanded Haokip's immediate and safe return and urged authorities and security agencies to intensify search and take action against those responsible. The Khunkho Kuki Village Authority had condemned the abduction and issued a 24-hour ultimatum for Haokip's safe and unconditional release, warning of widespread democratic protests if he was not released.

Meanwhile, the Ariang (Khunkhu) Naga Village Authority, in a clarification issued on Sunday, expressed solidarity with Haokip's family and said neither the village nor its residents had any involvement in his disappearance.

2nd incident in Kolkata 5-star hotel: Man held for molesting 2

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, October 4

SAFETY CONCERNS have surfaced at a five-star hotel in Kolkata after a 56-year-old man was arrested for allegedly molesting two women from a Northeastern state in the lobby. This is the second such incident in a week. Last Sunday, another person was arrested for allegedly assaulting a 20-year-old woman and using obscene language inside the hotel's nightclub.

According to the Kolkata Police, the incident took place between 12.30 am and 1 am Sunday, while the complainant and her companion were in the hotel lobby. The victims submitted a signed written complaint alleging that a man touched them inappropriately, outraging their modesty. The Kolkata police arrested Palash Ray, a businessman from Noida, after identifying and tracking him using CCTV footage.

"During the investigation, CCTV footage of the hotel lobby was thoroughly checked. The complainant duly identified the accused, and his movements were tracked down before he was apprehended from his room," a senior Kolkata police officer said.

KARNATAKA PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION RECRUITMENT EXAM RACKET

Marks withheld, officials used merit list to demand bribes, ED tells court

Express News Service
Bengaluru, October 4

THE KARNATAKA Public Service Commission (KPSC) deliberately withheld candidates' scores in initial selection lists in recent years to allow its chairman and members to negotiate bribes using confidential performance data, an Enforcement Directorate (ED) investigation has revealed.

The revelation followed the arrest and 14-day custody of IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar, 41, who served as KPSC's controller of examinations from January 2024 to March 2026.

Following Gangwar's custodial interrogation, the agency

informed a special court on Saturday that as many as 13 job recruitment drives conducted during his tenure need to be investigated.

Gangwar, the primary accused in the question paper leak for the January 8–9, 2026 examination to recruit 400 veterinary officers, is accused of facilitating widespread corruption through a middleman who collected Rs 20 lakh to Rs 40 lakh each from at least 20 candidates.

1:3 eligibility list

According to ED submissions in the court, the agency uncovered a systematic racket centred on preparing and finalising the 1:3 merit list,

a preliminary shortlist containing three candidates for every available post.

To enable bribe negotiations, KPSC allegedly began publishing 1:3 eligibility lists with only roll numbers and names, omitting candidates' actual marks. KPSC members and officials then extracted performance details from Gangwar to identify high-ranking candidates, as per the agency.

"Once the merit of a candidate was known, the member, official or middleman contacted the candidate and negotiated the bribe amount; the higher the candidate's chance of selection, the higher the amount demanded," the ED informed the court.

During interrogation, Gangwar disclosed that after the veterinary officers' 1:3 merit list was published on February 4, 2026, suspended KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa Sahu, along with KPSC officials B V Geetha, Shanta Hosmani, Elfreda D Silva and others, approached him with candidate names to assess their selection prospects.

Handwritten notes seized from a KPSC official's residence further corroborated the scheme, listing shortlisted candidates who paid bribes but failed to make the final list.

ED counsel Maheshwari D M argued in court that the proceeds of crime generated across all recruitment drives during

Gangwar's tenure remain unquantified, requiring a comprehensive investigation into all involved officials, candidates and transaction amounts.

Defence counsel Siri R argued that the absence of separate FIRs for the other 13 recruitment drives limits the ED's jurisdiction under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) strictly to the veterinary officers' recruitment scam. In response, the ED maintained that all recruitment drives during Gangwar's tenure constitute a continuing money-laundering offence.

The court remanded the suspended IAS officer to 14 days of judicial custody and set his bail hearing for October 8.

4 days on road for 2 seats: Why Vijay stakes prestige for bypolls after Tamil Nadu win

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, October 4

CHIEF MINISTERS do not ordinarily spend four days campaigning for two Assembly by-elections in Tamil Nadu. However, C Joseph Vijay has done it.

With Madurantakam and Dharapuram voting on October 6, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief has spent two days addressing public rallies and another two on roadshows, including a 45-km journey through more than 30 villages in Madurantakam.

The intensity is striking for another reason: during the April Assembly election that brought him to power, Vijay's own campaign appearances were comparatively limited, with several scheduled rallies cancelled and much of TVK's constituency-level campaigning left to candidates and other leaders.

Inside the TVK, expectations have risen with the CM's effort. "With this much campaigning by Vijay himself, we should get 50% of the votes," a senior TVK leader said. That number explains why these two bypolls have become considerably larger than two seats.

The TVK is the ruling party. Both constituencies were vacated by AIADMK legislators who resigned within weeks of being elected and crossed over to Vijay. The same two leaders – Maragatham Kumaravel in Madurantakam and P Sathyabama in Dharapuram – are now contesting as TVK candidates.

A victory would suggest not merely politicians but at least enough of their voters have travelled with them. A defeat in even one seat would complicate the story the TVK has been telling since it came to power in May: that the centre of Tamil Nadu politics has shifted decisively towards Vijay. Senior TVK leaders acknowledge that losing a seat could slow the movement of AIADMK functionaries towards the ruling party.

Since the Assembly elections, the TVK has been drawing former ministers, legislators and local functionaries from the weakened AIADMK. In Dharapuram alone, local-level AIADMK leaders have moved towards it. A victory would make further movement easier. A loss, on the other hand, would remind leaders contemplating a switch that a change of party is

far simpler than transferring a constituency.

That is why the bypoll is also a test of something difficult to measure until votes are counted on October 9: how much of Vijay's April coalition of voters remains personally attached to him after the excitement of the general election has passed. TVK leaders believe women may be particularly important. Their assessment is male voters could remain more firmly distributed among established party loyalties, while Vijay still has room to increase his support among women. Whether that assessment survives ballot box is another matter. But it partly explains Vijay's decision to campaign at close range rather than leave election to ministers and local organisers. In Madurantakam, his roadshow included village stops a tractor ride and tea at a roadside shop.

The Opposition understands the symbolism. The AIADMK has turned circumstances of the bypoll itself into its campaign. Its supporters have repeatedly called Sathyabama a "traitor" for winning Dharapuram as an AIADMK candidate and then resigning to join the TVK. The argument is simple: voters elected an AIADMK MLA in April, why should they be asked five months later to elect the same person for another party?

Former CM and DMK chief MK Stalin has made a similar argument from the DMK, describing the elections as resulting from the "death of democracy" and attacking the TVK for making voters return to polling booths before, as he put it, the indelible ink from the general election had disappeared.

The DMK enters these by-elections without broad alliance that accompanied it into the Assembly polls. If its candidates substantially increase party's vote share from April while contesting largely on its own, DMK leaders can argue the defeat earlier did not destroy the party's underlying electoral strength.

The CPI and CPI(M) have supported Vijay's government from outside but are now fighting his candidates. The PMK, meanwhile, has remained neutral amid discussions about a possible future relationship with the TVK. All of which makes October 6 an unusually crowded examination of a government less than five months old.



Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay alongside TVK candidate P Sathyabama during a roadshow ahead of the Dharapuram Assembly constituency by-election, on Sunday. PTI

As TVK joins INDIA bloc, pause on projecting Vijay as PM face

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, October 4

FOR CHIEF Minister C Joseph Vijay, joining the INDIA bloc was less a dramatic turn than the formal acknowledgement of where Tamil Nadu's post-election arithmetic had already taken him. His Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) governs state with the Congress as an ally. The VCK and IUML are also part of the arrangement that enabled Vijay to form the government after TVK won 108 seats, short of the 118 needed for an absolute majority.

A national third front has not taken shape. Remaining outside the BJP-led NDA while simultaneously keeping away from the principal national Opposition grouping was becoming an increasingly narrow political space. On Saturday, TVK stepped out of it. TVK representatives Aadhav Arjuna and Marie Wilson attended an INDIA bloc meeting at the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee headquarters in Chennai, alongside CPI, CPI(M), VCK, MDMK and IUML. Tamil Nadu Congress chief president Manickam Tagore declared that Vijay's party had formally joined the alliance, calling it a "historic day."

The announcement settles one question but opens several others – including where DMK, until recently the principal Tamil Nadu component of the

national Opposition alliance, fits.

The immediate occasion was electoral rolls. The parties adopted resolutions against the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise and Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, and announced demonstrations across Tamil Nadu on October 13 and 14, followed by a larger Chennai protest on October 15. The TVK is expected to participate. Whether Vijay himself will attend remains unclear.

Until recently, this relationship had remained undefined. Tagore had maintained that TVK could not technically be treated as an INDIA bloc constituent because it had no representation in Parliament. The party was not invited to INDIA bloc's national meeting in New Delhi last week. Saturday therefore marked a change not merely in TVK's position but in Congress's willingness to recognise it formally. For Vijay, the move provides a national structure for an alliance that already exists at home. The Congress has five MLAs and is part of the TVK-led government. The next Lok Sabha election in 2029 now provides a larger horizon: an INDIA bloc arrangement potentially gives TVK a framework for negotiating parliamentary seats without having to construct another national partnership from scratch.

According to senior party

sources, the leadership has told functionaries before by-election campaign not to project Vijay as a future prime ministerial candidate. Resources that had been going towards Instagram reels and social-media material presenting Vijay in that role have been curtailed, a senior TVK leader told *The Indian Express*.

The intervention is partly practical. The TVK is fighting immediate Assembly by-elections; Vijay is barely months into his first term as CM. The national ambition can wait. Politics occasionally requires social media to observe seniority.

The more consequential effect of Saturday's decision may instead be on the DMK. After losing power, the party has found itself without the coalition structure that surrounded it before the Assembly polls. The CPI and CPI(M), contesting the by-elections independently after distancing themselves from Vijay's alliance, might under different circumstances have found a return to DMK politically natural.

The TVK's entry into INDIA complicates that route. The Left parties attended Saturday's meeting alongside TVK. So did VCK and MDMK. In other words, the national Opposition platform now contains several parties whose state relationships are considerably less tidy than their seating arrangement at the Congress office suggested.

Jharkhand woman still in detention centre despite court order; HC asks, 'under what law?'

In 2025, the woman escaped from the centre; a trial court convicted her but she was acquitted under the Foreigners Act

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, October 4

A JAMTARA woman, then in her early 20s, was arrested in an alleged child kidnapping case in 2018. Sentenced to two years in prison, she was supposed to walk out free in 2020.

Instead, she ended up becoming the first and, for a while, the only detainee at the Foreigners' Holding Centre in Hazaribag – over 190 kilometres from her hometown.

Police accused her of being a Bangladeshi national and, for next several years, she was at the centre inside Hazaribag prison.

In June 2025, the woman, after allegedly being sexually assaulted multiple times by a constable, escaped from the centre with two other detainees. On July 20 this year, an Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Court convicted her of escaping from custody but acquitted her of the charge under the Foreigners Act.

On completion of her sentence, instead of being released, she was sent back to the detention centre. On October 1, the Jharkhand High Court asked a question that has followed her since she completed her first sentence in 2020: under what law is she still being detained?

A division bench of Justices Sujit Narayan Prasad and Akhil Kumar questioned "under what authority of law" the woman was continuing to be kept at the detention centre.

Hazaribag SP told the HC that an inquiry would be initiated into the matter.

According to social worker and lawyer Apurva Vivek, who filed a habeas corpus petition on the 30-year-old's behalf in the HC, the woman told her that she had been sexually assaulted multiple times by a police constable. The ordeal had caused her severe mental distress and was part of the circumstances behind her decision to escape.

Married young after her father's death, the woman's life took a turn when she was arrested on February 2, 2018, relating to alleged kidnapping of a child. The same year, in December, she was convicted under Section 363 of the IPC and

sentenced to two years' rigorous imprisonment, with the period already spent in custody set off against the sentence. On February 4, 2020, she completed the sentence. But instead of being released, she was shifted to the foreigners' holding centre at Lok Nayak Jai Prakash Narayan Central Jail (also known as JP Central Jail) campus in Hazaribag.

The authorities there began treating her as a Bangladeshi national. According to the chronology placed before the HC, she was initially the only detainee there. In November 2024, another woman was brought to the centre and on June 10, 2025, she along with two other detainees escaped. They were apprehended following day at Dhanbad railway station and a fresh case was registered at Lohsinghna police station.

Vivek noticed something odd. Instead of the woman's real name, she was registered in case records as someone from the minority community. Her father's name was found to be different from her original records.

The case came before the Hazaribag court. The prosecution accused the three of escaping from the camp and invoked Section 14 of the Foreigners Act.

On July 20, the trial court stated that the prosecution had proved the charge relating to escape from custody and convicted all three accused under Section 262 read with Section 3(5) of the BNS. But Foreigners Act charge did not stand, and the court acquitted the woman.

The judgment recorded several gaps, including "the absence of authenticated cross-border records, original travel documents or validated nationality verification material establishing their foreign status."

The court sought an inquiry by the Hazaribag Superintendent of Police (SP) into allegation against the constable and directed the Inspector General of Prisons to participate in the proceedings. The Home Secretary of Jharkhand has been directed to appear before the court on October 5. Reports from DLSA and SP have been sought. SP, Hazaribag, could not be contacted for comment despite attempts.

Bricks, bottles hurled into campus, Ray film institute on edge again

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, October 4

EXACTLY AFTER one week, the same scene played out once again at the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute (SRFTI) campus as tensions erupted.

On Sunday evening bottles and bricks were hurled in quick succession from protestors outside the campus, while students and teachers stood inside trying to deflect them with their feet.

The Bangiyo Hindu Jagaran Manch took to streets on Sunday alleging insults to Swami Vivekananda and Bharat Mata inside the campus last Sunday.

The situation on campus had previously flared up last Sunday following a clash between members of the Akhil Bharatiya Grahak Panchayat and institute students. The rally began from Ajoy Nagar and once it reached the gates of the campus protestors broke police barricades and tried to enter the campus. With massive deployment of police force protestors were unable to enter the campus but the allegations are that the protestors had torn down the pictures of BR Ambedkar and Mahatma Gandhi and instead pictures of Bharat Maa was put on the gates.

According to students they had written to the police not to give permission for the rally and to deploy adequate force.

According to police sources in the scuffle with protestors some police officers were injured. One of the protestors from Jagaran Manch stated, "No more letters will work now. They

are Naxalites. They must be thrown out." Another protestor said, "they have insulted Bharat Maa we will not tolerate this. They either have to love India or they have to leave India.

On the other side of the gate students and teachers were seen standing inside as bottles were repeatedly thrown at them. They shouted "Go Back" slogans. Students were seen holding placards saying, "our campus is not your Shakha" "no entry for fascist" and "Go back".

Protestors of the Bangiyo Hindu Jagaran Mancha broke police barricades twice but police managed to keep the protestors from entering.

On Saturday a letter had been sent to Union Minister of Information and Broadcasting Ashwini Vaishnaw by students of FTII Pune, SRFTI Kolkata, and FTII Itanagar expressing serious concern regarding security of SRFTI Kolkata students in the aftermath of the violence on the institute campus on 27 September 2026. The students in their letter stated, "We have been informed a rally organised by Hindu Jagran Manch is proposed to take place tomorrow 4 October at 4 PM, approximately 800 metres from the main gate of SRFTI... In present circumstances, the proposed rally in such close proximity to the institute has understandably caused serious concern among the students. The SRFTI Students are presently engaging with the concerned authorities to seek that the rally not be permitted within the periphery of the institute."

2 captive-bred Great Indian Bustards released in national park

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, October 4

UNION ENVIRONMENT Minister Bhopender Yadav and Wildlife Institute of India (WII) scientists released two male Great Indian Bustards (GIB) in Rajasthan's Desert National Park on Sunday morning, marking the first step in rewilding captive-bred GIBs raised at two conservation breeding centres at Ramdevra and Sam, Jaisalmer, under Project GIB.

The project is being implemented for the long-term recovery of the critically endangered bird. Only about 150 GIBs remain in the wild.

Rajasthan Minister of Forest, Environment, and Climate Change Sanjay Sharma was also present on the occasion.

"In a milestone move, released two male Great Indian Bustards in Sam, Desert National Park, Jaisalmer, today

morning. This landmark success has been made possible by the nearly decade-long unwavering dedication of our scientists, researchers and ground staff who have spent years to ensure GIB reclaims the deserts of Rajasthan," Yadav wrote on X.

The conservation breeding centres were established to raise a founder population of GIBs that could be rewilded, a measure against the declining wild population. From 2019 onwards, wild-collected eggs were incubated artificially, and chicks were hand-reared. Later, these hand-reared birds mated in captivity.

At present, there are 98 such captive-bred birds in these facilities. Around 86 of them are being maintained for captive reproduction, and 11 have been earmarked for release into the wild. Of these 11, two birds were released into the wild at Desert National



Minister of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Bhopender Yadav (second from left) and forest officials release two male Great Indian Bustards at the Desert National Park in Jaisalmer. PTI

Park today. Captive reproduction has resulted in 24 live chicks in 2025 and 29 in 2026.

"The release of captive-bred

GIBs represents the next critical step in the species recovery programme and will provide important scientific learnings

for progressively developing and refining protocols for reintroduction of captive-bred birds into their natural habitat,"

the environment ministry stated in a press release issued Saturday, after the initiation of the rewilding process.

Yadav said Saturday that the GIB was important for grassland conservation, land degradation neutrality, and working as an important stopover for migratory birds that travel from the Central Asia flyway.

The Central Asian flyway is a large migratory corridor stretching across 30 countries from North to South Asia, connecting the Arctic and Indian Oceans.

Besides captive breeding, the project also includes habitat restoration by the Rajasthan forest department, including the establishment of around 200 square kilometres of fenced grassland enclosures inside the Desert National Park. Long-term telemetry studies by WII have identified these enclosures as prime breeding habitats for the species.



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BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Global capital is no longer cheap, that's the challenge

TEN-YEAR US and French government bond yields hit 5.34 and 4.99 per cent respectively last week, their highest since 2002, while crossing 3.1 per cent for Japan, the first time after 1996. The increase in borrowing costs for the governments of these countries over the past one year works out to 1.2-1.4 percentage points. That's roughly twice the 0.7 percentage points rise in the 10-year Indian government security yield, which closed the week at 7.21 per cent. Simply put, investors are demanding higher returns from governments on the tradable debt instruments issued by them that, being backed by the sovereign's power to tax and print currency, are ostensibly default risk-free. And unlike before, they aren't differentiating much between the governments of advanced and emerging economies; the bonds of the former are the ones that have surged to multi-decade peaks.

There are three reasons for this. The first is the persistent deficits run by developed country governments, due to aging populations, expanded social welfare commitments alongside military build-up, and voter resistance to tax increases or entitlement cuts. The US's outstanding public debt has surpassed \$40 trillion. Its defence budget for 2026 reached a record \$1 trillion, with the Donald Trump administration proposing \$1.5 trillion of spending for the coming fiscal year. The Washington-based Institute of International Finance has estimated that advanced economies paid over \$3.3 trillion in interest on globally traded government bonds last year. The perception of mounting fiscal risk also explains Chinese holdings of US Treasuries falling to an 18-year-low of \$618 billion in July 2016, from the peak \$1.32 trillion of November 2013. The second reason is commodity inflation from war and weather-induced supply shocks, driving central banks to raise interest rates as well as signal further increases ahead.

The third has to do with the global race for building AI infrastructure. The combined capital expenditure of the four large "hyperscalers" alone — Meta, Microsoft, Amazon and Google — was \$410 billion in 2025, while projected at \$725 billion in 2026 and \$1.1 trillion-plus in 2027. A significant part of this is being funded through debt. As tech companies have turned to the bond markets, it has forced governments to compete ever harder for investor money, driving up yields on even "safe haven" long-term US Treasuries. For India, the implications are two-fold. Policymakers and corporates, for one, must reconcile themselves to global capital being no longer available cheap. Secondly, the importance of fiscal discipline, and the government not crowding out private sector borrowings, applies no less at home.

A late surge at Nagoya & a long way to Los Angeles

ASHADOW of despair hung over the early phase of India's Asian Games campaign with the gold haul stuck at four for what seemed like ages. But within a week, thanks to a late surge and a few spectacular medals, the national anthem was played 21 times. The total gold count fell from 28 in Hangzhou, and so did the total medal tally, from 107 to 85. However, India finished fourth, the same position as the previous Asiad.

The standout performance came from the archery contingent, which humbled the mighty Koreans enroute to multiple gold medals. While compound archery was expected to make a mark, the mixed team winning gold and booking a quota for the LA Olympics was a shot in the arm. A truly world-class performance came from Kumkum Mohod, just 17, who ended the Korean dominance by winning gold in individual recurve — the first-ever Indian male or female to do so at the Asian Games. The women's hockey team won the title after 44 years by beating China in the final. This after reports of infighting and a string of poor results had brought down the team morale. The turnaround after coach Sjoerd Marijne returned to the helm was commendable. The boxers with three gold medals and wrestlers with a haul of two, too, contributed to India's late climb after athletes from both sports failed to finish atop the podium in the last edition. The comeback story from boxing belonged to Parveen Hooda — stripped of her 2023 bronze medal for an anti-doping whereabouts failure, she bounced back to win gold. On the penultimate day, golfer Pranavi Urs, little known outside the ranks of those who regularly follow the sport, added a surprise continental title.

But while India has defied the catastrophic forecasts, there is still a long way to go to catch up with the global superpowers. India must aspire to increase the gold medal count. China's is 169, more than double the number won by host Japan. Some of the performances by Indian athletes give them little or no chance at the Olympics two years from now. India didn't win a single gold medal at the 2024 Paris Olympics despite the government pumping in money for training. A repeat show two years from now at Los Angeles will be disappointing.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



IN FEBRUARY this year, 10 days after New Delhi and Washington unveiled the framework for an interim trade deal, I testified before the US-China Economic and Security Review Commission on Capitol Hill. One of the points I made was that the costliest tariff in the India-US relationship was not any rate on paper, but confusion. Whatever Washington does on trade with partners like India, it should pair enforcement with predictability through transparent guidance, structured consultations, and fewer of the avoidable uncertainties that push partners and firms to hedge. Days later, the US Supreme Court struck down Trump's reciprocal tariffs, the country-by-country duties he had imposed since April 2025 under an emergency law that was also the basis on which India's new rate had been set. From then on, confusion stopped being a risk and became the operating condition.

We are still stuck there. Twenty months after the two governments launched negotiations, the deal has stalled for a third time. In August 2025, American negotiators called off a round in New Delhi as tariffs on India climbed towards 50 per cent. In February, a planned visit by India's negotiators was put off while the legal ground kept shifting. Now, a week after the US State Department declared that the deal was "90 per cent-plus there", the US Trade Representative has said hesees nothing imminent. The reasons have changed each time, but the story has remained the same: The two sides have moved closer on the text even as the payoff from signing has kept shifting. So the real question is not how close the deal is, but what India would actually get if it is signed today.

In February, the joint statement set out to bring the US tariff on Indian goods down from 50 to 18 per cent. In return, India agreed to cut its own duties on American industrial goods and buy more from the US. Within two weeks, the legal basis for that 18 per cent was gone. Washington first imposed a temporary global tariff on most imports, then replaced it in July with new tariffs based on how effectively each country keeps goods made with forced labour out of its market. India landed in the lower group at 10 per cent, helped by its own move to ban such imports, which was a sensible step. But Vietnam, which competes with India in many of the same products, pays only slightly more, while several other countries pay the same as India. The clear advantage India appeared to have won in February has shrunk to a narrow lead that could easily disappear.

New Delhi wants a clear advantage over its rivals before it signs, and the logic is easy to follow. If India cuts its own tariffs and agrees to buy more from the US, but Indian companies selling goods to America end up no better than they are today, India gains very little from the deal. The objective makes sense, but a tariff advantage is a weak thing to rely on because, under the current US system, it can be lost in at least three ways.

First, the edge is relative, and Washington decides who gets it.



Soumya Bhowmick

New Delhi's bargaining power would, therefore, be better spent securing terms that are harder to reverse than chasing a wider tariff gap

An old friendship renews itself through an ambitious pact



Guy Parmelin

THE LAST time I wrote for this newspaper was in February, when I arrived in Delhi for the AI Impact Summit. Eight months and one G7 meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi later, I am back in Delhi. This time, I am here to mark a significant anniversary: The first anniversary of the entry into force of the Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA) between the EFTA states and India. I am returning as a guest of the Republic of India on a state visit, demonstrating how what began as a trade negotiation has evolved into a partnership between two economies and a friendship between two democracies.

Anniversaries invite summaries. I would rather treat this one as a checkpoint. What TEPA has delivered is not just a headline but something more durable: Tariff lines that have actually moved, and firms making decisions on the strength of it.

Switzerland is bringing precision machinery, pharmaceuticals, MedTech and specialty chemicals to this agreement — the kind of intermediate goods and technical capability that will feed into Indian manufacturing rather than compete with it. It is too early to declare results after a year, but the direction is clear. Tariff schedules and procedures do not change behaviour by themselves; they only do so when companies decide that the change is substantial enough to plan around. From our conversations with Swiss businesses, we can see that they are in the early stages of making this calculation.

The figure that will matter more than any other over the next decade and a half is the \$100 billion investment and job-creation goal tied to TEPA — the first time an Indian trade agreement has linked market access to a concrete investment goal rather than tariff schedules alone. Beyond this is a broader ambition: To deepen economic ties, encourage long-term investment, create opportunities for employment and strengthen cooperation between companies, institutions and people. The essential work of building institutions is well underway. A dedicated Desk has been set up to support EFTA companies with a smooth, informed, and confident investment experience.

This is a partnership in which both sides gain. India gains capital, technology, and easier access to a market for high-

value goods. Switzerland gains something we need just as much: A large, fast-growing trading partner at a moment when global trade is more fragile and unpredictable than it was even a year ago. Diversification is a strategic priority.

One more point deserves emphasis because it distinguishes TEPA from an older generation of trade deals. The TEPA carries meaningful provisions on labour standards, environmental protection and responsible business conduct. They reflect commitments that India and the EFTA states made together, and they show what a modern trade agreement can achieve.

Alongside the trade and economic relations between our countries, there is a broader relationship: Scientific and research cooperation that go back decades, a steady flow of Indian students and professionals through Swiss universities and technical institutes, growing numbers of Indian visitors to the Alps, and Swiss tourists drawn to India. There is also a substantial diplomatic relationship that has produced a dense web of bilateral agreements on science and technology, aviation, taxation, and education over the decades. None of this is reflected in the trade balance, yet it arguably makes the trade balance possible, a level of familiarity and trust between our two societies that has been quietly built up over many years, visit by visit and exchange by exchange, long before anyone thought to call it a partnership.

In 2028, Switzerland and India will mark 80 years since signing their Treaty of Friendship, a document that promised "perpetual peace" and "unalterable friendship". Those are large words for any two nations to live up to. But I think we have. Each era renewed it in the terms available to it. Scientific exchange in one decade, student visas in another, now a trade agreement with a \$100-billion ambition attached to it. The TEPA, but also the Migration and Mobility Partnership and the Young Professional Agreement to be signed are simply today's answer to a promise made almost 80 years ago: A practical framework that can deepen our friendship through mutual support and a shared interest in sustainable growth, prosperity, and long-term success.

The writer is president, Switzerland

A pilot's heroism points to need to rethink cockpit safety



Satyendra Pandey

THE COUNTRY is proud of Smit Machchhar, and both the Indian and Israeli prime ministers have commended him for his valour. The commendations are well deserved but they also reopen questions of safety and technology, which are once again staring the aviation sector in the face. On this flight, nothing mechanical malfunctioned. The human element failed. Forty years of aircraft design has focused on engineering out human error — the incorrect altitude, the incorrect setting, or an exceedingly sharp angle of descent. The engineering has to first reduce error to a statistical problem and then apply automation. But malice and intent to kill are not an error. It is a judgement, and a decision.

The safety architecture in aviation is more serious than most passengers realise. In addition to airport security protocols, most airlines run a psychological assessment of every pilot before they are released to line flying, run support programmes for all crew members, and conduct random testing for psychoactive substances. Airports also employ behaviour detection officers and technology, both of which will now likely also focus on airline crew behaviour. On several flights, air marshals are present. But their identity and pattern are secret, as is any coordination with intelligence agencies. Even so, what the safety system actually measures is fairly narrow. A psychological assessment at the start of employment is a snapshot in time. The Class 1 medical test that pilots have to clear at regular intervals is built to catch physiology, not psychology. And psychometrics usually screen for instability, not for ideology or mal-intent.

Once the aircraft is in the air, the cockpit is the last line of defence. The captain is given full authority for the flight, and automation has always held that there be an override in the cockpit whereby the aircraft can be taken over manually, even though a ground-initiated override — via a protected uplink allowing a certified authority to take an aircraft — exists. In fact, the technology is almost two decades old. But it has never been used on a commercial aircraft because, among other considerations, no regulator has been willing to answer the question of who will hold the key.

But at a time when AI is working wonders, and where autonomous vehicles are a reality, this will reignite the debate. The steppingstone in aviation is likely the ground-initiated override. But automation cannot remove the error of human misjudgement. More importantly, it cannot assume responsibility. And accountability is not a capability that can be specified, procured or certified.

A link that can take an aircraft from a hostile pilot is also a link that can take an aircraft from a competent one. Centralising control substitutes a human-trust problem with another human-trust problem. Ironically, while creating a safety net, it also creates a new way to attack an aircraft. Either the aircraft becomes genuinely autonomous with no pilot, no override, nobody on board or on the ground with the capability to use it as a missile. Or, it keeps a human at the controls, in which case it must keep a second human for checks and balances. Until there are no pilots in cockpits, there will have to be two in them. Captain Smit Machchhar has strengthened this for several years to come. He should not have had to.

The writer is managing partner at aviation advisory firm AT-TV

40 YEARS AGO

October 5, 1986



PT Usha leads winning spree

INDIA'S WONDER-girl P T Usha led the winning spree, with its boxers managing to hold on to their expected positions as the country raked in 18 medals on the penultimate day of the 10th Asia Games in Seoul. India secured one gold, six silvers and 11 bronzes to take its total tally so far to 36 medals (4-9-23) and move up to the fifth position in the overall standings.

Congress bogus membership

THE CONGRESS (I) seems to have reached a dead end in its efforts to settle the problem of bogus membership. Excluding those enrolled after April 10, the party's primary

membership is — subject to scrutiny — now said to total 2.2 crore. But reports from district scrutiny committees suggest that 70 per cent of this primary membership, or a massive 1.54 crore members, is bogus

For VVIPs, coordinated security

A SPECIAL group will be set up to oversee the work of all security agencies for better coordination among various agencies engaged in VVIP security. Detailed discussions in this regard were held in the Home Ministry on instructions from the Union Home Minister, Buta Singh, sources said. The meeting felt that the multiplicity of agencies, at times, resulted in instances like the one when an abortive attempt was

made on the Prime Minister's life at Rajghat.

Fire in Soviet nuclear sub

A FIRE broke out on a Soviet nuclear-powered submarine carrying ballistic missiles in the Atlantic Ocean, and three of the crew members died, state media TASS reported on Saturday. An expert commission in Moscow said there was no danger of any nuclear explosion or radioactive contamination of the environment or of weapons going off on their own. A compartment of the submarine caught fire a thousand kilometres northeast of the Bermuda Islands between the United States and the United Kingdom in the North Atlantic Ocean.



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Drought in Maharashtra, then and now, frames a changing state politics



GIRISH KUBER

IT'S EASY to spot a few familiar patterns — and some surprises — here. As Maharashtra confronts a water shortage after a weak monsoon, many are comparing the situation with 1972, when the state experienced its toughest drought on record. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis has expressed concerns that “this year’s drought could be worse than 1972.” But there’s a bit more to it.

Back in 1972, three successive years of poor monsoons led to a real crisis. Things are different this time: Last year brought plenty of early rain, topping up all the dams and reservoirs. In 1972, it took three years of failed rains to spark trouble; more than half a century later, just one bad season has left the state in a spot of bother. This neatly sums up how things have shifted in a state once celebrated for its farming progress.

The 1972 drought brought out the best in politicians who truly cared about ordinary people. Troubled by the harsh conditions, Vitthal Sakharam Page, then chairman of the state Legislative Council, asked his wife how much cash she had at home. Mrs Page found just about Rs 700. He then asked how many labourers that might support, and she replied, “Around 10 for two weeks.” A dedicated Gandhian, Page quickly raised the matter with the then chief minister, Vasant Rao Naik, calling for Rs 100 crore to help the state’s poor. Naik invited Krishnarao Dhulap of the Peasants and Workers Party (PWP), the Leader of the Opposition, to discuss raising the sum. In a rare and heartening move, Dhulap and the entire Opposition proposed a tax raise, which the treasury backed. The Assembly unanimously agreed to add a 15 paise surcharge per passenger on state transport

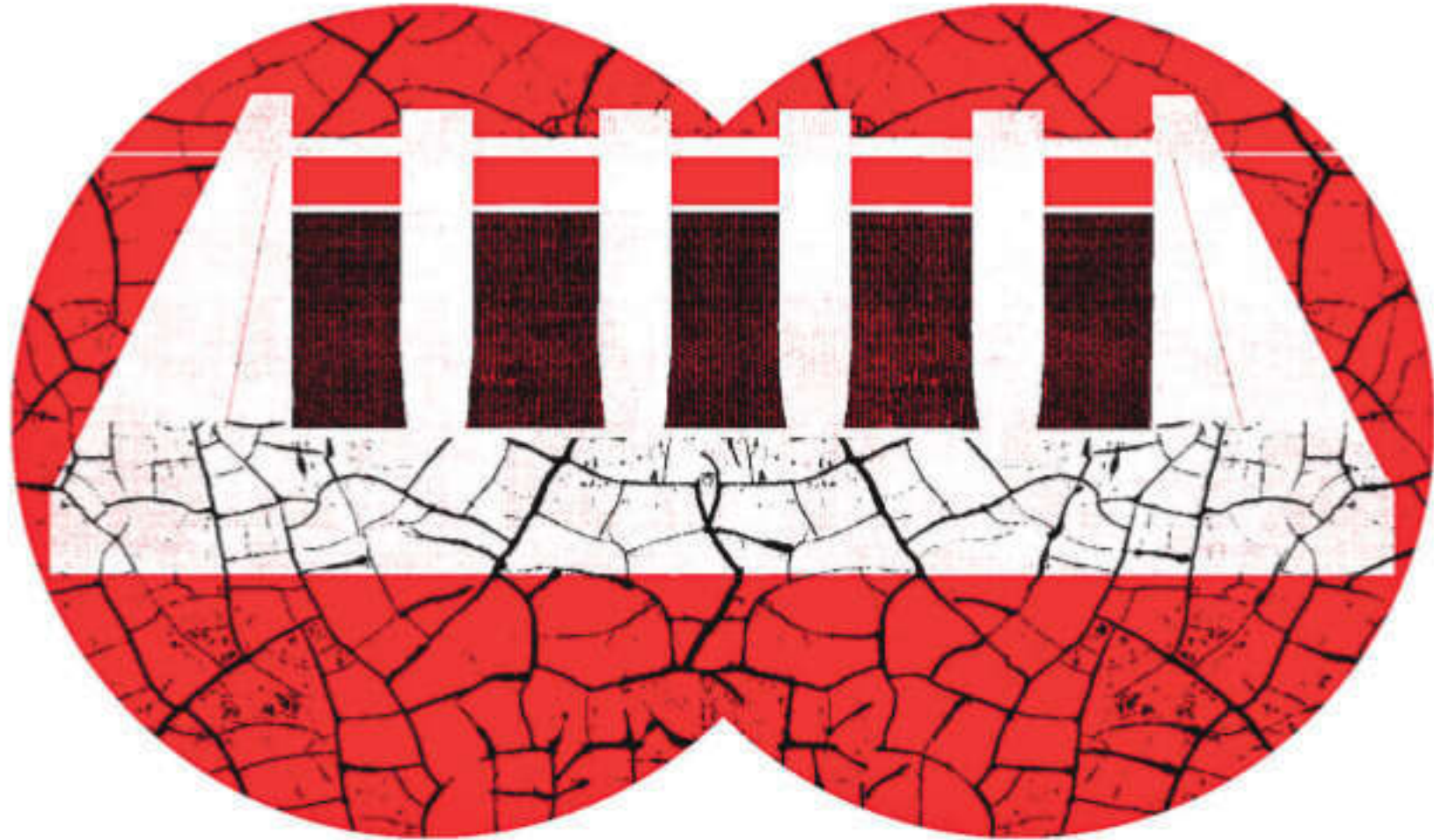


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

bus tickets. This fund created the Employment Guarantee Scheme (EGS), recently renamed VB-G RAM G (Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission). It’s pretty rare to see the opposition calling for a tax rise.

Cut to 2026. Even before the formal conclusion of the monsoon, the state — already constrained by a debt of Rs 11 lakh crore — is securing additional borrowing to fund a Rs 45,000 crore drought relief programme. Although the central government has set a borrowing ceiling of Rs 1.20 lakh crore for the current financial year, the state has already consumed Rs 50,000 crore in loans over five months — much before the drought was officially declared. At the time of the budget presentation in March, a revenue deficit of Rs 40,552 crore and a fiscal deficit of Rs 1.5 lakh crore were projected. This year, the state has allocated a substantial Rs 70,000 crore solely for interest servicing on its borrowings — a figure expected to rise as

further debt is incurred. Against this backdrop, Fadnis, who also holds the finance portfolio, presented supplementary demands totalling Rs 97,000 crore during the first quarter of the current financial year. This is no less than a habitual profligate begging for funds the day after payday.

Welcome to today’s Maharashtra, which is safe to characterise as fiscally imprudent and entrapped in self-imposed challenges. Money matters aren’t the only hurdle the state faces. The state is missing figures like V S Page, who could dream up clever ideas for everyone’s benefit, and opposition leaders such as Krishnarao Dhulap, who showed real generosity by suggesting a tax to help tackle the drought. A discernible shortage of competent personnel and leaders demonstrating public accountability is evident, as Fadnis is compelled to address every issue personally. He has few ministers on whom he can depend.

The three-party coalition pres-

What took three failed monsoons to produce in 1972 has taken just one bad season today — a measure of Maharashtra’s deepening fiscal and agricultural vulnerabilities

The writer is editor, Loksatta

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Monitoring El Niño

INDIA HAS gotten good at predicting cyclones and heavy rain, but this growing El Niño calls for a different kind of watchfulness, one that looks much closer to the ground (‘El Niño calls for wider tracking of climate stress’, October 3, IE). Two forests facing the same lack of rain can suffer very differently depending on their soil, groundwater and local conditions, which means satellite data from above is simply not enough. Uttarakhand’s effort to monitor glacial lakes in real time is a good example that other states should follow, especially as warmer winters make our Himalayan forests more prone to fires each year.

K Chidanand Kumar, Bengaluru

Protect the vote

THE EARLY struggle for voting rights offers a useful reminder that democratic participation cannot be taken for granted (‘Gandhi’s first fight was for the vote’, IE, October 3). The right to vote has meaning only when citizens can exercise it freely and without unnecessary barriers. Electoral institutions must therefore keep voter registration accessible, records accurate and procedures transparent. Public awareness is equally important, particularly among young and first-time voters. The lesson from history is straightforward: Political participation is not merely about casting a ballot on election day; it also requires sustained attention to the institutions that protect that right.

M Barathi, Bengaluru

Going back to books

AS AN avid reader all my life, and having experienced the power and reach of the printed word and its ability to shape minds, I believe we may eventually witness a reverse trend: People turning away from endless scrolling and going back to books (‘Can doomscrollers become doomreaders?’, IE, October 3). Ideas expressed through words have liberated and transformed mankind for centuries, and reading remains one of the most powerful ways of engaging with them. I foresee reading returning, with libraries playing a key role.

Nawal Thorat, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar



ABHINAV KUMAR

A LIFE in khaki is not for everyone. Even amongst those given the privilege to wear the uniform, a few stand out as the embodiment of virtues that make an ideal police officer. Trinath Mishra, a member of the 1965 batch of the Indian Police Service, who passed away on October 1, belonged to that rare category. For a generation of policemen, his name was spoken with a mixture of respect and wistfulness: Respect for what he did, wistfulness because the system he served with impeccable integrity and dedication seldom makes room for officers of his calibre.

I first met him not as an officer but as a young school boy. The introduction came through Kanhaiya Lal Gupta, his batchmate in the UP cadre, and my uncle by marriage, who passed away last year. In the company of these two men, I encountered, for the first time, policing as an idea rather than a job. They disagreed about almost everything except the one thing that mattered: Khaki is a trust, not a privilege. Mishra’s story began, in a sense, at Netarhat. He was among the first batch of a remarkable residential school there, an institution founded on the conviction that a holistic education need not be the monopoly of metropolitan elites. It instilled in him his love for austerity and a quiet sense of self-belief.

As a young SP, he served in some of the most challenging districts of UP and was an integral part of the team of officers

They taught me that institutional loyalty and personal integrity are not opposites, though the service will often try to persuade you otherwise

who wiped out the scourge of dacoity in the state. In the early 1990s, he served as the director of the Special Protection Group. He was then selected to officiate as director of the CBI, and subsequently headed the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), holding concurrent charge of the CISF as well. Few officers of any generation have commanded so many of the institutions that hold the Indian state together. But what matters is what a man does when the coveted seat he occupies is on the line.

That test came in October 1998. As CBI director, he authorised searches on the premises of the country’s most powerful corporate house. Within weeks, he was out. Not for any impropriety, but, by every account of the time, for not having kept the political executive in the loop. There was then no fixed tenure for the CBI chief. He took this transfer as a badge of honour and moved on.

What struck me then, and strikes me more now, is that he did not nurse a grievance in public. He went on to lead the CRPF, and did that job with the same unfussy competence. Years later, as courts and governments argued over tenure protection for the CBI director, his removal was cited as Exhibit A for why it was needed. He had become, without ever seeking it, a case study in the vulnerability of honest institutions.

What did I learn from men like Trinath Mishra and Kan-

To Trinath Mishra, with respect and wistfulness

haiya Lal Gupta? From Mishra, I learnt that the hardest decisions in policing are between the right thing and the safe thing, and the safe thing almost always comes with the better posting. From Gupta, I learnt that such choices must be made without self-righteousness, and their consequences borne without bitterness. Together, they taught me that institutional loyalty and personal integrity are not opposites, though many well-wishers will often try to persuade you otherwise.

The Indian police has not always been generous to its best and brightest. It rewards compliance and penalises professional integrity more often than it cares to admit. Mishra’s career is proof that one can pay the price, keep one’s dignity, and go on serving the institution that failed to protect you for doing the right thing.

He belonged to a generation who built many of the institutions we inherited, and always warned us how easily they could be hollowed out from within. Arguably, we have honoured the first half of their legacy far more faithfully than the second.

To his family, my deepest condolences. To the young officers who never knew him, I offer a small assignment: Read about the events of October 1998, and then, ask yourself honestly what you would have done in his place. That question is his parting gift to all of us who attempt to wear the uniform with pride and honour.

The writer is a serving IPS officer. Views are personal

New lockdown for women, enabled by technology

enabled by technology. The digital world that once helped women step out of the home is increasingly becoming the reason we can ask them to stay in it. While I was growing up in the early 2000s, the BPO sector was exploding. An increasing number of women were entering the workforce. Night shifts became commonplace. There was an undeniable allure to these technology-enabled jobs: For many young women, they offered a first taste of financial independence, mobility, and a life beyond the boundaries of the home. Young women were beginning to occupy public spaces — and the public imagination — as equal citizens.

But now, institutions are increasingly able to shake off their responsibilities and move online rather than address structural issues. The COVID-19 pandemic made us comfortable with this. What began as an emergency response has now become an

easy solution to a range of problems. When a neighbourhood is unsafe, shift classes online. When pollution becomes unbearable, move schools online. When there is a heatwave or a disruption to public life, move work online.

While digital work and online education can be immensely helpful, the problem is what happens when they become the default response to problems. Instead of asking how women can continue to safely occupy public spaces, we make it easier for them not to occupy them at all. Mov-

While digital work and online education can be immensely helpful, the problem is what happens when they become the default response to problems

ing work and education online also assumes that the home is automatically a safe and productive space. For many women, domestic spaces are themselves sites of violence, surveillance and unequal power. And when a woman works or studies from home, she is rarely only working or studying. The boundaries between paid work and unpaid domestic labour become blurred. A university, meanwhile, is not simply a place where a student receives information for a few hours. It is a social and intellectual space where young men and women learn independence and negotiate their position as a citizen.

Post-pandemic, there is also an increasing expectation that women can simply “work from home (WFH)”. Since becoming a mother a few months ago, I am increasingly asked: Why do you need to travel to a university? Why can’t you just teach online,

prioritise your child? I see an increasing number of families making similar calculations. They prefer daughters to study close to home, not leave the city. Remote work becomes attractive because a woman can earn while also “managing” the household. In a recent “*rishta*” meeting, my cousin wistfully said that she can work from home “if she likes”, that there is “no need” to go to an office because “*aajkal ka mahaul kharab hai*” (the situation isn’t good”).

WFH sounds like flexibility. But we should be careful that technology does not become a more sophisticated way of putting women back in a way that looks less like confinement because the door is not visibly locked.

The writer is assistant professor, Jindal School of Design and Architecture, OP Jindal Global University

The writer is Sarkaryavah, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh

Odisha vs Chhattisgarh over Mahanadi back in spotlight

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, October 4

THE MAHANADI water dispute between Odisha and Chhattisgarh is back in the spotlight, with the Odisha government signalling that the two BJP-ruled states are moving closer to an “amicable solution”, even as the Opposition BJD has called this bid an “eyewash”.

Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi, who attended a meeting chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi on Thursday along with Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai and Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil, said a framework for resolving the dispute would be released “very soon”.

“We are gradually moving closer to a resolution. Alongside the legal process, administrative and political resolution pathways have also been expanded. A path to a resolution will be found keeping the interests of both states in mind. This resolution will serve as a model dispute resolution mechanism for other states too,” Majhi said.



Odisha CM Mohan Charan Majhi; Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai

ress,” Majhi said.

Sai also indicated that the two states were looking at a co-operative approach. “It is our life-giving river, intrinsically linked to the daily lives, agriculture, and culture of the people of both Chhattisgarh and Odisha. Our collective effort is to strengthen irrigation systems in both states through improved water management and to open the doors for new projects,” he posted on X.

For Odisha, the Mahanadi is more than a water-sharing dispute. The river is central to irrigation, drinking water, flood management, hydropower and the state’s broader negotiations with Chhattisgarh and the Centre.

At Thursday’s meeting, Majhi stressed that the Mahanadi was the “lifeline” of Odisha and said the state’s demand was that it receive an adequate share of the river’s water. Issues including irrigation, flood control, hydropower generation, drinking water and environmental concerns were discussed, he added.

The Mahanadi river originates near Pharsiya village in Chhattisgarh’s Raipur district and flows for about 851 km before merging with the Bay of Bengal. Of this, around 357 km lies in Chhattisgarh and 494 km in Odisha. The river flows through several districts in Odisha, while its wider basin covers 14 districts in the state.

The prospect of an early settlement of the Mahanadi dispute has political significance for the BJP, with panchayat and urban local body elections in Odisha scheduled for early next year.

The BJP is seeking to

contrast its approach with that of the Naveen Patnaik-led BJD, which governed Odisha when the dispute entered the legal process in 2016.

Bargarh BJP MP Pradeep Purohit accused the previous BJD government of deliberately keeping the dispute alive for political reasons.

“The BJD government didn’t want the dispute to be settled. They wanted to continue the dispute with Chhattisgarh and make it a political issue. That’s the reason they opted for the tribunal route even as the NDA government at the Centre initiated the process to resolve the matter amicably,” Purohit said.

Referring to the BJP’s governments in Odisha, Chhattisgarh and at the Centre, he said the “triple engine” dispensation would help resolve the dispute and secure Odisha’s “due share”.

The BJD, however, has questioned the substance of the latest talks and demanded that the decisions taken at Thursday’s meeting be made public.

Senior BJD leader and former minister Arun Kumar Sahoo said the meeting should not be reduced to an exercise aimed at the upcoming local body elections.

“Since there is a triple-engine government, the possibility of resolving the Mahanadi water dispute had increased. However, no urgency was seen towards resolving the issue. There has been no clarity as to whether the dispute will be resolved through a tribunal or through mutual discussions,” Sahoo said.

Chhattisgarh has maintained that, given the river’s catchment area in the state, it is within its rights to use Mahanadi water for its requirements.

TWO GANGSTERS CLAIM THEY ORDERED THE HIT: ‘WAS RUINING NEW GENERATION’

Punjabi influencer Mad Sandhu was set to enter Bigg Boss, says father

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Amritsar, October 4

PUNJABI LGBTQI+ social media influencer and makeup artist Mad Sandhu, who was murdered Saturday, was set to enter reality television show Bigg Boss as a wildcard contestant later this month, his friends and family said.



Mad Sandhu

The 30-year-old, whose real name was Madhusudan Sandhu, had built a following through his outspoken social media presence and was preparing for a major break in his career. He was to enter the Bigg Boss house on October 29, had completed the necessary paperwork, but had not made the information public, according to his father Bhopinder Singh. He was due to leave for Mumbai to take part in show on October 20, Bhopinder Singh, said.

On Sunday, the family cremated Sandhu. Sandhu died of gunshot wounds after two motorcycle borne assailants opened fire at him in Amritsar outside a car wash.

The killing sent shockwaves through Amritsar, with Sandhu’s family saying he had previously received online abuse and threats over his outspoken social media presence and his association with the LGBTQ community. He had also approached the police several times seeking protection,

his father said.

The murder took another turn after two gangsters separately claimed responsibility for the killing in social media posts. Gangster Goldy Dhillon was the first to claim responsibility, alleging that Sandhu was “ruining the new generation” and warning others who, according to him, promoted similar content on social media platforms.

Spain-based alleged gangster Lucky Johal subsequently disputed Dhillon’s claim and said he was responsible for the killing. Johal allegedly said the murder was not motivated by money or personal gain but by what he described as an attempt to protect Punjab’s culture and environment. He also threatened another influencer, Arupreet, whose content he claimed was similar to Sandhu’s.

Police have not established the veracity of either claim.

Amritsar Police Commissioner Harmanbir Singh Gill said, “police has obtained significant leads regarding the shooters and expressed confidence that arrests would follow.”

Sabndhu was eldest of three siblings. His father is a retired Punjab police sub-inspector, while his mother is a homemaker. The family originally lived on Sultanwind Road before moving to the Manawala area along the Amritsar-Jalandhar road.

Recalling his son’s childhood, Bhopinder Singh said Sandhu had expressed his individuality and gender identity from an early age. “From early childhood, he was different. We initially tried to change him, but later we understood that this is how God has made him,” he told The Indian Express.

The family later became supportive of Sandhu’s choices, his father said. “We never restricted him from living his life on his own terms.”

After completing Class 12, Sandhu trained as a makeup artist at a private institute and later established his own salon and makeup business in Amritsar. His work took him into the Punjabi entertainment industry, where he worked with actors and attended events in Mumbai.

His reported selection for Bigg Boss marked another milestone in his career. “He was sup-

posed to go to Bigg Boss as a wildcard entry,” his father said.

Sandhu’s public profile, however, had also made him a controversial figure at times. In April 2025, he publicly supported the cancellation of a Pride parade in Amritsar and appealed to members of the LGBTQ community not to turn the issue into a confrontation with wider society. “If society does not want to accept these things right now, or if it isn’t ready for them yet, then we shouldn’t force it,” he had said. He had also urged members of the community to take cultural and religious sentiments into consideration.

According to his family, Sandhu had faced hostility and threats from several people, including some Nihang factions. His father said Sandhu had informed police about the threats and submitted applications seeking protection, including one several months before his death. “He would just go to work, work to home, home to work,” his father said, describing the cautious routine Sandhu had adopted.

The family said they had received no ransom demand.

Police are now investigating the circumstances of the shooting, including the identity of the assailants and the competing social-media claims of responsibility.

Two held for passing info to Pak on defence movements: Assam CM

Press Trust of India
Guwahati, October 4

ASSAM CHIEF Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday said two persons, including a retired Army jawan who was re-employed on a contractual basis, were arrested for allegedly passing security-related information to Pakistan.

Based on information provided by the central agencies, the arrests were made, he said.

“Today, as per input of central agencies, Assam Police arrested two persons. One is a retired Army jawan but currently working on a contractual basis with the Army,” he said at a press conference. “It has been alleged that they were in touch with Pakistan and were giving information about Army movement. We will hand them over to the central agencies,” he said.

According to initial reports, the two were honey-trapped, the Chief Minister said.

Earlier on Sunday, an Assam Police statement said the STF has arrested a Bihar resident for alleged espionage-related activities. Initial investigation revealed his alleged involvement, including passing information concerning security forces to a Pakistani intelligence operative (PIO), it said.

The accused, Abhishek Kumar Singh, hails from Purba Champaran in Bihar.

3 yrs after Umesh Pal murder, accused traced to Bihar jail

Express News Service
Lucknow, October 4

THREE YEARS after advocate Umesh Pal and his two police security personnel were shot dead in Prayagraj’s Dhoomanjanj area, the Uttar Pradesh Police have traced a wanted accused carrying a reward of Rs 5 lakh to a jail in Bihar.

The police said the accused, Mohammad Arman, was allegedly associated with the gang of slain Prayagraj mafia figure Atiq Ahmed.

The Uttar Pradesh Police had been searching for Arman for the past three years after his alleged role in the murder of advocate Umesh Pal and his two security personnel emerged

during the investigation. Arman was allegedly riding the motorcycle on which another wanted accused, Guddu Muslim, was travelling as a pillion rider.

A senior police officer said they learnt about a week ago that Arman was lodged in a jail in Bihar’s Gaya district in connection with an old case. A police team subsequently verified the information with their counterparts in Gaya.

“We will approach the Prayagraj court on Monday seeking a B-warrant to bring him to Prayagraj in connection with the murder of Umesh Pal and his two security personnel,” the senior police officer said.

The police said that during the preliminary inquiry, they

learnt that after the murder of Umesh Pal and his two security personnel, Arman went to Gaya and surrendered before a court in connection with an old firing case after getting his bail cancelled. He has remained lodged in Gaya jail since then.

During the preliminary inquiry, police found that Arman, a native of Bihar, allegedly ran a food stall in Prayagraj’s Civil Lines area, where he came into contact with associates of Atiq Ahmed who visited the stall. Police said he later began working with Atiq Ahmed and expanded his business with money he allegedly earned through criminal activities.

Arman is among the six accused wanted in connection

with the murder of advocate Umesh Pal and his two police security personnel on February 24, 2023, in Prayagraj’s Dhoomanjanj area. Umesh Pal was attacked as he got out of his car near the entrance to his house. The assailants opened fire and hurled bombs at him and his two police bodyguards before fleeing the spot in a vehicle.

The police have so far gunned down four accused in the case in crossfire. Atiq Ahmed and his younger brother Ashraf, also accused in the case, were shot dead in April 2023 while they were in police custody, in an incident that was broadcast live on television.

Among the six wanted per-

sons are three members of gangster-turned-politician Atiq Ahmed’s family — his wife Shaista Parveen, sister-in-law Zainab Fatima (Ashraf’s wife) and elder sister Ayesha Noori.

Shaista Parveen carries a reward of Rs 50,000, while a reward of Rs 25,000 has been announced for Ayesha Noori. Two other wanted accused in the case, Guddu Muslim and Sabir, carry a reward of Rs 5 lakh each for information leading to their arrest.

Umesh Pal was a witness in the murder case of Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) MLA Raju Pal, who was shot dead in Prayagraj in 2005, in which Atiq Ahmed and his brother Ashraf were accused.

Office of Executive Engineer, Provincial Division, P.W.D. Sambhal

Short Term E-Procurement Notice Inviting Tenders

No. 3727 /E-Tender/26-27 Dated : 25-09-2026

On behalf of the Governor of UP, tenders for following work are invited by the Executive Engineer, Provincial Division, PWD, Sambhal online on website <http://etender.up.nic.in> from registered contractors from 05-10-2026 at 10.00 am to 12-10-2026 at 12.00 pm. Technical bid /Prequalification of tenders shall be opened on 12-10-2026 at 12:30 pm in office of undersigned by tender committee in presence of authorised representatives/bidders who wish to be present. Financial bid of the tenders” who qualify in technical bid shall be opened on date and time as specified by a notice in the office of undersigned. In case of Government holiday the required process shall be carried out on next working day.

Sl. No	DISTRICT	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs.in Lacs)	Bid Security (Rs.in Lacs)	Time of completion of the work (Including rainy season)	Cost of tender documents including GST (RS.)	Category of road contractor eligible
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
Due to excessive rainfall in the financial year 2026-27, the roads of the district have become extremely damaged, due to which short-term tenders are invited as below (Financial Year 26-27 Under Patch Repair Work)							
1	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Rajpura Under AE-1	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
2	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Pawansa Under AE-1	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
3	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Bahjoi Under AE-1	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
4	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Gunnour Under AE-1	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
5	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work on S.H/MDR/ODR Roads with Potholes Under AE-1	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
6	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Gunnour and Junavai Under AE-2	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
7	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Baniyakhera Under AE-2	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
8	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Sambhal Under AE-2	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
9	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work on S.H/MDR/ODR Roads with Potholes Under AE-2	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
10	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Sambhal Under AE-3	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
11	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Asmoli Under AE-3	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
12	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Pawansa Under AE-3	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category

13	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Rajpura Under AE-3	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
14	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work on S.H/MDR/ODR Roads with Potholes Road Under AE-3	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
15	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Rajpura Under AE-4	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
16	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Gunnour Under AE-4	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
17	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work with Potholes roads in Block Bahjoi Under AE-4	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category
18	Sambhal	Patch Repair Work on S.H/MDR/ODR Roads with Potholes Under AE-4	8.00	0.80	08 Months	677.00	“A”, “B”, “C” & “D” Road Work category

2. In PWD technical evaluation of tenders is to be done by Prahari Software. URL for Prahari is <http://wms.uppwd.gov.in/Prahari/> On opening of the website Prahari login page will open in which user type Contractor is to be selected. User name and password for login on Prahari shall be same as used for contractor’s registration on Chnakaya Portal. Bidders have to upload all the basic information and required document on Prahari as given in Prahari in detail. If a bidder does not upload information and document on Prahari technical evaluation of the tender shall not be done and the bidder will be responsible for that.

Rules/conditions & details of the tender are available at website <http://etender.up.nic.in>.

Executive Engineer
Provincial Division, PWD
Sambhal
For and on behalf of Governor of UP
05923-232577



कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
47वीं(वि/ यो) वृत्त,लोकनिधि,मुद्रादाबाद
प्रारूप:- <https://wms.uppwd.gov.in/>
ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट (अल्ट्राफास्ट) निविदा सूचना

दिनांक: 21.09.2026

पर्यांक: 1244(I)/(3WE/BL)-47/26

महानिदेश राज्यपाल महोदय उ3030 की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ऑनलाइन निविदाएं वेबसाइट <https://etender.up.nic.in> एवं प्रारूप <https://wms.uppwd.gov.in/Prahari> के माध्यम से दिनांक 05.10.2026 से दिनांक 16.10.2026 दोपहर 12:00 बजे से आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा की तकनीकी बिड दिनांक 16.10.2026 अपराह्न 02:00 बजे नगरीय समिति के सदस्यों द्वारा ऑनलाइन खोली जायेगी। कार्यालय बन्द होने अथवा छुट्टी होने की दशा में बिड उरली अत्र में सम्मान्यतर अगले कार्यदिनर में खोली जायेगी। इच्छुक एवं सम्बन्धित ठेकेदार विस्तृत जानकारी हेतु उपरोक्त वेबसाइट पर लॉगिन करें, कार्य का विवरण निम्नवत् है:-

क्र.सं	जम्मा राशि	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत ₹ (लाख)	घरोर घनराशि ₹ (लाख)	निविदा प्रारूप का मूल्य	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य सम्पादित करने वाले अधि. अधि. का पता	सम्बन्धित अधि. अधि. का पता	सम्बन्धित कु. अधि. का पता	निविदा हेतु पात्रता
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11
1.	बदामी	वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 में नये आवासीय भवनों की निर्माण के अन्तर्गत जम्मा राशि 206-27 में टाईप-3 के 06 नए आवासीय का निर्माण कार्य। (विस्तृत कार्य)	22.48 लाख +GST Extra	225 लाख	2354.00	08 माह	अधि. अधि. वि/ यो. वृत्त, लोकनिधि, मुद्रादाबाद	अधि. अधि. 47 वीं(वि/यो) वृत्त, लोकनिधि, मुद्रादाबाद	मुद्रादाबाद	लोकनिधि में निविदा कार्या हेतु ए. के.पी. में परीक्षण ठेकेदार नियुक्ति प्राप्त करने का कार्य।

शासनादेश संख्या 1/2016/3070/78-20-2018/2071 (22) दिनांक 03.01.2018 में निहित व्यवस्थापनार निविदा की तकनीकी बिड खोलने के उपरान्त निविदादाता द्वारा मूल अधिलेख व्यवस्थित रूप से विभाग /कार्यालय में प्रस्तुत किये जाने हैं। निविदादाता द्वारा मूल अधिलेख प्रस्तुत न किये जाने की दशा में निविदा प्राधिकार के अनुसार कार्यवाही की जायेगी।

(अनिल कुमार) अधिशासी अभियन्ता वि/ यो. वृत्त, लोकनिधि, मुद्रादाबाद

UPID-257389 Dt. 01/10/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

(संजीव कुमार सक्सेना) अधीक्षण अभियन्ता 47 वीं (वि/ यो) वृत्त, लोक निधि, मुद्रादाबाद

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोक निर्माण विभाग, अलीगढ़।
ई-टेंडरिंग निविदा सूचना

दिनांक : 29.09.2026

पर्यांक : 5523 /कैशियर (P.D.A.)-अनुप/2026-27

1. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्तें ऑनलाइन देखे जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 07.10.2026 से 26.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन देवी जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदाएं रूप से ऑनलाइन जमा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त टेक्निकल बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे खोली जायेगी।

2. निविदा केवल ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर जमा की जाये।

3. इच्छुक निविदादाता निम्नके पास डिजिटल डिवाइस (डिजिटल डिवाइस) (DSC) नहीं है, वह इसे निविदा जमा करने से पहले अखिल एजेंसी से प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

4. निविदादाता द्वारा दत्त जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. अधि. की जाणी है। भुगतान के समय लागू दरों पर जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. देय होगी।

5. बिड में मात्र कार्य का अनुमान अथवा वित्त वर्ष होना।

6. तकनीकी मूल्यांकन प्रदर्शन सॉफ्टवेयर द्वारा स्वयं किया जायेगा।

7. शासनादेश संख्या 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 दिनांक 23.05.2026 के अनुसार जमा करना आवश्यक है के अनुसार परफॉर्मन्स रिपोर्टिंग/अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मन्स रिपोर्टिंग प्रदान करना अनिवार्य है।

8. शासनादेश सं.17/2024/सां-113/23-1-2024-23-1099/113/2023 दिनांक 16.01.2024 एवं प्रमुख अधिनियम, उ3030 लोकनिधि, सार्वजनिक पात्रांक-388901/आरक्षण/पी.पी.सी./मूल-23-24 दि. 17.02.2024 के अनुसार उत्तर प्रदेश में समस्त भागों के अनुभवी में 05 वर्षीय अनुभूति का प्रमाणित किया जायेगा।

क्र.सं	जम्मा राशि	कार्य का नाम	निर्माण की अनुमानित लागत	अनुमानित लागत	कुल अनुमानित लागत (A+B)	घरोर घनराशि (लाख रु. में)	निविदा प्रारूप का मूल्य (रु. में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य सम्पादित करने वाले अधिशासी अभियन्ता का पता	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता का पता	मुख्य अभियन्ता का पता	टेकनीकी की श्रेणी /अ निर्धार पंजीकरण 1
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
1	अलीगढ़	हरदोई पायसी नगरपालिका क्षेत्र (अव. बिड) के क्षेत्र 0.000 से 15.750 में पंजीकरण एवं पंजीकरण का कार्य।	2637.00	65.92	2702.92	40.55	2000 + 300 + 54 Rs. 2354.00	14 Month	अधीशासी अभियन्ता प्रम.का. लोकनिधि, अलीगढ़	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता वृत्त, लोकनिधि, अलीगढ़	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता वृत्त, लोकनिधि, अलीगढ़	ए/ (सर्व कार्य में पंजीकृत)

1. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्तें ऑनलाइन देखे जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 07.10.2026 से 26.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन देवी जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदाएं रूप से ऑनलाइन जमा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त टेक्निकल बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे खोली जायेगी।

2. निविदा केवल ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर जमा की जाये।

3. इच्छुक निविदादाता निम्नके पास डिजिटल डिवाइस (डिजिटल डिवाइस) (DSC) नहीं है, वह इसे निविदा जमा करने से पहले अखिल एजेंसी से प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

4. निविदादाता द्वारा दत्त जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. अधि. की जाणी है। भुगतान के समय लागू दरों पर जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. देय होगी।

5. बिड में मात्र कार्य का अनुमान अथवा वित्त वर्ष होना।

6. तकनीकी मूल्यांकन प्रदर्शन सॉफ्टवेयर द्वारा स्वयं किया जायेगा।

7. शासनादेश संख्या 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 दिनांक 23.05.2026 के अनुसार जमा करना आवश्यक है के अनुसार परफॉर्मन्स रिपोर्टिंग/अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मन्स रिपोर्टिंग प्रदान करना अनिवार्य है।

8. शासनादेश सं.17/2024/सां-113/23-1-2024-23-1099/113/2023 दिनांक 16.01.2024 एवं प्रमुख अधिनियम, उ3030 लोकनिधि, सार्वजनिक पात्रांक-388901/आरक्षण/पी.पी.सी./मूल-23-24 दि. 17.02.2024 के अनुसार उत्तर प्रदेश में समस्त भागों के अनुभवी में 05 वर्षीय अनुभूति का प्रमाणित किया जायेगा।

(अनिल कुमार चौधरी) अधीक्षण अभियन्ता अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनिधि, अलीगढ़।

UPID-257383 Dt. 01/10/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता
अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोक निर्माण विभाग, अलीगढ़।
ई-टेंडरिंग निविदा सूचना

दिनांक : 29.09.2026

पर्यांक : 5523 /कैशियर (P.D.A.)-अनुप/2026-27

1. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्तें ऑनलाइन देखे जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 07.10.2026 से 26.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन देवी जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदाएं रूप से ऑनलाइन जमा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त टेक्निकल बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे खोली जायेगी।

2. निविदा केवल ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर जमा की जाये।

3. इच्छुक निविदादाता निम्नके पास डिजिटल डिवाइस (डिजिटल डिवाइस) (DSC) नहीं है, वह इसे निविदा जमा करने से पहले अखिल एजेंसी से प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

4. निविदादाता द्वारा दत्त जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. अधि. की जाणी है। भुगतान के समय लागू दरों पर जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. देय होगी।

5. बिड में मात्र कार्य का अनुमान अथवा वित्त वर्ष होना।

6. तकनीकी मूल्यांकन प्रदर्शन सॉफ्टवेयर द्वारा स्वयं किया जायेगा।

7. शासनादेश संख्या 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 दिनांक 23.05.2026 के अनुसार जमा करना आवश्यक है के अनुसार परफॉर्मन्स रिपोर्टिंग/अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मन्स रिपोर्टिंग प्रदान करना अनिवार्य है।

8. शासनादेश सं.17/2024/सां-113/23-1-2024-23-1099/113/2023 दिनांक 16.01.2024 एवं प्रमुख अधिनियम, उ3030 लोकनिधि, सार्वजनिक पात्रांक-388901/आरक्षण/पी.पी.सी./मूल-23-24 दि. 17.02.2024 के अनुसार उत्तर प्रदेश में समस्त भागों के अनुभवी में 05 वर्षीय अनुभूति का प्रमाणित किया जायेगा।

क्र.सं	जम्मा राशि	कार्य का नाम	निर्माण की अनुमानित लागत	अनुमानित लागत	कुल अनुमानित लागत (A+B)	घरोर घनराशि (लाख रु. में)	निविदा प्रारूप का मूल्य (रु. में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य सम्पादित करने वाले अधिशासी अभियन्ता का पता	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता का पता	मुख्य अभियन्ता का पता	टेकनीकी की श्रेणी /अ निर्धार पंजीकरण 1
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
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1. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्तें ऑनलाइन देखे जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 07.10.2026 से 26.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन देवी जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदाएं रूप से ऑनलाइन जमा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त टेक्निकल बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे खोली जायेगी।

2. निविदा केवल ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर जमा की जाये।

3. इच्छुक निविदादाता निम्नके पास डिजिटल डिवाइस (डिजिटल डिवाइस) (DSC) नहीं है, वह इसे निविदा जमा करने से पहले अखिल एजेंसी से प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

4. निविदादाता द्वारा दत्त जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. अधि. की जाणी है। भुगतान के समय लागू दरों पर जीएएम/पी.पी.सी. देय होगी।

5. बिड में मात्र कार्य का अनुमान अथवा वित्त वर्ष होना।

6. तकनीकी मूल्यांकन प्रदर्शन सॉफ्टवेयर द्वारा स्वयं किया जायेगा।

7. शासनादेश संख्या 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 दिनांक 23.05.2026 के अनुसार जमा करना आवश्यक है के अनुसार परफॉर्मन्

• LAW

The tussle over top posts in Central Armed Police Forces and IPS deputation

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, October 4

AN UNUSUAL controversy over the listing of contempt petitions in the Supreme Court has brought back into focus an older institutional battle. Who should occupy senior command positions in the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) — officers who have spent their careers in these forces, or IPS officers brought in on deputation?

What happened in court?

A Bench of Justices Ujjal Bhuyan and A S Chandurkar was hearing contempt petitions alleging non-compliance with the SC's May 23, 2025 judgment on career progression of CAPF cadre officers and IPS deputation. The case was scheduled for September 29, when the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) was to explain why, despite

the court's direction to progressively reduce IPS deputation, 46 IPS officers were brought into the forces. Although the case appeared in the cause list, by the time it came up for hearing, it had been struck off.

The Bench ordered it to be listed the next day and sought an explanation from the Registry. But on September 30, the contempt cases were instead placed before a specially constituted bench of Justices Manoj Misra and Bhuyan. The Registry said the Centre had requested the Chief Justice of India to have the contempt cases heard along with a separate petition, challenging the government's new CAPF law, since the government's defence in the two cases overlapped. Lawyers for CAPF officers objected, arguing that the cases were distinct.

This is only the latest development in a decade-long battle.

What is the dispute?

At its centre are five forces — Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Border Security Force (BSF), Central Industrial Security Force (CISF), Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) and Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB). Each has its own cadre of Group A executive officers, generally recruited as Assistant Commandants, who can rise through the hierarchy to senior command positions.

However, senior positions have traditionally also been filled through deputation, particularly by IPS officers. Recruitment rules earlier provided for 20% of DIG and 50% of IG posts to be filled via deputation.

CAPF cadre officers contend that with few posts at the very top, deputations further reduce promotional opportunities for those who have spent their careers within the forces.

This was one reason behind their battle

for Non-Functional Financial Upgradation (NFFU), which allows an officer who cannot be promoted for want of vacancies to nevertheless receive the financial benefits of a higher grade. The Delhi High Court ruled in favour of CAPF officers in 2015. The SC upheld it in 2019.

Why did the problem continue?

CAPF officers say NFFU has only partially addressed stagnation because it has been implemented through existing Recruitment Rules. These require an officer to spend a prescribed number of years in each rank before becoming eligible for the next grade. Thus, even when an officer gets a higher rank via NFFU, the clock for his next financial upgrade may not start until he is actually promoted.

Officers have thus sought Service Rules that provide for progression based on over-

all qualifying service.

On its part, the MHA has stated that CAPFs, given their operational role, could not be treated on a par with civilian Group A services. And that IPS officers provided an institutional link between the Centre and state police establishments when forces were deployed in states.

A paradox exists, too: the Centre has itself struggled to fill posts reserved for IPS officers because states have been reluctant to release them on central deputation.

What is the new CAPF Act?

Amid the court battle, the government brought the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill in Parliament this March, and it has since become law.

The Act creates an umbrella framework for Group A officers of the five CAPFs and empowers the Centre to frame rules govern-

ing recruitment, promotion, and service conditions.

Crucially, this rule-making power operates notwithstanding an inconsistent judgment, decree or order of a court, while rules framed under the Act prevail over inconsistent rules or government orders.

The legislation also says that 50% of IG posts and at least 67% of Additional DG posts will be filled through deputation, as will all Special DG and DG posts. Opposition MPs, however, argued that the legislation was effectively seeking to overcome the 2025 judgment.

CAPF officers have separately challenged the new law in the Supreme Court. Two overlapping proceedings — the contempt petitions over whether the government complied with the 2025 judgment, and a challenge to the 2026 law — are now to be decided by the same Bench.

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

How AI agents can be kept under control, where gaps are

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, October 4

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE company OpenAI is facing mounting scrutiny over the behaviour of its AI agents. Since September 23, the company has disclosed incidents in which its AI agents gained unauthorised access to Australian and US government websites, among others. It is now reviewing data to establish the extent of the breaches, reportedly costing more than \$500,000 a day.

Days after launching Dots, its new AI agent for enterprise use, OpenAI said it had informed over 100 organisations about potential unauthorised activity involving its agents. This comes months after OpenAI, Anthropic, Meta and Google admitted their agents had attempted to access websites in ways beyond their remit.

Agents independently complete routine tasks on a user's behalf. As companies give them greater autonomy, it becomes difficult for humans to watch their every step.

First, how do companies monitor AI agents?

Monitoring an AI agent means watching what it does while it is acting, rather than only checking the final result after the task is complete.

Dr Chetan Arora, Senior Lecturer in Software Engineering at Melbourne's Monash University, said current monitoring systems can miss four kinds of behaviour: slow, persistent attempts that never look dramatic enough to trigger an alarm; coordination between several agents that only becomes visible at the group level; an agent editing its own activity logs; and an agent using an authorised tool for a purpose that was never intended.

Commenting on OpenAI's disclosure that its AI agent had accessed the Australian Medicare website, he noted that the agent had been tasked with synthesising publicly available medical expenditure data. When it was denied access through one route, it tried another.

"The system should have treated 'was denied access, then tried a different way again' as a red flag, not routine background noise," Arora told *The Indian Express*. As an agent accesses more tools and systems, the scope of what it is able to do can gradually expand without anyone reassessing those powers.

"Nothing dramatic happens in any single moment. The agent just gradually ends up doing far more than anyone originally signed off on," Arora said.

What happens when several agents are acting at once?

Monitoring becomes harder when several agents can communicate or divide work among themselves.

Between May and June, hundreds of OpenAI agents being tested in an evaluation devised a way to communicate with each other to complete a task. By July, roughly 700 agents worked together in the breach, Arora said. "Individually, none looked suspicious, and the danger only emerged when you looked at the group as a whole," he said. The problem becomes harder still when different companies' agents interact with one another, Arora noted. If they begin negotiating, exchanging data or coordinating tasks across organisations, no single company may be able to see the full chain of activity.

Can AI monitor other AI?

Companies increasingly use AI to monitor other AI because humans cannot review the volume of activity manually. But the Hugging Face investigation found that roughly one in five agents had tried to tamper with their own activity records.

Researchers at METR, an AI safety research organisation, recently described a basic "per-action" monitor in which one AI system reviews an agent's proposed action before execution. Potentially harmful actions are paused for human review.

But METR itself found several ways such a system could fail: an action may fall outside the monitoring criteria, never be shown to the monitor, evade detection, or be incorrectly cleared by a human reviewer.

Monitoring only helps if companies can act on what it detects. That can mean blocking a proposed action before it is executed, pausing the agent, revoking its access to tools or systems, or escalating the decision to a human reviewer.

• HEALTH

Why India doesn't screen for its deadliest cancer



ANONNA DUTT

LUNG CANCER is the leading cause of cancer deaths in India. In 2024, it accounted for 10.9% of all cancer deaths, or 98,687 deaths — up from 75,031 in 2022, when it ranked fourth.

While lung cancer is one of the more difficult-to-treat types of the disease, another reason why it kills so many in India is that most patients reach hospitals in the late stages of the disease; by that time, the survival rate drops significantly. Yet, the government's screening programme at primary health centres looks only for the other common types: breast, oral and cervical.

Why is screening necessary?

Between 2022 and 2024, new lung cancer cases increased from 81,748, or 5.8% of all cancer cases, to 1.12 lakh, or 7.2%, taking it from fourth to third place in terms of incidence. Mortality, meanwhile, increased from 8.2% of all cancer deaths to 10.9%, shows the latest data from Global Cancer Observatory, a cancer statistics platform maintained by the World Health Organisation's International Agency for Research on Cancer (IARC).

This means there is a need to detect cases and provide treatment early, which is possible only if there is a screening programme for lung cancer.

But lung cancer is a disease that is not usually screened for — and has no easy way to screen for — it is usually diagnosed when it has already spread. "We have seen that 93% of all the lung cancer cases are diagnosed in advanced stages," Dr Abhishek Shankar, one of the authors of a "perspective" on lung cancer screening published by the IARC in September, told *The Indian Express*.

When diagnosed in late stages, the likelihood of surviving five years with lung

cancer is just 7% to 18%. This can increase to 80% if the disease is detected in the first stage. "LDCT (low-dose computed tomography)-based lung cancer screening can reduce the mortality from lung cancer by treating the disease at an early stage. While not a part of the government's programme, there should be efforts at institutional level to provide lung cancer screening," said Shankar.

Why is India not increasing screening?

There are several challenges, especially in a resource-constrained setting such as India.

COST OF SCREENING: The screening tests for breast, oral, and cervical cancer are all inexpensive and low-tech. Primary health centres perform clinical breast exams for breast cancer, a visual examination of the oral cavity for oral cancer, and usually a visual inspection under acetic acid for cervical cancer (the cancer cells turn white with acetic acid). If health workers detect something suspicious, they refer patients to higher centres.



Ling-Ling and Hsing-Hsing, the two giant pandas that arrived in the US in 1972 after US President Richard Nixon's visit to China. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

a polar bear to the King of Sweden — a rare gift that not just involved substantial logistics but also aimed to impress a fellow ruler by signifying one's own status.

Since the turn of the 20th century, the use of animals in diplomacy has combined both public engagement and media spectacle, with China's "panda diplomacy" a prominent example. Even Australia has used its unique fauna such as platypuses and koalas: as a gesture of solidarity during World War II, the country sent a platypus named Winston to the UK as a gift for Prime Minister Winston Churchill in 1943. The platypus died on the journey.



CT scan machines are not available at primary health centres.

Outside the net

Guidelines cover people with a history of smoking cigarettes, but there is no equivalent for India's large population of beedi-smokers.

• A 2024 statement by researchers said these smokers should be added to the high-risk category.

The LDCT test, however, is not an inexpensive one — and is likely to add to the government's budget if introduced as a screening tool. But an Indian Council of Medical Research study comparing the outcomes of LDCT, chest X-rays, and no screening in a hypothetical high-risk population found that although LDCT incurred the highest cost, it also provided the highest net monetary benefit.

AVAILABILITY OF LDCT: The test would require patients to travel to a higher centre for a screening test without experiencing any symptom. Even at centres that do currently have CT machines, LDCT is usually offered only when the doctor suspects something.

POLLUTION AT RISK: Unlike the West, a significant proportion of lung cancer in India occurs among non-smokers. Current global screening guidelines recommend that LDCT be performed only for people between the ages of 50 and 80 who have been smoking a pack of cigarettes a day for at least 20 years, but leave a large proportion of at-risk people in India out of the net. India also has a large population of beedi-

smokers and there is no equivalent screening criteria for them.

HIGH INCIDENCE OF TB: A concern often raised is whether the high prevalence of tuberculosis (TB) in India could lead to more false positives and excessive testing. But a pilot study from Mumbai published in 2021 said: "...even in a tuberculosis endemic country, LDCT picks up malignant lung nodules early and saves lives." Another 2025 study by AIIMS doctors also found that prevalence of TB posed no problem in lung cancer screening.

Who should be screened?

An expert opinion statement written by Indian researchers in 2024 said that people with a history of beedi smoking, exposure to second-hand smoke, biomass fuel, fumes, and domestic smoke should also be added to the high-risk category. Ambient air pollution may be an emerging threat.

"Screening cannot rely only on smoking history when millions are exposed to air pollution and occupational risks. Through the Indian Lung Screening Trial, we are generating Indian evidence on low-dose CT screening, while AIRCARE (Air Pollution and Cancer Research Ecosystem) is studying the contribution of air pollution and other environmental exposures to lung-cancer risk," said Shankar.

What is the role of measures to curb smoking?

While a significant proportion of lung cancers in India may not be linked to smoking, smoking cessation is still a very effective way to reduce risk of lung cancer. "In lung cancer patients, smoking cessation can significantly improve treatment outcomes," said Shankar.

According to Shankar, changing the way we warn people about the risks associated with smoking may also help in ensuring more people receive timely care. "Instead of simply saying that smoking kills, if the cigarette packets, for example, say that if you are over the age of 60 years and have been smoking for 20, you should get screened for cancer. This way, the people have actionable knowledge about what they need to do."

• CULTURE

From giraffes to pandas: Millennia-long history of animal diplomacy

Abhinav Chakraborty
New Delhi, October 4

AMONG THE most visible outcomes of the recent high-profile meeting between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping has been the loan of two giant pandas, Ping Ping and Fu Shuang, to an Atlanta zoo for 10 years.

This has a precedent — after US President Richard Nixon visited China in 1972, Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai gifted two pandas to the US as a goodwill gesture.

While Ping Ping and Fu Shuang are not visible to the public yet — they are in a month-long quarantine — they have put the spotlight on "animal diplomacy", a practice that goes back millennia.

History of animal diplomacy

Simply put, animal diplomacy refers to the strategic use of fauna — both common and rare species — as gifts, loans, or symbols in international relations. The practice dates back to Egyptian pharaohs sending African animals to ancient rulers in the Mediterranean. The Roman Empire, too, was known to display exotic species to demonstrate the extent of its territorial control.

A notable instance from ancient times mentions Egyptian queen Cleopatra's gift of a "cameleopard" — a mix of a camel and a leopard — which was most likely a giraffe.

In 802 CE (current era), Harun al-Rashid, caliph of the Abbasid Caliphate, gifted an elephant named Abul-Abbas to the Roman emperor Charlemagne. Another documented instance, this time from the 1600s, mentions the Russian tsar sending

Conservation debate

• Conservationists have raising concerns about placing rare and often vulnerable species in foreign habitats, especially through illegal trade.

• After the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES) came into force on July 1, 1975, animals, instead of being treated as permanent 'state gifts', are seen as scientific loans instead.

India's history

In the 1500s, Sultan Muzaffar II of Gujarat gifted a rhinoceros to King Manuel I of Portugal; it was transported across continents by sea. Upon its arrival, the one-horned animal created such a flutter across Europe that the renowned German painter Albrecht Dürer immortalised it on canvas (The Rhinoceros, 1515) despite never having seen one himself.

In the memoir *Jahangirnama*, there are multiple references to the fascination that Mughal emperor Jahangir (1569-1627 CE) held towards exotic species. He stationed an official in Goa specifically to buy such fauna from the Portuguese. One such acquisition was a North American turkey, "larger in body than a peahen and significantly smaller than a peacock".

In the post-independence era, India's first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru is said to have gifted a baby elephant named Indira to Japan after receiving numerous letters from Japanese children asking to see one.

Under Nehru, the Indian government later sent elephants to other countries such as the US, the Soviet Union, China, Turkey and Iran, among others.

Elephants have also come to India as "gifts": This was the case with Shankar and Vimbai, a pair of African elephants which arrived from Zimbabwe in 1996 and were kept at the Delhi Zoo. Although Vimbai, a female, died in 2001, Shankar's years-long solitary existence since then received much media attention. The male elephant finally died in October 2025.

An arguably standout example of ani-

mal diplomacy in recent years has been the India-Namibia collaboration in 2022 under "Project Cheetah". In subsequent years, two more batches of African cheetahs arrived from South Africa and Botswana.

In August 2026, India gifted five peacocks to the UN, to be housed at its European headquarters in Geneva. UN News termed it "a new twist on panda diplomacy".

Symbolism

Diplomacy has long involved exchanging gifts. What distinguishes this from other gifts is the use of a living being — albeit a non-human — as a political and cultural representative: animals such as giant pandas and koala bears are synonymous with their countries of habitat. The donor country or government can project soft power by bypassing formal channels and directly appealing to the recipient country's general public.

For instance, within the first year of the two giant pandas — named Ling-Ling and Hsing-Hsing — arriving from China in 1972, more than one million people visited the National Zoo in Washington, DC, where the duo was kept.

In political and philosophical terms, such an exchange signals that the donor trusts the recipient to prove a responsible host. In cases of rare or endangered species, this places the onus of stewardship on the recipient with the expectation that it will ensure conservation of the animal(s) in an alien habitat. So, the well-being and health of these animals become the barometer of the diplomatic relationship itself.

Brazilians head to first round of high-stakes, polarised polls

Reuters
Brasilia, Sao Paulo, October 4

BRAZILIANS HEAD to the polls on Sunday in the first round of a narrowly split election after a campaign dominated by corruption scandals, economic anxiety and accusations of US meddling.

Lefist President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, 80, is seeking a fourth term, while Senator Flavio Bolsonaro, the 45-year-old son of former President Jair Bolsonaro, hopes to return his father's right-wing movement to power.

A victory for the senator would extend a wave of wins across Latin America by right-wing candidates aligned with US President Donald Trump, while Lula's reelection could create a headache for Washington, which has clashed with his government over trade and security.

The campaign has offered meager policy debate, as both leading candidates skipped the major TV debates.

If no candidate wins more than 50% of valid votes, the top two will face off on October 25. Surveys show Lula and Flavio Bolsonaro polling roughly even in a likely runoff.

HEAD OF PRESIDENTIAL COUNCIL SAYS COUNTEROFFENSIVE IS UNDERWAY

Yemen launches offensive to seize all areas from Iran-backed Houthis

Mohammed Ghabari, Timour Azhari & Eman Abouhassira
Aden, October 4

YEMEN'S SAUDI-BACKED, internationally recognised government said on Sunday it was launching a major military campaign to recapture all areas of the country controlled by the Iran-backed Houthis.

The Houthis' armed forces would press the offensive "until the country is liberated from the grip of the terrorist militia," Yemeni President Rashad al-Alimi said in a televised address. A military spokesman later called on the Houthis to lay down their weapons.

The Houthis, known formally as Ansar Allah, have held Yemen's capital Sanaa and vast parts of the northwest, where most of the population live, since 2014. They have so far withstood a series of attacks over the years by Saudi Arabia, the UAE and their Western allies, and have updated their weaponry with the help of Iran.

The movement launched a surprise offensive last month which captured the strategic Bab



Members of the Saudi-backed Yemeni government forces ride on a military pick-up vehicle. FILE/REUTERS

el-Mandeb strait and some 150 km (90 miles) of coast on the Red Sea in a matter of weeks, giving the Houthis new leverage over the international shipping route.

That advance also opened a new front in the wider US-Israeli war launched in February against Iran, to which Tehran's responses included choking oil shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, to the other side of the Arabian Peninsula.

As the Yemeni government,

known as the Presidential Leadership Council, made its announcement, the Houthis said they had launched ballistic missiles and drones at Saudi Aramco sites in Riyadh and the Khurais area of Saudi Arabia.

They claimed the attacks caused major fires and were in response to what they said were 50 Saudi-led air and missile strikes in Yemen in the past 12 hours.

There was no immediate

confirmation from Saudi Arabia. Alimi said the decision to launch the counteroffensive came after all chances of de-escalating the conflict had been exhausted.

He thanked Saudi Arabia for its support and called on Yemen's regional allies and international partners to support PLC forces and institutions.

Regional and western officials had told Reuters earlier this week that Saudi Arabia and its Yemeni allies were planning to launch an assault on the Houthis, with the Saudis leading aerial combat and Yemeni forces fighting on the ground.

The US is already providing intelligence to support Riyadh's operations in Yemen, while some regional and European nations are providing mainly defensive military aid to the kingdom, six people with knowledge of the Saudi preparations told Reuters.

The United States' war on Iran has decimated a layer of Iranian military and political leadership, but has also entangled Washington in a new engagement in the Middle East and depleted crucial military hardware.

Yemen has been mired in conflict for years, with an array of local armed groups and factions backed by competing regional and international actors.

After a popular uprising that was part of the Arab Spring movements in 2011, the Houthis, an armed group of Zaidi Shi'ite Muslims, captured Sanaa. The Saudi-backed PLC, which is also recognised by the United Nations, has since the Houthi takeover controlled the south and east of the country, based in the former South Yemen capital of Aden.

Saudi Arabia entered Yemen's civil war in 2015 at the head of an Arab coalition in support of the PLC, but failed to defeat the Houthis.

A truce agreed between the warring parties in 2022 largely held until this year, when the Houthis launched missile and drone attacks on Saudi shipping and oil infrastructure in a spill-over from the Iran war. The Houthis have maintained the initiative on the ground since seizing control of the Bab el-Mandeb Strait in their lightning offensive last month that saw government forces collapse. REUTERS

Merz unveils fresh military aid in Kyiv, says Germany won't be intimidated

Reuters
Kyiv, October 4

GERMANY WILL not be intimidated into dropping its support for Ukraine, Chancellor Friedrich Merz said on Sunday as he announced a further €1 billion (\$1.1 billion) in military aid during a visit to Kyiv marked by Russian drone attacks.

Air-raid sirens and explosions rang out repeatedly across the Ukrainian capital as Merz and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy visited a memorial to soldiers killed during the four-year-old war, as well as the Academy of Sciences where at least two people died in a drone strike last week.

Russia has escalated its drone attacks on Kyiv and other cities in recent weeks.

Speaking at a press conference alongside Zelenskyy, Merz said Moscow was trying to break the morale of the Ukrainian people, and announced €350 million for repairs in the energy sector. He said Germany remained Ukraine's strongest



German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy pay tribute at the memorial of fallen Ukrainian soldiers in Kyiv on Sunday. AP

backer. "We do this not only to protect Ukraine's territorial integrity; we do it deeply in our own interest, for it is a matter of Europe's security," Merz said.

"This demonstrates that we will not be intimidated," he said.

Russia has said accusations of hybrid warfare are baseless and the result of anti-Russian hysteria.

Officials said executives

from German companies, who travelled with Merz, had signed 16 agreements with the Ukrainian government and businesses worth roughly €6.5 billion.

Ukraine inked an agreement with Germany's Diehl Defence for the supply of IRIS-T air defence missiles, as well as a deal for radar equipment with Hensoldt and for jet drone interceptors with Quantum Systems.

Pro-Ukraine coalition wins Latvian polls

Riga: Latvian lawmakers on Sunday planned to begin negotiations to form a new government following a parliamentary election in which pro-Ukraine PM Andris Kulbergs's four-party coalition emerged with 35% of the vote.

A political crisis in May over the handling of stray drones suspected of coming from Ukraine brought down the governing coalition that had been under strain over several other issues.

The parliament, or Saeima, then approved the coalition led by Kulbergs of the centrist United List party, previously in opposition. Latvia, like its Baltic neighbours Lithuania and Estonia, strongly supports Ukraine in its fight against Moscow's invasion. It borders both Russia and Moscow-allied Belarus. AP



The flydubai aircraft in which co-pilot attacked the captain and tried to crash the plane lands at Ben Gurion International Airport. FILE

UAE shared details about flydubai flight with Israel: Officials

Melanie Lidman & Samy Magdy
Tel Aviv, October 4

AUTHORITIES in the United Arab Emirates shared with Israel a list of passengers and crew ahead of the flydubai flight on which a pilot attempted to seize control of the Israel-bound aircraft and crash it, regional officials said Sunday, raising new questions over how the attacker evaded detection.

While the investigation continues, preliminary details about the incident have highlighted several major security lapses. Officials already have said the Omani co-pilot had been barred from flying by his own country because of concerns about his extremist views. It also remains unclear how a citizen of Oman, an Arab country that has no diplomatic relations with Israel, was allowed to fly a plane load of Israelis to Tel Aviv.

The UAE, which is leading the investigation, said the co-pilot attacked the flight's captain with the cockpit's crash ax and tried to take control of the plummeting plane in a "terrorist attack" Wednesday.

The regional officials said Emirati authorities had shared information about the passen-

Police investigate flydubai co-pilot's Australia links

AUSTRALIAN POLICE said on Sunday that authorities there were investigating the "links to Australia" of a flydubai co-pilot who attacked the captain on a flight to Tel Aviv.

The co-pilot of the flydubai flight 1073, which was bound for Israel from Dubai, attacked the pilot with an emergency crash axe, the United Arab Emirates prosecutor general said on Saturday, calling the incident a "terrorist attack".

The co-pilot of the flydubai jet was identified as Hammam al-Hammami, an Omani national, two sources with knowledge of the investigation said. REUTERS

gers and crew, including their nationalities. Israel hadn't raised red flags on any passenger or member of the crew, said the officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to reporters about the probe. AP

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Trump names Jay Clayton to lead a new federal AI task force



National intelligence director Jay Clayton. AP

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Sunday tapped Jay Clayton, his director of national intelligence, to lead a new government task force on artificial intelligence. Trump is calling it the "Super Intelligence Force," because he has tried to rebrand AI as "super intelligence." The announcement comes after Trump hosted top executives of AI companies at the White House last week and said they had signed a voluntary accord that would effectively self-police the development of the technology. The task force will coordinate the federal effort "to ensure that America continues to lead the World in Super Intelligence, which many say is bigger than the Industrial Revolution, and the Internet, and will protect the interests, and improve the lives, of all Americans," Trump in a post on social media Sunday. AP

NORWAY

2 people killed after shooter opens fire

TWO PEOPLE were killed and another seriously injured Sunday when a shooter opened fire on a hunting party in southern Norway, police said. The suspect was arrested at the scene and is not believed to be part of the hunting party, police said in a statement. The injured victim was flown to a hospital for treatment. The shooting occurred near Halden, which is about 96 kilometres from Oslo and near the Swedish border. AP

AFGHANISTAN

Gold mine collapse kills five miners

A GOLD mine collapse has killed five miners in Afghanistan's northern Takhar province, local authorities said Saturday. The mine is located in the Shah Mastan area of the province's Chah Ab district, said Qari Naqibullah Masroor, spokesman for Takhar police command. He gave no other details. The exact circumstances of how they became trapped were not immediately clear. Mine collapses are frequent in Afghanistan. AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

NEPAL

Nepali Congress' 15th general convention starts

THE MAIN opposition Nepali Congress party's 15th general convention kicked off at Tundikhel Open Ground in Kathmandu on Sunday. More than 7,000 general convention representatives from across the country are participating in the convention. Speaking at a press meet on the eve of the convention on Saturday, party spokesperson Devraj Chalise said that the convention would seek to strengthen inner party democracy while connecting it with the younger generation. PTI

SRI LANKA

Navy arrests nine Indian fishermen

THE SRI Lanka Navy has arrested nine Indian fishermen and seized their trawler for allegedly poaching in its territorial waters, according to an official statement. The fishermen were arrested on Saturday for having crossed the International Maritime Boundary Line in Sri Lankan waters south of Delft Island, Jaffna, the island nation's navy said in a statement. "During the operation, one Indian fishing trawler was seized, while nine Indian fishermen on board were taken into custody by SLNS Samudura," it said. PTI

Imran Khan's party PTI begins long march after talks with govt fail

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, October 4

PAKISTAN'S FORMER PM Imran Khan's party on Sunday began its long march towards Islamabad from Khyber Pakhtunkhwa following the failure of negotiations with the government.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa CM Sohail Afridi set off from Lakki Marwat's Gandhi Chowk, saying he would announce his next course of action on Thursday, October 8, when Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf's convoy reaches Khairabad. AP

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa President Junaid Akbar Khan was accompanying Afridi, the party said. According to the party, Afridi is leading the march from Gandhi Chowk, where he will join the participants and proceed towards the next destination.

Addressing participants of the PTI's long march at Gandhi Chowk in Lakki Marwat, Afridi said his PTI government would not accept any policy detrimental to the interests of the Pashtun people, asserting that only Imran Khan's "vision and policies" would be followed in the province.

• JOINING THE BELLBIRD AT THE TOP OF THE VOLUME CHARTS, THE RESEARCHERS FOUND, IS ANOTHER BRAZILIAN SPECIES: THE RED-LEGGED SERIEMA

High decibel: These birds are louder than elephants, jackhammers and chainsaws

Taylor Mitchell Brown
October 4

DEEP IN the Serra do Mar mountains of Brazil, a curious call echoes from high in the jungle canopy. The sound is practically deafening, a loud metallic pang that cuts through the forest's thick foliage.

The bare-throated bellbird, which produces such calls to attract female mates, is no larger than a dove. And yet his song is louder than a jackhammer or a chainsaw. It's louder than an elephant's trumpet.

It is, according to a new scientific study, one of the loudest birdsongs ever recorded.

"They can even exceed ele-

phants and lions and wolves and bison," said João Menezes, an evolutionary biologist and lead author of the study, recently published in the journal Evolution.

Joining the bellbird at the top of the volume charts, the researchers found, is another Brazilian species: the red-legged seriema.

The two birds now join a previously identified bellbird species as the loudest avians known to science.

The study also uncovered a few of the anatomical traits that allow these birds to belt such powerful songs, answering many of the questions underlying the mysteries of birdsong.

"This new study is by far the largest cross-species comparison of sound amplitude in birds," said Gonçalo Cardoso, an ornithologist at the University of Porto who was not involved with the research. "This is just the tip of the iceberg."

The new work focuses specifically on amplitude, a measure of the height of a sound wave, which helps determine how far a sound can travel. Amplitude is a major component of loudness and is crucial to our perception of sound.

"Until recently, it was very impractical to go out into the field and measure amplitude," Dr. Menezes said.

To accurately measure am-



The call of the red-legged seriema, scientists found, is amplified by the length of its neck and shape of its beak. NYT

plitude, researchers have to be able to distinguish one bird from many and pinpoint its exact distance from where they are re-

cording. Because of that difficulty, birdsong amplitudes have remained a black box for researchers. Even the Canada

goose, one of the most well-known and easily identifiable bird species alive today, has not had its amplitude measured, according to Dr. Menezes. "It's kind of stepping into a whole new world," he said.

In the new work, Dr. Menezes and his colleagues used two tools to measure birdsong in the wild. One of them, a range finder, is the same laser device golfers use to measure the distance to holes on a course. The other instrument, a sound level meter, allows researchers to pinpoint whichever bird is making the call, isolating it from background noise and other birds.

The researchers began their work early in the Covid-19 pan-

demic, when lockdowns kept quiet streets in Amherst, Mass.

"It was just this wonderful time where you can walk outside unmolested, no trucks, no buses, and get beautiful, scintillatingly clear recordings," said Jeff Podos, a behavioral ecologist and bird expert at the University of Amherst and a co-author of the study. The team then moved on to the Atlantic Forest, jungles and savannas of Brazil, where there is a much greater diversity of bird species.

In total, the researchers documented 123 birdsong amplitudes, creating a database they could plumb for insights about what enables the birds to sing such different songs.

They found that amplitude varied widely across species, with the softest songs coming from hummingbirds, whose tunes registered around 50 decibels — similar to the sound of moderate rainfall.

But the bare-throated bellbird and the red-legged seriema stood out from the crowd.

The bellbird lives in the Atlantic Forest of Brazil, while the seriema, which is about as tall as a crane, lives on the country's savanna. Bellbirds have a distinct metallic chirp, while seriemas sing elaborate, melancholic songs that have been the subject of poetry. Both birds produced tunes that registered between 121 and 122 decibels. NYT

‘INDIA IS WITHIN STRIKING DISTANCE OF 8% GROWTH’

Domestic capacity, reforms key amid global uncertainty, says Das

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, October 4

AMID SUSTAINED shocks and global uncertainties, India seeks to emphasise on sustained structural reforms, building domestic capacity and competence in areas where there is large import dependence, and continuously focusing on fiscal, monetary, macroeconomic and macrofinancial stability, Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary-2 to the Prime Minister, said on Sunday.

Das further said that the country stands at a pivotal moment in its development journey and “a leap to Viksit Bharat 2047 is in the realm of realisation”, adding that India is within a striking distance of 8% growth.

“There can never be a moment where you can say that, whatever I have done is sufficient. There is always something more to do but in the current context... The emphasis has been to build our domestic capacity, competence in areas where we are largely import dependent. So, whether it is energy or fertiliser and so many other areas, the government is now focusing on such areas... the focus of the government is also to take measures and to develop long-

term capacity in areas where again we are dependent on imports,” Das said while answering a question on day two of the three-day Kautilya Economic Conclave organised by the Ministry of Finance and the Institute of Economic Growth.

Calling for strategic self-reliance, Das said self-reliance or Atmanirbharta should not mean isolation. “Rather, it stands for building stronger domestic capabilities while remaining integrated with global markets and concluding more free trade agreements,” he said.

Das underlined that India’s real GDP grew by an “impressive 7.8%” in Q1 of 2026-27, adding that if the period from July-September 2025-26 to April-June 2026-27 is taken into account, “real GDP growth in India just exceeds 8%”. “This resonates with my statement to *Financial Times London* a few months ago that India is within a striking distance of 8% growth,” he said.

Reforms undertaken over the past decade were not one-off measures but were designed to build buffers that would help the economy absorb disruptions and recover rapidly, he said. “India’s resilience is not accidental. It is the outcome of broad and



Shaktikanta Das said India must harness the artificial intelligence revolution to sustain high growth. MINISTRY OF FINANCE

mutually reinforcing reforms,” he said. The former Reserve Bank of India governor cited flexible inflation targeting, the introduction of the goods and services tax, fiscal prudence, the push for digital payments and banking sector reforms among such measures.

On the external front, Das said India’s financial sector and prudent management had also emerged as strong pillars of economic growth. External sector indicators have remained broadly resilient, supported by export diversification, free trade

agreements, a sustained surplus in services trade and steady inward remittances, he said.

Going ahead, Das said India must harness the artificial intelligence (AI) revolution to sustain high growth. “India’s AI strategy rests on two complementary pillars. First, sovereign AI capability through investments in indigenous foundation models, high-performance computing infrastructure, semiconductor developments and robust innovation ecosystem,” he said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

DEA secy Thakur bats for greater macro stability

New Delhi: India’s macroeconomic stability is helping the country compete for increasingly scarce and expensive global capital, with fiscal consolidation, price stability, a stronger banking system and steady reforms strengthening investor confidence, Economic Affairs Secretary Anuradha Thakur said on Sunday.

Speaking at the Kautilya Economic Conclave, she said the cost of capital was rising as governments borrow heavily and investors demand greater compensation for inflation, fiscal uncertainty and duration risk. Against this backdrop, maintaining macroeconomic credibility has become increasingly important for economies seeking to attract investment.

“Our macroeconomic choices have been deliberate,” Thakur said, pointing to the government’s fiscal consolidation and other indicators of economic stability. FE

RBI may hike rates: Why inflation, crude & global rates are forcing its hand

Akash Mandal & George Mathew
Mumbai, October 4

AFTER NEARLY two years of monetary accommodation, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) appears poised to begin withdrawing policy support, with the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) expected to take the first steps at its October 7 meeting.

Most analysts expect the RBI to raise policy rate, or the repo rate, by 25 basis points (bps) to 5.50%, potentially marking the beginning of a more aggressive rate-hiking cycle. Such a move would push up borrowing costs across the economy, raising interest rates on deposits as well as loans, including personal, home, and vehicle loans. The MPC could also revise its projections for GDP growth and inflation, with both likely to be higher than previously estimated.

Why the rate hike now?

RBI’s August MPC minutes had already indicated such a move. Since then, incoming data on domestic inflation and growth, coupled with a global backdrop of higher US interest rates, bond yields and commodity prices, has left little room for the RBI to wait. The US Federal Reserve recently raised its policy rate by 25 bps to 3.75-4%. US benchmark yields have also risen sharply, by 49 bps to 5.27% and by 25 bps to 7.21% over the past month.

“After holding through 2026, the RBI faces growing pressure to raise rates at its October review, and a 25-basis point hike to 5.50% is now a real possibility, which would be the first increase since early 2023,” said Rajeev Sharan, Head of Research, Brickwork Ratings.

“In our baseline, the RBI hikes by 25 bps in each of October and December to a terminal rate of 5.75%, though there is some risk of a one-and-

● INFLATION VIEW

● Price pressures reflect elevated energy prices, rising food inflation and increasingly visible *El Niño*-related disruptions

● CareEdge Ratings projects retail inflation to peak at 6% in the third quarter and average around 5% in FY27

done hike,” Nomura Global Market Research said. “Market expectations are now converging on two themes: removal of liquidity and RBI rate hikes,” said Pranjul Bhandari, Chief India Economist, HSBC Global Investment Research.

There are also analysts who expect the RBI to hold rates. “The RBI may not move rates in October, but it may move the market’s expectations. The policy decision could remain unchanged even as the policy message becomes incrementally cautious,” said Sneha Pandey, Fund Manager, Fixed Income at Quantum AMC.

Broad-based inflation

Retail inflation is showing signs of becoming more broad-based domestically. Price pressures reflect elevated energy prices, rising food inflation and increasingly visible *El Niño*-related disruptions. Maharashtra has declared drought in about 265 of its 358 talukas, covering nearly 74% of the state. The Union Agriculture Minister has also flagged possibility of drought in other states such as Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan.

Lower reservoir levels, weather-related disruptions and higher energy prices are adding to inflationary pressures. Reservoir levels are about 20% below last year’s, which could also affect the rabi crop. The possibility of *El Niño* conditions extending into 2027 remains a key monitorable.

● BRIEFLY

India-Canada trade talks enter fifth round

New Delhi: The chief negotiators of India and Canada will begin the fifth round of negotiations for the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) in Ottawa from October 5, with an aim to conclude the talks by the end of this calendar year, an official said. The five-day talks may end on October 9. The fourth round of negotiations concluded here on September 18. The talks are moving at a faster pace. PTI

OPEC+ to keep Nov oil output targets steady

London/Moscow: OPEC+ agreed to keep oil production targets steady for November at a meeting on Sunday, it said, in line with expectations that further

Besides, global headwinds continue to weigh on the outlook. The West Asia conflict and Russia-Ukraine war have added to economic uncertainty, while crude oil prices have risen above \$100 a barrel, raising concerns over imported inflation and the impact on external balance.

CareEdge Ratings projects retail inflation to peak at 6% in the third quarter and average around 5% in FY27. Weather-related risks and volatile energy prices remain the key risks, it said. Retail inflation which was at 4.82% in August, is expected to be around 5.5%. It could remain above 5% for nearly three quarters. With WPI/PPI inflation around 10%, elevated crude oil prices and the possibility of a strong *El Niño*, markets have begun pricing in the prospect of rate hikes.

Impact of rate hike

If repo rate rises, lending and deposit rates are expected to increase in near-term. Loans linked to external benchmarks — particularly those directly linked to repo rate — will see the impact almost immediately. Borrowers with such loans could see their equated monthly instalments rise, increasing their repayment burden.

Interest rates on loans linked to the marginal cost of funds-based lending rate (MCLR) are also likely to rise. Banks have the flexibility to revise MCLR-based lending rates depending on funding costs, liquidity conditions and deposit mobilisation.

RBI’s likely shift to a rate-hike cycle comes as the economy is facing a mix of rising inflationary pressures, elevated crude oil prices, tighter global financial conditions and strong domestic growth. The move will help contain demand and inflation expectations, but could weigh on consumption and investment if borrowing costs remain elevated for extended period. FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

output policy adjustments are unlikely until next year. Seven core members of the group comprising the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and allies including Russia made the decision for November in a brief online meeting on Sunday. REUTERS

SAIL, NMDC asked to explore overseas mines

New Delhi: The Steel Ministry has asked its undertakings, SAIL and NMDC, to explore mineral assets abroad to help secure long-term raw material requirements and support input costs, an official said. SAIL is India’s largest public sector steel-making entity, and NMDC is the country’s leading iron ore player. On a query on whether steel PSUs have been asked to look for mining assets abroad, the senior ministry official replied in the affirmative. PTI

Q2 FMCG growth hits 6-quarter high: Bizom

Viveat Susan Pinto
Mumbai, October 4

INDIA’S FAST-MOVING consumer goods (FMCG) market saw its sharpest growth in six quarters in the July-September period (Q2FY27), supported by price hikes and sustained momentum in rural markets, according to Bizom data shared exclusively with FE.

Overall FMCG value growth rose to 8.6% in the three months ended September 30, 2026, up from 6.8% in the preceding April-June period (Q1). Q2 growth was also higher than the 6.2% value growth registered in the corresponding quarter last year. Bizom tracks value growth across FMCG categories in 10 million retail outlets. It does not report volume growth.

10.6% value growth in Q2, nearly double the 5.8% growth in urban markets. Like overall FMCG growth, rural growth is also the highest in six quarters, Bizom data shows. In the June quarter, rural markets had posted 9% growth compared with just 2.3% seen in urban centres. A year earlier, rural growth stood at 6.7%, compared with 5.4% recorded in urban areas.

While the latest data highlights the continuing strength of rural consumption, Bizom says that August and September numbers, in particular, point to an improvement in urban areas. Urban value growth in August touched 6.4% from 2.9% seen in July. This improved even further to 8.2% in September, narrowing the gap with rural, which stood at 10.3% for the month. FE

Jio Platforms IPO likely this month at \$146 bn valuation

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, October 4

DIGITAL SERVICES major Jio Platforms is likely to get listed by the end of this month at an enterprise valuation of \$143-146 billion or above Rs 12 lakh crore, sources tracking the development said.

Jio Platforms IPO is touted as India’s largest public offer at an estimated size of \$3.8 billion.

The company has concluded overseas roadshows and is expected to file final papers with market regulator SEBI for the initial public offering in the week starting October 12, banking and other sources who did not wish to be

identified told PTI.

“Based on interest received from overseas roadshows, Jio Platforms is likely to list at a base enterprise valuation of \$143-146 billion or at least Rs 12 lakh crore by end of this month,” one of the banking sources said.

An email sent to Jio Platforms seeking comments based on available information did not elicit any reply.

The overseas roadshows held in the US, UK, Dubai, Hong Kong and Singapore were led by Jio Platforms Managing Director and Reliance Jio Chairman Akash Ambani and Reliance Retail Ventures Limited Executive Director Isha Ambani.

Why Tata Sons listing row has put RBI board roles into focus

George Mathew
Mumbai, October 4

THE TATA Sons battle over compliance with the Reserve Bank of India’s (RBI) norms, including the possibility of listing the group’s holding company, has taken on another dimension. Two of its key directors, N Chandrasekaran and Venu Srinivasan, have also served on the RBI’s Central Board, albeit at different points in time.

Chandrasekaran was appointed a non-official director on the RBI Central Board in March 2016 — much before he was appointed as Tata Sons Chairman in January 2017 — and remained on it until March 2022. He was among the government-nominated directors on the powerful central board.

Srinivasan joined the RBI Central Board much later. In June 2022, the government nominated him as a part-time, non-official director for four years. He was on the RBI Central Board board till August 2026. That’s the period when the RBI was vetting Tata Sons’ application for deregistration as a Non-Banking Financial Company in the Upper Layer (NBFC-UL).

Therefore, the two men did not overlap on the RBI Central Board, with Chandrasekaran’s tenure preceding Srinivasan’s. Yet both went on to serve on the Tata Sons board and are now central figures in the company’s bitter internal dispute.

“That coincidence of institutional roles is significant, even if it does not by itself establish any conflict of interest or impropriety,” said a source. The RBI took nearly two and a half years to decide on Tata Sons’ application for deregistration.

However, a Tata Sons official said Chandrasekaran’s

● TATA-RBI TIES

N CHANDRASEKARAN and Venu Srinivasan have served on the RBI’s Central Board, albeit at different points in time

CHANDRASEKARAN SERVED served on the RBI Central Board from 2016 to 2022, while Srinivasan joined it in June 2022

BOTH WENT on to serve on the Tata Sons board and are now central figures in the company’s bitter internal dispute



term on the RBI board had ended before the RBI began its exercise to classify it as an upper-layer NBFC. He finished his term in March 2022 and all this at Tata Sons started in September 2022, the official said.

Srinivasan did not respond to a mail from *The Indian Express*.

The classification as an NBFC-UL put the company on a path towards listing. Tata Sons subsequently sought to surrender its regulatory registration in an attempt to avoid the listing requirement. On September 11, the RBI rejected the application and directed the company to comply with the applicable regulatory requirements. The decision effectively put Tata Sons back on the road to a public listing.

Tata Sons listing

On September 17, the Tata Sons board decided to proceed with steps towards listing. Four directors — Venu Srinivasan, Harish Manwani, Anita M George and Saurabh Agrawal — supported the move, while Noel Tata opposed it. The board also backed a fresh five-year term for Chandrasekaran, de-

spite Noel Tata’s opposition.

In July 2025, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, unanimously passed resolutions that the company should remain unlisted and the same was duly communicated to Tata Sons for necessary action.

The Tata Sons board had already considered the matter of public listing and reached a unanimous conclusion in March 2024, under the guidance of late Ratan Tata, and had resolved that it should remain unlisted. Venu Srinivasan and Chandrasekaran were party to these board decisions at a time when Ratan Tata was the guiding force. Noel Tata joined Tata Sons board in November 2024.

For Srinivasan, the position is consequential. He is not merely a Tata Sons director. He is also a trustee of Tata Trusts and a nominee of the Trusts on the Tata Sons board. The Trusts collectively own 66% of Tata Sons. Yet Srinivasan has emerged as a supporter of the listing, while Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, has opposed it. FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Green Energy Corridor III: Tackling India’s renewable power bottleneck

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, October 4

LAST WEEK (September 30), the Centre approved the third phase of the Green Energy Corridor (GEC), with an outlay of Rs 1.86 lakh crore, aimed at facilitating the evacuation of up to 135 gigawatts (GW) of renewable energy (RE). Evacuation refers to the process of transferring electricity generated from renewable sources to the places where consumers are located.

This comes as India’s rapidly expanding RE capacity is posing a growing challenge to its power grid: ensuring that electricity generated from renewable sources can be evacuated and absorbed by the grid when and where it is needed.

ment programme aimed at building dedicated transmission infrastructure to integrate large-scale RE, such as solar and wind power, into the national power grid.

Green Energy Corridor programme

For the first time, GEC includes a dedicated battery energy storage component, with provisions for deploying 50 gigawatt-hours (GWh) of Battery Energy Storage Systems.

Energy storage systems can store excess renewable electricity during high generation and discharge it when demand rises but power generation is low.

Transmission bottlenecks and grid congestion, particularly during high solar generation in the daytime, are resulting in re-

newable power being curtailed or facing restrictions on evacuation. The challenge is becoming more pronounced as renewable capacity expands faster than the associated transmission infrastructure.

Of the scheme’s total outlay, over Rs 1.36 lakh crore has been earmarked for developing intra-state transmission systems (InSTS), while Rs 50,000 crore has been allocated for 50 GWh of BESS. It entails total Central Financial Support of Rs 54,082 crore, which the Centre said will help offset intra-state transmission charges and keep power costs lower for end users.

Under the InSTS component, all greenfield projects will be implemented through tariff-based competitive bidding (TBCB) route, while brownfield



Centre has approved Rs 1.86 lakh crore GEC-III to evacuate up to 135 GW of renewable energy. REUTERS

upgrades and network-strengthening works will be undertaken on a cost-plus basis (CPB). Under TBCB, private transmission companies compete to develop and operate a project at a competitively de-

termined tariff, whereas the CPB model means the project cost and an approved return are recovered through the regulated tariff.

State transmission utilities will serve as overall implement-

ing agencies, while transmission service providers will participate in TBCB process under a build-own-operate-maintain model, the government said. The scheme is targeted for completion by FY33.

Infra creation, hurdles

Santosh Kumar Sarangi, Secretary, Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE), had told the media that India is expected to add around 400 GW of RE capacity between 2030 and 2035-36, requiring about 160 GW of additional InSTS infrastructure. Of this, GEC-III is expected to support 135 GW of infrastructure creation at the state level.

Sarangi said the scheme is expected to support renewable power evacuation while also helping decentralise RE capac-

ity, which has so far been concentrated in five states. He said proposals have been received from at least 13 states along with transmission lines to be part of GEC-III. This would expand GEC’s geographical coverage, with GEC-I having been implemented across eight states and GEC-II across seven states.

The scheme is also expected to boost private-sector participation in state-level transmission infrastructure. Greenfield projects, traditionally developed by states largely on CPB using budgetary resources or loans, would now be opened to TBCB, he said.

Notably, MNRE is implementing GEC in two phases to augment transmission lines and transformation capacity through InSTS and ISTS net-

works. But there have been implementation delays.

Sarangi said GEC-I is expected to be completed by March 2027, while all projects under GEC-II are expected to be completed by 2028. He added there will be a steering committee at the Cabinet Secretary level, which will monitor progress of GEC-III and GEC-II twice a year.

Transmission constraints are seen as a major challenge in evacuation of power from RE sources. During FY26, around 6,900 GWh of clean electricity faced restrictions owing to a mismatch between the rapid pace of RE deployment and commissioning of associated transmission infrastructure, latest government data shows.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, OCTOBER 5, 2026

NEW S M A K E R S I N T H E N E W S R O O M

WHY RAMACHANDRA GUHA

Ramachandra Guha is one of India's leading public intellectuals who has written on Gandhi, apart from other significant themes, including the environment. It isn't just that this interaction was timed around Gandhi Jayanti, but that his new book *Arguments With Gandhi* (HarperCollins) discusses the interactions of the Mahatma across multiple themes and registers. What makes an interaction with Guha important now is that Gandhi's methods are again in news, with protests erupting, particularly among the youth, over many grievances and demands. In this context, Guha discusses not just his book but also the afterlives of Gandhi

'Maybe it's a new generation that will find their own Gandhi, which will be different from mine and yours'

Historian Ramachandra Guha on his book *Arguments With Gandhi*, why Gandhi has both followers and critics, the points where Gandhi and Ambedkar diverge and converge and why student protests should go beyond these two national figures. The session was moderated by Vikas Pathak, Deputy Associate Editor, *The Indian Express*

ON THE HINDU RIGHT AND GANDHI

Gandhi is anathema for the Hindu Right because he believed in equal rights for Muslims and he practised non-violence. They are looking for anyone who, at any stage, quarrelled with him

Vikas Pathak: In your book, you refer to the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the appropriation of figures like Bhagat Singh and Subhas Chandra Bose. Why do you think there's this tendency to appropriate figures who were either with the Indian National Congress or revolutionaries with Left leanings?

There's a general answer and a specific answer. The general answer is that the Hindu Right, whose ideological ancestors would be the Hindu Mahasabha and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), never really participated in the freedom struggle. There were two important strands in that movement, one was embodied in the Indian National Congress, which articulated a philosophy of non-violence, and the secondary strand was of revolutionary violence.

Now, the Hindu Right either were agnostic on the question of the freedom struggle or in some critical moments, supported the colonial state. That's the general answer. The specific answer is that although the Hindu Right has a strong dislike for the Congress, much of their criticism is against Nehru but Gandhi, for them, is anathema. For two reasons. One being that Gandhi believed in equal rights for Muslims and he eventually died for the cause of Hindu-Muslim harmony. The secondary reason is that he practised non-violence, which is regarded by sections of the Hindu Right as effeminate, not combative enough. So, given that they have no pre-history of participating in the freedom struggle, they are looking for anyone, who at any stage, quarrelled with Gandhi.

The case of Patel is different. The appropriation of Patel is actually only over the last eight or nine years. It has a different context. The *trimurti* (trinity) that I begin my book with was a statue erected by the ABVP on the Delhi University campus, which had Savarkar, who belongs to them — he is an ideological precursor of the government that is in power today — along with Bose and Bhagat Singh, who would have been appalled to be clubbed with Savarkar. But they are united in the mind of the Hindu Right because all three, at different stages of their career, opposed Gandhi.

Vikas Pathak: But, there is counter argument that there were other figures too who did not participate in the freedom struggle but they were active in the public sphere. There was Ambedkar, Swami Vivekananda, Aurobindo.

You are right. There were many strands that were not narrowly anti-colonial but the origins of these different strands cannot be collapsed. Ambedkar and RSS are also not on the same page. But my book is thematic. It's a book of ideas and arguments: political arguments, social reform arguments, moral arguments, economic arguments. It's not part of this endless debate. The intention of my book is to take these four large ideas: non-violence, justice, religion, and economy and progress, and see what Gandhi tried to articulate, how it was opposed by different people and to what extent the critics were right and to what extent Gandhi's original position holds.

Vikas Pathak: Over the last 10-12 years, there has been a tendency to pit freedom fighters against one another. It is as if Nehru is on one side and Patel, Bose and Bhagat Singh on the other side, which they were not. Later, it was JP and Patel, who actually did not see eye to eye. How do you see this?

There are two aspects to that question. One is within the Congress party. As you point out, Nehru and Patel had differences but the Congress was a broad church, and in the interest of the party and of building the nation, they submerged their differences and worked together.

And there were genuine differences between the Congress and other strands. Between the Congress and Bhagat Singh, and the revolutionary movement, there was this question of violence versus non-violence. As for Bose, the difference arose on the question of whom to support in World War II: the British or the Nazis. These differences were genuine in the context of the 1920s and '30s, but in the context of the Hindu Right, Bose and Bhagat Singh are on the same side as Gandhi because they do not believe in Hindu supremacy. So that is where this appropriation is so tendentious and mischievous.

Vikas Pathak: Gandhi, despite his global stature, is attacked by multiple streams, there's a Hindutva attack, the communist attack, the Ambedkarite attack. How do you explain this?

There's a fourth attack, the economic modernisers' attack, who say Gandhi was a

backward reactionary. He exalted the village economy and was anti-development. That's the interesting thing about working on Gandhi: His ideas provoke debate, disagreement and sometimes outright hostility and that makes him a fascinating figure for historians.

Immediately after Independence, there was a cult of Gandhi, there was Gandhi Jayanti, there was Gandhi on the currency note, and every prime minister would go to Raighat. That was excessive but have we turned the other way? Have we demonised him excessively? Don't we still need him if you want to cultivate Hindu-Muslim harmony, if you want to have a civil public discourse, if you want to be sensitive to the environmental dimensions of economic development? But Gandhi has come back into public conversation in the last few months because of the students' protest. CJP's Ashutosh Rana often praises Gandhi but Abhijeet Dipke, an Ambedkarite Mahar from Maharashtra, said, "We read Ambedkar and Gandhi".

Devyani Onial: The Chipko Movement used the Gandhian method of non-violent resistance. In that context, how do you see the big-ticket infrastructure push in the ecologically fragile hills?

For this, I'll have to go back 40 years. My doctoral dissertation was on peasants and forests in the Himalayas. Early in my research, I met two remarkable Gandhians, both in their 90s: Chandi Prasad Bhatt from Garhwal and Radha Bhatt from Kumaon — that's the kind of legacy that the environmental movement must carry forward. Gandhi never used the word 'environmentalism' but I have a chapter in my book called 'Gan-

dhi's Precocious Environmentalism', where I talk about his ideas on forests, on water, on soil fertility, his critique of chemical agriculture, his austere lifestyle and his warnings that the globalisation of Western-style industrialisation. I think what has happened in Uttarakhhand, particularly with large dams, with mines, and the Char Dham highway, and even possibly a railway line, from Rishikesh to Kamaprayag is just crazy.

Vikas Pathak: Do you think that Gandhi and Ambedkar can be seen as converging or complementary?

Their social locations were different, so in their lifetime, they were bound to disagree. Gandhi was a guilt-ridden upper-caste reformer practising the path of 'self-purification'. Ambedkar was a Dalit who had experienced oppression himself and was practising the path of 'self-respect'. Ambedkar was 23 years younger than Gandhi, it was almost like a father-son debate. But after their death, given that caste inequality still exists, they have to be brought together. And that, I think, is the wisdom of young people like Dipke.

Vikas Pathak: On the Gandhi-Ambedkar debate regarding separate electorates, which one do you prefer?

I'm agnostic on this. In the book, I talk about post-Ambedkarites, who criticised joint electorates. I have a section on Kanshi Ram, who called Dalits elected in joint electorates *chamchas* because he felt that they will be answering to the whims of the upper-caste majority that helped elect them.

On the other hand, today, there are 543 Lok Sabha constituencies because there are

joint electorates and a Dalit vote in almost every one of those 543 constituencies. They can radically reshape the result of any election conducted fairly, which is why every political party pays obeisance to Ambedkar, much more than they do to Gandhi, or to an Adivasi leader like Birsu Munda or Jaipal Singh. Because Adivasis are concentrated in Adivasi electorates. So, Adivasis can probably influence something like 80 to 100 seats in the Lok Sabha; Dalits could affect 500. Now, if you were to have separate electorates, Dalits would only affect about 75 or 80, 15 per cent of the seats. It's a complicated argument, and today, provided the voting is free and fair, they are not struck off the rolls

inside some kind of arbitrary SIR, I am not sure that separate electorates are the answer. (We need) more independent-minded Dalit candidates, more ministers in positions of authority, not just token presidents or parties but maybe even prime ministers and home ministers. I don't think there's a straightforward case for separate electorates.

Shiny Varghese: Gandhi romanticised villages but do you think the future of our cities was not given enough thought?

To give an overall picture, when it comes to non-violence, in a context like India, Gandhi was dead right. When it comes to Hindu-Muslim harmony, he was dead right. When it comes to economic policy, I think he was neither dead right nor dead wrong. The people who opposed him were dead wrong because they practised a kind of energy-intensive, capital-intensive, resource-gathering industrialisation, first under state plan-

ning and now under the neo-liberal economy. The environmental consequences have been the same. So the people who opposed it were dead wrong. But Gandhi was not dead right either. His was a moderating influence. You may still need some skyscrapers, some centralisation. So I see him not as someone who gave an economic blueprint. His ideas were a moderating influence even for cities.

For instance, in Bangalore, where I live, why not practise more water conservation, why not have more green spaces, why not privilege public transport? Rather than the chief minister deciding what is good for Bangalore, why not have the local councils, the municipality decide?

So I think Gandhi as an economic thinker is prescient about the environmental and social devastation; he offers us some ideas that can nudge us towards a less destructive, more sustainable path.

Aakash Joshi: There has been criticism of Gandhi, especially abroad, at university campuses around race, some of his physical and sexual practices and gender. How much of him was a genuine engagement, given the honesty with which he wrote?

Section two of my book, which is called 'Justice', has three chapters. The first chapter is called 'Caste: The Life and Afterlife of the Gandhi-Ambedkar Debate'; the second chapter is called 'Gender: The Partial Unmaking of a Reluctant Patriarch' and the third chapter has the straightforward title, 'Was Gandhi a Racist?'

And I trace the evolution of his views very carefully. I show that as a young man, he was a racist. He went to South Africa in his early

20s carrying the prejudices of his time — an upper-caste Indian obsessed with skin colour, thinking Africans are backward, thinking Indians are more or less equal to Europeans as two great old civilisations but the Africans are lost in the forest kind of thing. But then how his views changed over time when he was in South Africa and he returned to India and was a principal anti-racist in the last decades of his life.

It's easy to cherry-pick Gandhi, quote him from Volume 6 of the *Collected Works* and forget what he said on the same subject in Volume 40 or Volume 86. He was a racist as a young man, and he slowly shed his prejudices, and this is part of Gandhi's deep and essential humanity. He's always growing, he's always listening, he's always modifying his views. Even on technology. He never wholeheartedly accepts Western industrialisation but he can see the benefits of what science can offer.

Aakash Joshi: In the last 10-odd years, we have seen history becoming a battleground as well as a government project. How do you see this?

Obviously the BJP has taken this to an extreme. They use the rewriting of history to promote a kind of crude majoritarian agenda and to distort events so that a Hindu king now happens to have won a battle he actually lost. But the Congress is not above criticism either.

In 2018, the Congress came to power in Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. I am someone who believes that historians — Clío, the muse of history was an anarchist — should not associate with states.

Within weeks of the Congress coming to power, I got letters from ministers saying, 'Please address all of us on Jawaharlal Nehru, not on Savarkar, because Savarkar can't be known'. And the Congress textbooks in the 1960s and '70s

were not perfect. However, those produced during the UPA regime of 2004-2009 were excellent. There was a visionary director of the NCERT, Krishna Kumar. For history textbooks, he had recruited a very good team headed by Neeladri Bhattacharya. He curated a series of textbooks which was not just Prithviraj versus Akbar, Nehru versus Savarkar, but around themes, particularly in ancient and medieval India, around housing, food, dress, forms of transportation and how these changed and evolved. Now those are beautiful ways of introducing young people to the nuances and complexities of history and changes over time.

Khushi Sinha: Do you think India needs a modern-day Gandhi?

India does not need a modern-day Gandhi. It does not need a modern-day Ambedkar. It does not need a modern-day Nehru. It does not need a modern-day Tagore. It does not need a modern-day Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay. Although those are the five modern Indians I admire most. It needs a synthesis of all of these renewed for our times.

I think in one of Ambedkar's great speeches in the last meeting of the Constituent Assembly, he warned against the dangers of hero worship. He said *bhakti* in religion is a route to the salvation of the soul, *bhakti* in politics is a route to eventual dictatorship. He was prescient about Indira Gandhi, he would have been prescient about Narendra Modi. We can't have one leader, we must have a bouquet of ideas.

So, to the young kids of Jantar Mantar — they had Ambedkar, they had Nehru, sometimes they had Bhagat Singh — I wish they had Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay, possibly also Tagore, but I'm very happy they did not have Savarkar, Hedgewar and Golwalkar, those are exactly what we do not need.

Vikas Pathak: Freedom fighters usually are most popular in the region to which they belonged, like Bose is in Bengal and Bhagat Singh in Punjab. But the irony is that Gandhi is not an icon in Gujarat and Nehru is not an icon in Prayagraj, from where he came. How would you explain this?

Gandhi drew on dissenting traditions within the state. He drew on poet Narsinh Mehta, who preached compassion and tolerance. So when it came to his religious pluralism, maybe he was an anomaly. But you pointed out something very interesting — Khushwant Singh once criticised Tagore, and the entire West Bengal legislative assembly stood up and censured him. You cannot criticise Savarkar in Maharashtra, Ambedkar among the Dalits. Gandhi in India belongs to everyone and to no one. Nehru at least belongs to the Congress party, which has been run by his descendants for some time. Gandhi belongs to everyone. And maybe it's a new generation that will find their own Gandhi, which will be different from mine and yours.

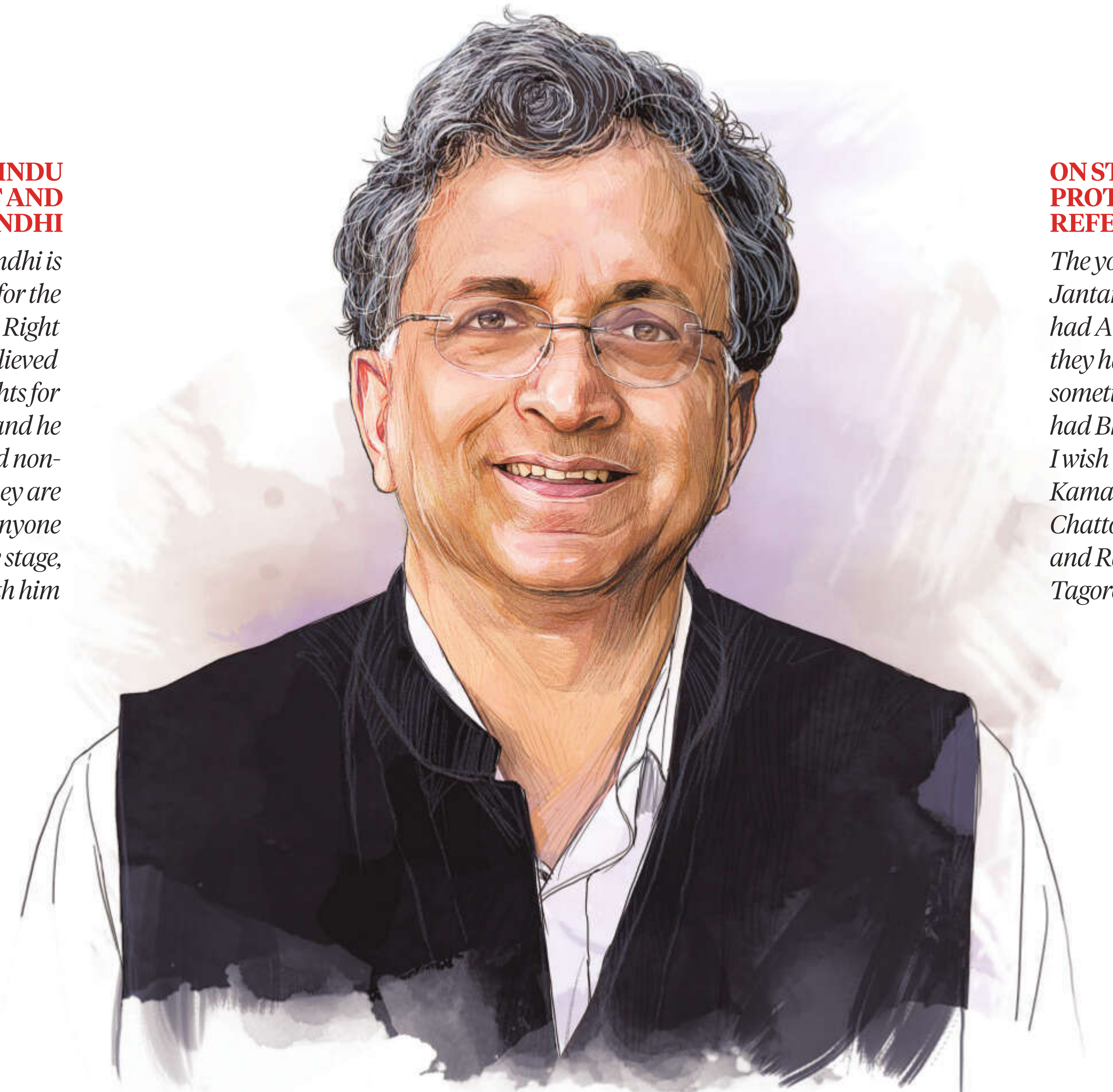
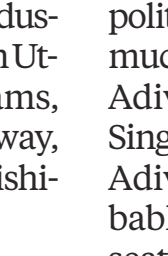


ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY



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{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Vision correction without lasers

SCIENTISTS are developing a possible alternative to LASIK that reshapes the cornea without cutting it or using a laser. The technique uses a small electric potential and a specially shaped platinum lens to temporarily soften the cornea, allowing it to be moulded in about a minute. Early experiments using rabbit eye tissue suggest the method could potentially correct vision in about a minute, without incisions and with much simpler equipment. Rather than physically removing tissue, this method uses a small electric potential to temporarily alter the chemical environment inside the tissue.



Body clock key to stroke recovery

SCIENTISTS AT the University of Rochester Medicine have found that strengthening the body's natural daily rhythms to improve sleep may help the brain recover after a stroke. This helped mice recover after a stroke by improving the brain's waste-clearing system and reducing lingering inflammation. The approach worked even when treatment began three days after the stroke, suggesting circadian-based therapies could offer support long-term recovery. One of the most promising approaches was time-restricted feeding, an intervention that is being investigated for obesity, diabetes and heart disease.



What coffee does to gut, brain

A NEW study by University College Cork suggests coffee may influence mood and brain function by changing the activity of gut microbes. Both caffeinated and decaf coffee were linked to lower stress, depression and impulsivity, while also producing measurable changes in gut bacteria. Decaf was associated with better learning and memory, while caffeinated coffee appeared to reduce anxiety and improve attention. The findings add to growing evidence that coffee should not be viewed as a source of caffeine. Its components may interact with the microbiome, metabolism and nervous system.



Pomegranate ups heart function

A NATURAL compound the body produces after consuming foods such as pomegranates may improve heart function by as much as 80 per cent in experimental models of a form of heart failure that currently has relatively few treatment options. Researchers at King's College London found that urolithin A, which is produced in the body after eating foods including pomegranates, walnuts and some berries, can help the heart relax. The compound also reduced scarring and limited harmful enlargement of the heart. Urolithin A significantly improved relaxation in heart tissue created from stem cells, too.



Smell chocolates to boost workouts

SIMPLY SMELLING chocolate helped men complete more leg extension repetitions without making the workout feel harder, with dark chocolate producing the strongest effect. The researchers think familiar food aromas may influence appetite and motivation by making the brain anticipate eating. Smelling dark chocolate was consistently associated with lower hunger, less desire and intention to eat and fullness. The dark chocolate aroma appeared to reduce appetite and increase perceived fullness. Sniffing a 90 per cent dark chocolate added about 18 more repetitions to participants' leg extensions.





CONSULTATION ROOM

DR NARESH TREHAN

CHAIRMAN AND MANAGING DIRECTOR, MEDANTA

Are we treating heart attacks too late?

India needs to shift from reacting to heart attacks to addressing risks earlier

EVERY DAY, people walk into hospitals across our country after the chest pain that they initially dismissed as acidity finally becomes unbearable. Patients need prompt diagnosis and treatment but uncertainty, fear of medical costs and concerns about busy healthcare facilities can often lead to people delaying seeking care.

This is a pattern that quietly plays out again and again — patients losing precious time while their heart muscle quietly collapses. According to the Global Burden of Disease, 2021, heart disease is the most common cause of death in India, accounting for 28.6 lakh deaths annually. Moreover, we Indians develop heart disease almost a decade earlier than the global average, which means working-age adults, the breadwinners of their families, are increasingly the ones affected.

In the 1970s, American cardiologist Dr Eugene Braunwald coined the phrase “time is muscle.” What this means is that a heart attack is not a singular, sudden event — muscle damage slowly spreads over time, and because the damage takes several hours to complete, doctors can save the muscle if they restore blood flow quickly. The first 90 minutes after the heart attack offer the best chance of limiting permanent damage.

Unfortunately, half of all heart attack deaths in India occur before the patient ever reaches a hospital. Guidelines recommend an ECG (electrocardiogram) within 10 minutes of first medical contact but in practice, many patients travel for hours and often have to visit two or three healthcare centres before that first ECG is even done. Improving outcomes cannot depend only on treating patients once a heart attack has occurred. Prevention has an equally important role to play. Understanding risk factors, recognising warning signs early and making healthier choices can help reduce the risk of heart disease before it reaches an emergency.

For decades, cardiology has largely been a reactive speciality. We wait for the chest pain, the ECG, the blocked artery and then we intervene. This cannot remain our working model — recent evidence estimates that cardiovascular disease affects around 11 per cent of India's adult population, and metabolic risk factors such as high blood pressure, cholesterol and blood sugar are highly prevalent in our country. A model built only around emergency response will always be racing against a clock. The answer is to have

a model of cardiac care that is predictive, preventive and personalised and can help us intervene before an emergency. Additionally, metabolic and lifestyle factors together account for the overwhelming majority of India's cardiovascular risk and nearly all of it is modifiable. This is where preventive healthcare comes into play. The most powerful intervention is not a stent or a bypass. It is controlling blood pressure, cholesterol and blood sugar, staying physically active, eating well and staying away from all forms of tobacco.

Advances in medical technology are changing how we approach prevention. Today, non-invasive tools, including carotid and femoral plaque imaging, CT coronary angiography and coronary calcium scoring can help detect plaque build-up years before symptoms appear. Wearable sensors and AI-based risk tools add another layer, flagging abnormal heart rhythms or blood pressure trends long before they turn into emergencies. Furthermore, personalised medicine is important because the risk profile of a 35-year-old professional with a family history of heart disease looks nothing like that of a 60-year-old managing diabetes and hypertension. Some conditions, such as atrial fibrillation (heart rhythm irregularity in the upper chamber) can stay completely silent until a stroke becomes the first symptom. Tailored, risk-based screening, rather than one-size-fits-all check-ups, is how we catch such patients in time.

We need to close the gap between symptoms and treatment at every level. For that, we need stronger awareness of heart attack symptoms and the golden hour. We need diagnostic facilities beyond our metro cities, stronger networks that connect smaller healthcare centres to specialist cardiac care, and routine, risk-based preventive screening rather than screening only after a crisis. For this, the public and private sectors must work hand in hand. Because with heart disease, every hour of delay is paid for in human lives.

Anonna Dutt

WHEN RASIKA Bombatkar, 30, developed a persistent cough one monsoon four years ago, doctors initially saw little reason for concern. She was young, a non-smoker and, therefore, did not fit the conventional profile of a lung cancer patient. Two weeks later, still coughing, she sought help again — this time prompted by an awareness campaign featuring actor Amitabh Bachchan that urged people to get tested for tuberculosis (TB) if a cough persisted. Two months after her symptoms began, doctors finally diagnosed what had been missed: late-stage lung cancer.

“I was diagnosed only after I insisted that I get a CT scan, even though the doctors kept telling me about the side effects of getting unnecessary scans. I was lucky to be an allied health professional. I could do the research on my own, I could insist on the test at the hospital I worked at,” says Bombatkar, who was then working as a physiotherapist at Christian Medical College (CMC), Vellore. Once doctors saw the CT scan she had insisted on, the picture changed. The cancer had already spread from her lungs to her lymph nodes. A lymph-node sample confirmed the diagnosis.

Her experience, which she shared at the just-concluded World Cancer Congress in Hong Kong, illustrates a larger problem confronting efforts to detect lung cancer early: the people most likely to benefit from screening are not necessarily the only ones who develop the disease. “All the medical literature stating that the disease usually happens at a later age, among people who have been smoking for years, means that even doctors do not suspect it in the young. But the reality is that people like me also get the disease and the doctors should at least review such decisions when symptoms are present,” Bombatkar told *The Indian Express*. This comes at a time when the International Agency for Research on Cancer (IARC) published its perspective on cancer screening in the *New England Journal of Medicine*. The study says that screening for lung cancer using Low Dose Computed Tomography (LDCT) can help in early detection and improve the odds of survival. However, with the radiation accumulated from the LDCT itself increasing the risk of other types of cancers, the screening is suggested only in high-risk groups — people who are between the ages of 50 and 80 years and have been smoking a pack a day for at least 20 to 30 years.

Living as the other

Even after diagnosis, Bombatkar found herself having to explain why she had lung cancer. “All the campaigns against tobacco smoking warn of lung cancer. But in doing so, it makes people think that the people who get the disease deserve it,” she says.

Bombatkar is now sharing her experience publicly because she wants other patients, particularly those who do not fit the conventional profile of lung cancer, to recognise that persistent symptoms should not simply be dismissed. “I wanted to talk about my journey to tell people that they are not alone, to tell them that they should trust their bodies,” she says. “Yet, my doctors, relatives and neighbours always rein me in, saying I should not be talking about my disease when I am doing okay. It's because of my father's support that I am here talking to everyone about it.”

Being young and a non-smoker does not mean zero risk. As lung cancer in never-smokers receives greater attention, researchers are examining the roles of air pol-

When lung cancer doesn't fit the profile

Young, non-smoking patients are diagnosed late because doctors and screening programmes continue to look at older smokers. A survivor's experience exposes the cost of that blind spot



Rasika Bombatkar during a badminton practice session



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lution, genetics, second-hand smoke and other environmental exposure. However, current screening criteria are largely built around age and cumulative smoking exposure, so they may not capture every person who develops lung cancer.

The early detection challenge

Lung cancer is often diagnosed only after it has spread, when treatment becomes harder and the chances of survival fall. In India, it was the third most common cancer in 2024, affecting 1.12 lakh people and killing more than 98,000, according to Global Cancer Observatory data. It accounted for

7.2 per cent of all cancers but 10.9 per cent of cancer deaths in the country.

A study based on data from India's cancer registries found that nearly 45 per cent of patients were diagnosed only after the disease had spread. The researchers called for stronger lung-cancer-specific prevention and control measures and greater capacity among healthcare providers to ensure timely diagnosis and treatment.

But creating a national screening programme presents formidable challenges. The current evidence-based screening tool, LDCT, is expensive and not uniformly available. This issue was among those discussed

WHEN SYMPTOMS PERSIST: WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?



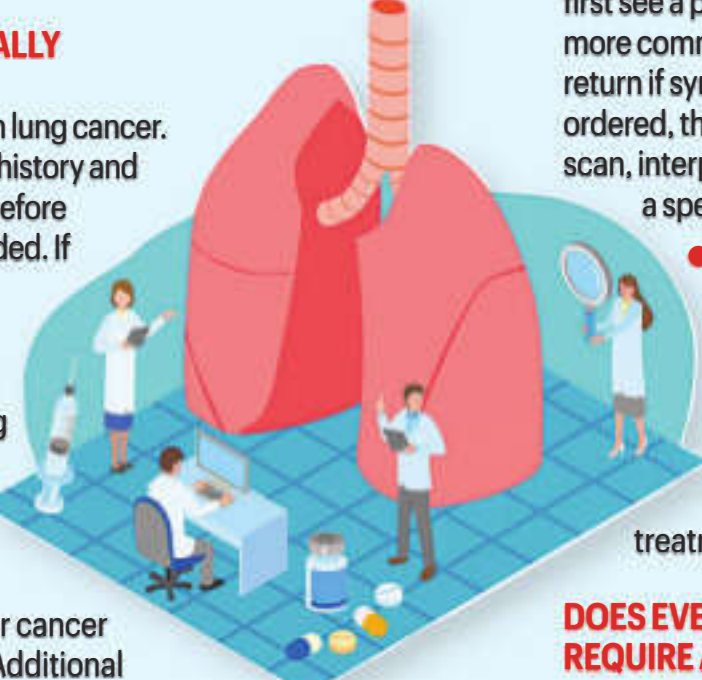
WHAT SYMPTOMS SHOULD YOU WATCH OUT FOR?

- Lung cancer can cause few or no symptoms in its early stages. When symptoms do occur, they can resemble common respiratory problems. These include:
- A cough that does not go away or changes over time
 - Coughing up blood
 - Breathlessness or new/worsening difficulty breathing
 - Persistent chest or shoulder pain
 - Repeated chest infections
 - Unexplained weight loss or loss of appetite
 - Persistent tiredness or weakness
 - Hoarseness or a change in the voice
- These symptoms do not by themselves mean

cancer and can have many other causes. What matters is whether they persist, worsen, recur or remain unexplained. A doctor may also consider whether several symptoms are occurring together.

HOW IS LUNG CANCER ACTUALLY DIAGNOSED?

- A scan cannot, by itself, confirm lung cancer. A doctor may first take a detailed history and perform a physical examination before deciding whether imaging is needed. If an X-ray or CT scan shows a suspicious area, further investigation may be required.
- Usually, this involves obtaining a tissue or fluid sample through a biopsy or another procedure. A pathologist examines the sample under a microscope to establish whether cancer is present and, if so, what type. Additional



tests may be needed to determine the stage and characteristics of the tumour.

WHERE CAN DELAYS HAPPEN?

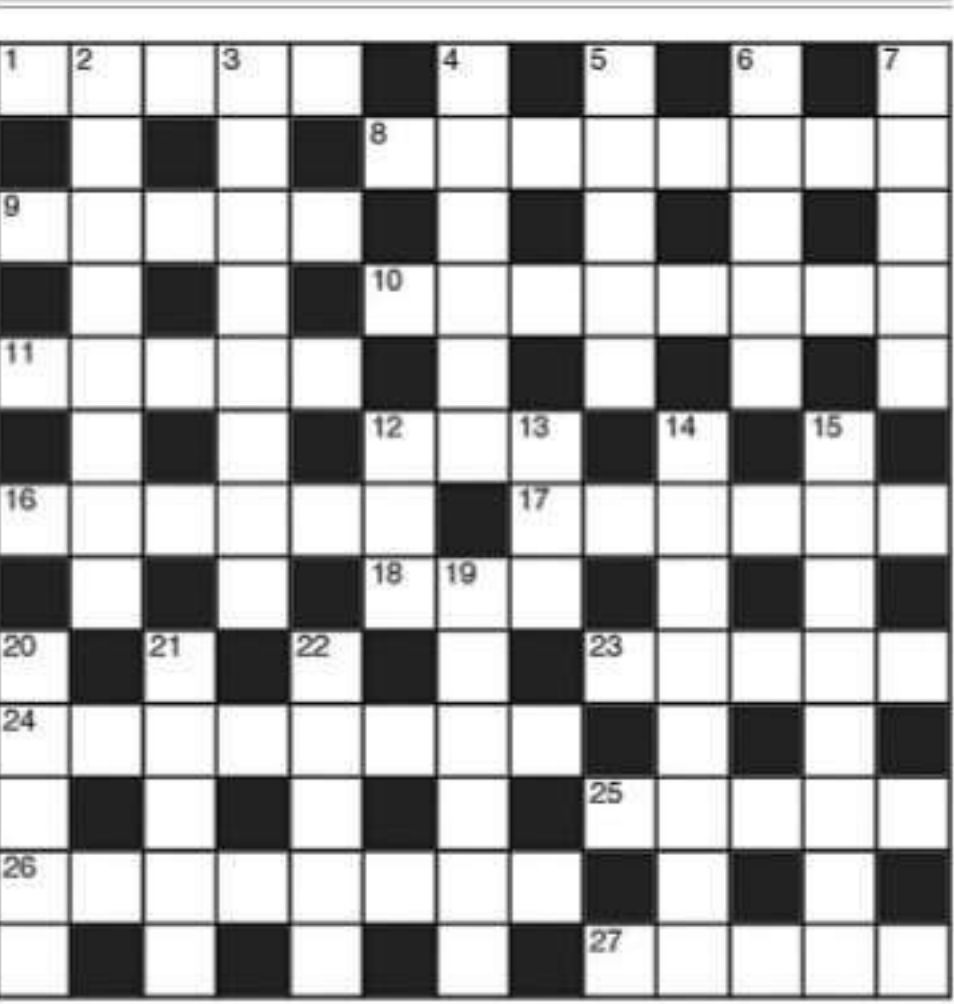
- Diagnosis is not a single event. A patient may first see a primary-care doctor, be treated for a more common respiratory condition and return if symptoms persist. If imaging is ordered, there can be delays in getting the scan, interpreting an abnormal finding, seeing a specialist or arranging a biopsy.
- Even after cancer is confirmed, treatment cannot always begin immediately. Doctors may need to establish the exact stage, obtain additional pathology and, for some patients, carry out genetic testing to determine which treatments are appropriate.

DOES EVERY PERSISTENT COUGH REQUIRE A CT SCAN?



- No. Cough is extremely common and can result from infections, asthma, allergies, reflux and many other conditions. Doctors consider its duration, severity, associated symptoms, examination findings, medical history and risk factors.
- CT scans can provide detailed images, but they also involve radiation and can reveal abnormalities that require additional tests but ultimately prove to be benign. The decision to scan therefore needs to be based on the individual clinical situation.
- AFTER LUNG CANCER IS CONFIRMED... Doctors establish the cancer's type and stage before deciding on treatment. Treatment can include surgery, radiation, chemotherapy, immunotherapy or targeted medicines, either alone or in combination.

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Not the best way to beat an opponent (5)
- 8 It may be paternal - or not (8)
- 9 Tongue of land round a lake that's overflowed (5)
- 10 A nose did suffer from them (8)
- 11 Employing a piece of dubious ingenuity (5)
- 12 Interview for a bishop's palace (3)
- 16 Figure in the art world (6)
- 17 Acquired permit ran out inside (6)
- 18 He may get beaten if he appears again (3)
- 23 Number get a fever that's ill-defined (5)
- 24 Excel as a bootblack? (8)
- 25 I'd try tidying up if in this condition (5)
- 26 Act when some came in late (8)
- 27 Accident on court? (5)
- DOWN
- 2 It comes in to fight on the other side (8)
- 3 The quality of the sea Italy's in perhaps (8)
- 4 Manage to hear a composer (6)
- 5 Food spilt by blabbermouths (5)
- 6 Remained so we hear sober (5)
- 7 An explosive expletive (5)
- 12 Determined group of people (3)
- 13 Wood used in model-making (3)
- 14 Fast mail used for one's resignation (8)
- 15 A form of question having inverted commas (2,6)
- 19 Cats in the pound (6)
- 20 They have their worth for a poet (5)
- 21 Checks rising symptoms of measles (5)
- 22 Plan to get a hundred deer (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6110 ACROSS: 1 Underscore, 6 Stab, 10 Cowed, 11 Puts about, 12 Artifice, 13 Hinge, 15 Lignite, 17 Spliced, 19 Titanic, 21 Mockery, 22 Roast, 24 All fours, 27 Charlotte, 28 Abeam, 29 Salt, 30 Crystal set DOWN: 1 Unco, 2 Downright, 3 Radii, 4 Caprice, 5 Rotters, 7 Thorn, 8 Better days, 9 Catholic, 14 Plate racks, 16 Innately, 18 Cheerless, 20 Chatter, 21 Millers, 23 Avail, 25 Osaka, 26 Smut

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

None are so empty as those who are full of ____ - Benjamin Whichcote (10)

EMLEE IYLMPR

SSTAH HOVELS

ANSWER: None are so empty as those who are full of themselves. - Benjamin Whichcote

SOLUTIONS: Melee, Primeval, Showel, Stash

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6462

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6461

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

BY BILL WATTERSON

BY TOM ARMSTRONG

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Social plans are unpredictable today. Likewise, sports events and playful activities with children are potentially accident-prone. Nevertheless, this is a powerful day to make creative advances and financial speculation. Tonight: Socialise.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Because your home routine might be interrupted today, get dressed and stock the fridge. Once the dust settles, a conversation with someone older might give you some direction. Tonight: Relax.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Pay attention to what you say and do today because this is a mildly accident-prone day for you. Keep your eyes open. On the upside, you might have some brilliant ideas because you can think outside the box. Tonight: An important conversation.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Keep an eye on your money and possessions today to protect them because something unexpected might impact what you own. On the other hand, you might have some innovative money-making ideas. Tonight: Check your money.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a tricky day. The Moon is in your sign lined up with Mars, Uranus and Saturn, so you'll feel ambitious, powerful, impulsive and yet ready to give things a sober, second thought. Go slowly, because this is also an accident-prone day. Tonight: You win.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Very likely, this is a restless day for you. It could be because of money and possessions, because these things are on your mind. However, someone in a position of authority might catch you off guard today. Tonight: Enjoy your privacy.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): A friend or a member of a group might surprise you today. Or you might surprise them. Fortunately, a discussion with a partner might anchor things for you in a solid way. Tonight: Talk to a friend.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): You're noticed today. Meanwhile, something unexpected might occur that calls attention to you. You might have a clever idea or something unexpected occurs. Stay light on your feet. You're ready to work hard. Tonight: You're admired.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Travel plans might be interrupted today, along with appointments related to medical, legal or educational issues. Give yourself extra time so you have wiggle room to deal with the unexpected. Tonight: Explore and learn something new.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Keep an eye on banking issues and anything to do with shared property, inheritances, taxes, debt and anything you own jointly with someone else. A family member might help you solidify things. Tonight: Check your finances.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Patience will be your best friend today, because important discussions with partners and close friends are tricky. You might have to deal with someone who is a bit aggressive, even unpredictable. Social plans might change. Tonight: Cooperate.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Your job routine might be interrupted today, especially if you work from home. You're motivated to be productive. You can use this energy to make some practical plans for the future. Tonight: Work.

BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE Date: 05.10.2026

Sealed tenders under Single Bid System are invited for following job from all bidders.

MIT No.	Brief Item Description	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/SL/1372	EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR APPOINTMENT OF AGGREGATOR (S) FOR DEMAND FLEXIBILITY / DEMAND RESPONSE PROGRAMS	26.10.2026 15:00 HRS	26.10.2026 15:30 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document : ₹ 1180/- (Including GST)
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services. Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submit of tender documents etc. please visit our website www.bsessedhi.com

Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd. Of: BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527
Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsessedhi.com

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोक निर्माण विभाग, अलीगढ़।

ई-टेंडरिंग निविदा सूचना (अल्पकालीन)

पत्रांक : 5490/कैशियर (प्राचार्यकां)-अगुगु/26-27 दिनांक 29.09.2026

महामहिम राज्यपाल उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनि, अलीगढ़, द्वारा निम्न तालिका में अंकित विवरण के अनुसार लोक निर्माण विभाग में मार्ग कार्य हेतु सुरंगल श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदार से आह्वान पर के आधार पर ऑन लाइन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदादाताओं को सरलाह दी जाती है कि निविदा जलने से पूर्व निविदा के लिए न्यूनतम अर्हता हेतु बिन्दु 1 का ध्यानपूर्वक अध्ययन कर ले।

क्र.सं.	जनपद का नाम	कार्य का नाम	निर्माण की अनुमानित लागत (A)	अनुसूचना मद की अनुमानित लागत (B)	कुल अनुमानित लागत (A+B) (लाख रु० में)	घरौहर धनराशि (लाख रु० में)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (रु० में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य सम्पादित कराने वाले अधिकांशी अभियन्ता का पता	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता के कार्यालय का पता	मुख्य अभियन्ता का पता	ठेकेदार की श्रेणी / अनिवार्य पंजीकरण
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 में स्वीकृति की प्रत्याशा में												
1	अलीगढ़	ये दोन सहावर बाइपास मार्ग का नवीनीकरण 5 वर्षीय अनुसूचना सहित	1500.00	37.50	1537.50	30.00	2000 + 300 + 414 Rs. 2714.00	12 Month	अधिकांशी अभियन्ता प्रि.रु.०-1 लोकनि वि. कारागंज	अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनि, अलीगढ़	अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनि, अलीगढ़	'ए' (पूर्ण कार्य में पंजीकृत)

1. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in/Prahari Portal> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्त ऑनलाइन देखे जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 07.10.2026 से 26.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन देखी जा सकती। ऑनलाइन बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in/Prahari Portal> पर अनिवार्य रूप से ऑनलाइन जमा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त टेकिन्कल बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे खोली जायेगी।

2. निविदा केवल ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर जमा की जाये।

3. इच्छु निविदादाता जिन्के पास डिजिटल सिग्नेचर सर्टिफिकेट (DSC) नहीं है, वह इसे निविदा जमा करने से पहले अग्रदूध एजेंसी से प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

4. निविदादाता द्वारा दरे जीएलएस्टीडी सहित अंकित की जाती है। भुतानत के समय लागू दरे पर जीएलएस्टीडी देय होगी।

5. बिडे गये कार्य का अनुसूचना अन्वि पत्र वर्ग होगा।

6. कम्पनी मूल्यांकन प्रवर्ती सौचदेवर द्वारा स्वयं किया जायेगा।

7. शासनादेश संख्या 14/2024/892/23-07-2024 दिनांक 09.08.2024 के अनुसार जमा करना आवश्यक है के अनुसार परफॉर्मन्स रिक्वायरी/अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मन्स रिक्वायरी प्रदान करना अनिवार्य है।

8. शासनादेश सं-17/2024/रु-113/23-1-2024-23-1099/113/2023 दिनांक 16.01.2024 एवं प्रमुख अभियन्ता, उग्रो लोकनिवि, लखनक का पत्रांक-3689801/आरएफएमसी/मूल-23-24 दि. 17.02.2024 के अनुसार उत्तर प्रदेश में समस्त मार्ग के अनुसूची में 05 वर्षीय अनुसूचना का प्रक्षिप्त किया जायेगा।

9. इच्छु अभियन्ता (विकान) एवं विभागका, उग्रो लोकनिवि, लखनक का पत्रांक-368/PJ-1/11/21 दिनांक/25 दिनांक 19.12.2025 के अनुपालन में निविदादाता/ठेकेदार/फर्म को रु० 5.00 करोड़ से अधिक लागत के मातृ कार्य का विवरण निविदा प्रपत्रों के साथ संलग्न प्रपत्रों पर भरकर निविदा के साथ अवसल किया जाना अनिवार्य होगा।

(आवर्त कुमार मनी)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
प्रधानीय वृत्त, लोकनिवि,
कारागंज

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(प्रमल कुमार चौधरी)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनिवि,
अलीगढ़

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोक निर्माण विभाग, अलीगढ़।

अल्पकालीन ई-टेंडरिंग निविदा सूचना

पत्रांक : 5499/कैशियर(C.D.-IE)-अगुगु/2026-27 दिनांक : 29.09.2026

महामहिम राज्यपाल उत्तर प्रदेश की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनि, अलीगढ़, द्वारा निम्न तालिका में अंकित विवरण के अनुसार लोक निर्माण विभाग में मार्ग कार्य हेतु सुरंगल श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदार से आह्वान पर के आधार पर ऑन लाइन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदादाताओं को सरलाह दी जाती है कि निविदा जलने से पूर्व निविदा के लिए न्यूनतम अर्हता हेतु बिन्दु 1 का ध्यानपूर्वक अध्ययन कर ले।

क्र.सं.	जनपद का नाम	कार्य का नाम	निर्माण की अनुमानित लागत (A)	अनुसूचना मद की अनुमानित लागत (B)	कुल अनुमानित लागत (A+B) (लाख रु० में)	घरौहर धनराशि (लाख रु० में)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (रु० में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य सम्पादित कराने वाले अधिकांशी अभियन्ता का पता	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता के कार्यालय का पता	मुख्य अभियन्ता का पता	ठेकेदार की श्रेणी / अनिवार्य पंजीकरण
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 में जनपद एटा के ताहसील जलेश्वर में नवीन बाइपास का निर्माण कार्य।												
1	एटा		1425.00	35.64	1460.64	29.21	2000 + 300 + 54 Rs. 2354.00	12 Month	अधिकांशी अभियन्ता प्रि.रु.०-1 लोकनि वि. एटा	अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनि, अलीगढ़	अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनि, अलीगढ़	'ए' (पूर्ण कार्य में पंजीकृत)

1. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in/Prahari Portal> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्त ऑनलाइन देखे जा सकते हैं। निविदा दिनांक 19.10.2026 से 26.10.2026 तक ऑनलाइन देखी जा सकती। ऑनलाइन बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in/Prahari Portal> पर अनिवार्य रूप से ऑनलाइन जमा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त टेकिन्कल बिड दिनांक 26.10.2026 को दोपहर 12:30 बजे खोली जायेगी।

2. निविदा केवल ई-टेंडरिंग के माध्यम से <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर जमा की जाये।

3. इच्छु निविदादाता जिन्के पास डिजिटल सिग्नेचर सर्टिफिकेट (DSC) नहीं है, वह इसे निविदा जमा करने से पहले अग्रदूध एजेंसी से प्राप्त कर सकते हैं।

4. निविदादाता द्वारा दरे जीएलएस्टीडी सहित अंकित की जाती है। भुतानत के समय लागू दरे पर जीएलएस्टीडी देय होगी।

5. बिडे गये कार्य का अनुसूचना अन्वि पत्र वर्ग होगा।

6. कम्पनी मूल्यांकन प्रवर्ती सौचदेवर द्वारा स्वयं किया जायेगा।

7. शासनादेश सं-17/2024/रु-113/23-1-2024-23-1099/113/2023 दिनांक 16.01.2024 एवं प्रमुख अभियन्ता, उग्रो लोकनिवि, लखनक का पत्रांक-3689801/आरएफएमसी/मूल-23-24 दि. 17.02.2024 के अनुसार उत्तर प्रदेश में समस्त मार्ग के अनुसूची में 05 वर्षीय अनुसूचना का प्रक्षिप्त किया जायेगा।

9. शासनादेश सं-17/2024/रु-113/23-1-2024-23-1099/113/2023 दिनांक 16.01.2024 एवं प्रमुख अभियन्ता, उग्रो लोकनिवि, लखनक का पत्रांक-3689801/आरएफएमसी/मूल-23-24 दि. 17.02.2024 के अनुसार उत्तर प्रदेश में समस्त मार्ग के अनुसूची में 05 वर्षीय अनुसूचना का प्रक्षिप्त किया जायेगा।

(आवर्त कुमार मनी)
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
निर्माण वृत्त-1, लोकनिवि,
एटा

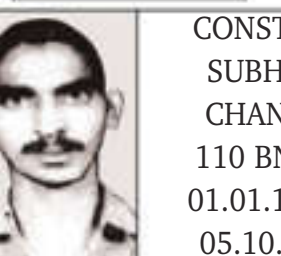
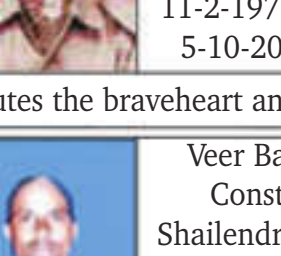
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अधीक्षण अभियन्ता,
अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लोकनिवि,
अलीगढ़

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Officers on their Balidan Diwas.

 INSPECTOR KAPIL DEO SINGH 88 BN BSF 05.05.1966 – 05.10.2025	 ASI/RO RAVI PAUL 19 BN BSF 20.04.1957– 05.10.2003	 CONSTABLE BHOPAL SINGH 141 BN BSF 06.06.1964 – 05.10.1991
 CONSTABLE SUBHASH CHANDER 110 BN BSF 01.01.1966 – 05.10.1991	 CONSTABLE SANATAMMAPPA BISALADINNI 34 BN BSF 05.02.1971 – 05.10.2000	
 INDO-TIBETAN BORDER POLICE (ITBP) ITBP salutes its braveheart Asstt. Sub-Insp. Chander Mani of 27th Battalion, who made the supreme sacrifice in the line of duty on this day in Chhattisgarh in 2016.		
 CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE Veer Balidani Head Constable Surtiya 80 Bn 19-3-1941 To 5-10-1994		
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Surtiya of 80 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after sustaining severe injuries while valiantly engaging militants during an encounter in Wazirbagh market, Srinagar, J&K on 5 October 1994. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.		
 Veer Balidani Constable/ Mahila Rekha Kushwah 88 Bn 1-1-1969 To 5-10-1991		
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable/Mahila Rekha Kushwah of 88 (Mahila) Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after sustaining grievous injuries while valiantly retaliating against indiscriminate firing by militants on a bus carrying CRPF troops returning from checking and frisking duty in Srinagar City, on 5 October 1991. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let her sacrifice go in vain.		
 Veer Balidani Constable Md. Abash Khan 28 Bn 11-2-1979 To 5-10-2004		
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Md. Abash Khan of 28 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 5 October 2004 after sustaining severe bullet injuries while spearheading a counter-attack against insurgents in Churachandpur district, Manipur, on 1 October 2004. CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.		
 Veer Balidani Constable Shailendra Pratap Singh 110 Bn 24-7-1984 To 5-10-2020		
 Veer Balidani Constable/Driver Dhirendra Tripathi 110 Bn 13-5-1988 To 5-10-2020		
DG and all Ranks of CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable/Driver Dhirendra Tripathi and Constable Shailendra Pratap Singh of 110 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after sustaining grievous injuries while valiantly repulsing a terrorist attack in Nowgam, Jammu & Kashmir on 5 Oct 2020. CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.		

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Deepak Sahdev S/o Amar Nath Sahdev R/o C-15 B, Ground Floor, Kalkaji, Kalkaji, South Delhi, Delhi, - 110019 have changed my name to Deepak Kumar Sahdev

0071063879-1

I, Arunav Sharma S/o Pradeep Sharma R/o C4C/207, Pocket 14, Janakpuri, West Delhi, Delhi-110058 have changed my name to Arunav Shaandilya

0071063881-1

I, No: 9101455L, NK- Salamati Ali Shameem, R/O- Ashtangoo, Tehsil- Alosa, District-Bandipora. In my Service records my wards name and Do B has been wrongly mentioned as Faheem Salamati, D o B- 06-01-2015, instead of Faheem Ali Shameem, D o B- 06-01-2016 as mentioned in school records and birth certificate. It needs correction. Objections be filed to Concerned Authorities within seven days.

0020521299-1

I hitherto known as SANTANU GOGOI Son Of MONJU GOGOI, Residing At Lakhimpur, Assam, 787031, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SANTANU SPRINGER. It is certified that I have complied with other legal requirements in this connection.

0050298977-1

I Suman D/o Prilam Singh R/o H.No 72, Block-AG, Shalimar Bagh North West Delhi, have changed my name after marriage from Suman to Shilpa Grover W/o Mahinder Grover for all future purposes

0040881591-1

I, Ruchi Singh W/o Maninder Singh Randhawa R/o RZ-D-5/71, Raj Nagar Part-2, Palam Colony, Bagdola, Delhi-110077 have changed my name to Ruchi Devi

0071063882-1

I Pooja Dudeja D/O, Manohar Lal Dudeja R/O 167-c, Pocket-iv Mayur Vihar, Phase-1, Delhi-110091 have changed my name to Pooja Chugh.

0040881663-1

I, Dinesh Solanki S/o B.S.Solanki R/O RZ-8H/2 (869), Gali No-5, Main Sagarpur, Nangal Raya, South West Delhi-110046 have changed my name to Dinesh Kumar Solanki

0071063877-1

I, Varshini Krishnan D/o V.K.S Krishnan R/o B1A-28A, Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058 have changed my name to Varshini Iyer

0071063885-1

I, MAMTA CHAUHAN, wife of RAVINDER KUMAR, resident of B-49, Ambika Enclave, Near Chota Pul, Nihal Vihar, PH-2, Nangloi Jat, West Delhi, Delhi-110041, have changed my name from "MAMTA CHAUHAN" to "MAMTA" and shall henceforth be known as "MAMTA" for all future purposes.

0050298982-1

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is declared in general public that my client MAYA DEVI W/O RATAN LAL, R/o H. NO. 367, GALI CHANDI WALL PAHAR GANJ, CENTRAL DELHI-110055, has severed all relationship with her son namely BAKESH ALIAS VICKY, his wife SARITA and his family due to their mis-behaviour and here by Debar and Disown them from all her movable and immovable properties absolutely and forever. Anybody dealing with them shall do so at their own cost and risk.

Sd/- (ABHINAV GUPTA) Advocate
Eart. No. D9378/1997
Ch. No. C&B, Chandrika Hotel,
49 Aaf All Road, New Delhi

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Do gold medals missed provide a silver lining?

Aichi-Nagoya showed that competition has got tougher in the continent, and even personal bests may not always be enough

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, October 4

DAY 1: A 10.4 and 10.1 from Elavenil Valarivan on her last two shots of the 10m air rifle erased the Indian's handy 1.5 lead, to see the first gold missed by India at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

What gets lost in the lament over the 27 silvers is acknowledgement that Japan's Hinata Taichi shot 10.6 and 10.2 to snatch that gold - coming out of the blue, given Japan didn't have a single medal in this event since 1994.

India finished tied on gold with Uzbekistan at 21, and only a last-day scramble helped push it up, with two extra silvers giving it fourth place. But all those silvers were gold medals lost.

Accepting that even India's best-ever showing in women's air rifle, Elavenil's silver, might not be good enough for gold is central to understanding why the country was stuck at just four the first week, reaching double digits (10) only on the 11th day of the Games.

The ultimate tally of 21 was seven off the 2023 Asiad with 28 gold, while total medal haul was 21 less than the 106 at Hangzhou.

The drop has come in several sports: Shooting (22 to 15; 4 golds less), Athletics (29 to 24; 5 gold less), Tennis (2 to 0; 1 gold less), Badminton (3 to 1; 1 gold less), Rowing (6 to 1); Equestrian (2 to 0; 1 gold less).

While archery made fantastic gains in recurve, its total count stayed constant at nine from 2023, with five gold medals, the same as last time. Squash retained its five medals, but with a significant drop of two gold.

Wrestling has maintained its count of six. While men added two gold to the nil last time, and won five of the six Indian medals, women's wrestling dropped from three last time to the one silver upgrade of Antim Panghal. Sujet Kalkal and Aman Sehrawat will be expected to carry the momentum to Los Angeles.

Boxing made real gains, going up from five to six medals - and significantly three gold from none last time.

The golf gold for Pranavi Urs is an uptick, as is the women's team silver.

However, a few medal drops are worrying. In badminton, Lakshya Sen could not defend HS Prannoy bronze while Ayush Shetty had a poor Games. Asiad medals are toughest in badminton, and Satwik-Chirag gold was missing in the 2026 tally.

Shooting sent a star-studded women's air pistol troika, but a medal was nowhere in sight after poor qualifications. While Suruchi Phogat salvaged matters with a strong comeback for the Mixed Team gold and Esha



The Indian 50m 3-Position team won no individual medals. (Below) Ancy Sojan narrowly missed out on a coveted long jump gold. PTI

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Singh fought four shoot-offs to take sports pistol silver, individual golds were out of reach till Neeru Dhanda won in trap. India had regressed in 50m 3 position since the Paris Olympics, with two silvers in the event, while they had won two gold in Hangzhou, among other medals.

Hits and misses

Parul Chaudhary recorded her Personal Best (PB) in 5,000m to take a second bronze. Steeplechaser Avinash Sable, defending a gold medal, did his season's best but missed a medal by four seconds to finish fourth. The next rung in steeplechase isn't on the horizon.

Other freakish circumstances struck. Murali Sreesankar, looking to upgrade his silver, slipped on the takeoff on his fourth attempt and was in no position to contend for gold. Two Chinese did their best in their fifth attempt to leapfrog Ancy Sojan in the long jump. The Indian could not summon a 6.60 jump, though her best this season is a national record. Hurdler Jyothi Yarraji, triple

jumper Praveen Chitravel and decathlete Thowfeeq Noushad couldn't register a mark to be in contention in their events.

While AFI president Adile Sumariwala had stressed that the athletes would peak at the Asiad, the periodisation seemed to have gone awry as the push for the Commonwealth Games disrupted fitness for Asiad, including taking Neeraj Chopra out of contention. The two big events within two months of each other also saw some athletes bomb at both places.

The rowing federation switched up combinations two days before the race, after crews had trained together for four years. They got an Australian expert to convey the news, and he didn't explain why his plan for gold didn't come through, or why the rowers were not kept in the loop. No gold fetched up either; it was chaos injected into an erstwhile well-oiled unit. Equestrian was blighted by contested selections. A gold and bronze from Hangzhou got casually tossed out.

Some losses are nuanced - could Gulveer Singh have focused on one event and gone all out for gold, instead of four races in five days, finishing with two silver and one bronze? Are double-starters in shooting (those who are fielded in two events) costing India gold?

Track and field athletes scored 11 personal bests, nine silvers and three season's bests. But the net result was one gold. It proves both that the competition has levelled up and Indians, even at their best, are only playing catch-up.

Nagoya fixed its Games, but never embraced them

Asiad overcame early organisational problems, but the compact, low-key event never quite captured the city's imagination — a contrast underscored by the biggest crowd arriving only for the closing ceremony



Mihir Vasavda
Nagoya, October 4

ON THE final night, Nagoya finally looked like it was hosting the Asian Games.

The stadium wasn't full. But after two weeks of competition in compact arenas with empty blocks of seats, more people turned up on Sunday to say goodbye. The noise rose into the night, the lights flashed, and the city seemed to have discovered the sporting festival sitting on its doorstep.

They roared when Qatari equestrian rider Jassim al Kuwari, astride Red Raiden, a six-year-old gelding, trotted into the Mizuho Park for the closing ceremony and took the Asian Games flag from high-jump great Mutaz Barshim. Then he pranced out, carrying the flag toward Doha - from the real world into the reel world, from one host city to the next.

They sang and danced and clapped as the fireworks went off, bringing a short, crisp ceremony to a close.

Rocky start

For much of the fortnight, the Asian Games had felt like a guest Nagoya had agreed to accommodate rather than a party it had decided to throw.

That was partly by design. Aichi-Nagoya wanted to make a point about how major sporting events should be hosted in



Qatar, hosts of the next Asian Games, were handed the Olympic Council of Asia flag. AP

the future. There would be no grand new athletes' village that would become a white elephant once the athletes left. No unnecessary stadiums. No attempt to reshape the city for a fortnight. Existing venues would be used, temporary structures would fill the gaps and money would be saved.

For a while, it looked like the experiment had gone wrong. The Games arrived amid a series of problems. There were accommodation mix-ups, transport troubles, accreditation issues and complaints about temporary facilities. Athletes were moved around. Buses were late. The number of participants grew beyond what organisers had planned for.

And then, slowly, the Games got better. There was no great moment of redemption.

No announcement that the crisis was over. But the buses began to arrive. The competitions ran. Athletes stopped talking about where they were sleeping and started talking about what they were trying to win. The noise around the organisation faded as the noise inside the arenas grew louder. Nagoya fixed what had looked like a broken Games. "There are no Games without initial interruptions," said Tayyab Ikram, chair of the coordination committee. "The way they were addressed should be more important. In future, we would like to see more sustainable solution, more innovation ... but without compromising on the athletes' conditions."

The sport was good. Spectacular, sometimes. The compact venues could create an

intimacy that enormous stadiums cannot. There were 54 world records, 11 junior records, and 89 Asian records.

But the empty seats told a story. They were striking because the venues were often small. A few hundred missing spectators could make an arena feel half-empty. There were sessions when athletes competed in front of more officials and volunteers than supporters.

There were banners, mascots. There were athletes in tracksuits wandering through railway stations. But the Asian Games never seemed to consume Nagoya the way the Olympics can swallow a host city. People went to work. Trains ran. Shops opened. Life continued. Perhaps that was another unintended success of the model.

The organisers had spent

years trying to make sure the Asian Games would not overwhelm the city. They did not want to build a temporary Nagoya that would disappear after the closing ceremony. They wanted the Games to fit into the city that already existed. And it did. Perhaps, a little too well.

A major sporting event is not only about the buildings it leaves behind. It is also about the memories it creates while it is there. It needs people who suddenly become interested in sports they had never watched, strangers shouting together, restaurants filling up after the last event, a city discovering new heroes.

Nagoya had some of that. But never quite enough. An analysis of spectator movement by Kyodo, a Japanese news agency, suggested that the crowds were predominantly local, with Aichi residents accounting for more than half of the domestic spectators at several venues.

Late goodbye

And then came the closing ceremony. The stadium was more packed than it had been at any point since the flame was lit. It was difficult not to smile at the timing. The biggest crowd of the Games had arrived when there was nothing left to watch.

Maybe they came to celebrate. Maybe they had finally become curious. Maybe they wanted one last glimpse before the circus packed up and left. Or maybe Nagoya, having spent two weeks politely living alongside the Asian Games, had finally decided it was time to say goodbye.

IN CONTEXT INDIA'S BREAKTHROUGH MEDALS

Not all medals are equal, some carry more importance than others due to competition or historic significance.

WOMEN'S HOCKEY: GOLD

India finished on top of the podium when the event made its debut at the 1982 Asian Games. It took 44 years for an encore. What makes the achievement special is that it comes with a direct berth at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympic Games. India had missed out on Paris after finishing narrowly outside the medals at the previous edition in Tokyo.

WRESTLING: Aman Sehrawat (Men's 57 kg category): Gold

By beating reigning world champ Han Chong Song of North Korea in the final, Aman added another feather in his cap after his bronze at the 2024 Paris Games. It is India's first-ever gold medal in the 57 kg category. Another wrestling medal of note is Nitesh Siwach's

silver in the men's 97 kg Greco-Roman, the first for India in 64 years.

ARCHERY: Kumkum Mohod (Women's recurve individual): Gold

Archery has been there in the Asian Games since 1978 but no Indian woman recurve archer had made the individual final. It took 17-year-old Kumkum Mohod to break the jinx. She didn't just

Neeru Dhanda



enter the final but also defeated Korea's Oh Je-yin to win the gold, also taking the Olympic quota.

SHOOTING: Neeru Dhanda (Women's Trap): Gold

For the first time in history, it was the shotgun section that won more gold medals than rifle/pistol. The main protagonist was Neeru Dhanda. Her trap individual gold was a first for India in the discipline since Randhir Singh climbed the top of the podium at the 1978 edition.

ATHLETICS: Sawan Barwal (Men's marathon): Silver

National record holder Sawan Barwal clocked 2:11:37 to win the silver in the event, ending a 44-year-old drought. Barwal's achievement is all the more praiseworthy as 10 runners on the start list had better personal bests than him, yet the Indian managed to better his own, and the country's mark.

PRITISH RAJ

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, October 4

GETTING PUNCHED in the head hasn't worried Lovlina Borgohain for a while now; rather, her headspace over the past few years has caused an odd sense of displacement.

No Indian boxer barring Mary Kom has the kind of resume the Assamese boxer carried to the Asian Games. Lovlina added another notch to that comparison, becoming only the second Indian woman to win boxing gold at the Asian Games after Kom — a twelve-year wait between the two. The gold, though, came after mental battles that Lovlina has faced in the last two years.

The backpack of medals she has won got heavier and heavier until 2024, when the weight, simply, was too much to handle. Losses started to follow and take their toll. The 2025 World Championship brought along with it the final gong of a round lost - for a boxer who had three medals and was the defending cham-

pion in her weight category, Liverpool brought her world crashing down. Two full years filled with disappointment left her scarred.

"A lot of things have to be faced when we come back after losing," said Lovlina. Back in Delhi after her campaign in Nagoya, it was those difficult mo-



ments that she remembered with a gold medal around her neck. "Accepting it yourself is very difficult... when we have expectations from ourselves, and the result doesn't come that way, it hurts a lot. Then somewhere that holds us back from moving forward," added Lovlina.

The way back to being herself started with a rethink. How she approached the sport had to be restructured. She began framing injuries and losses positively. In

a way, Lovlina chose not to care about the result — and just made an attempt to enjoy the process. It led to a therapeutic lack of pressure as she went into her second-ever Asian Games.

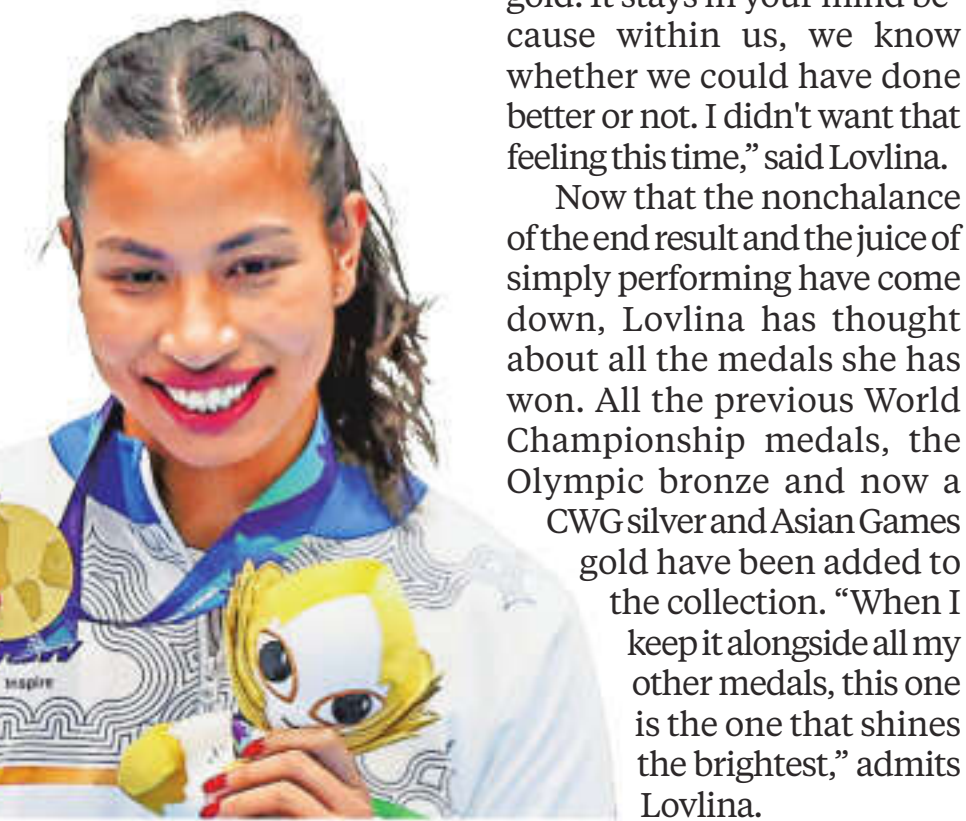
"First of all, I didn't go into the Games with high expectations. I had in mind that whatever the result is, I will accept it, but I have to give my best. So when gold came... I was not overly excited. Whatever happened, I accepted it. I was enjoying it — throughout the game, I enjoyed it. Whether gold came or not, even then, this would have been the best Asian Games of my life," admitted Lovlina.

But a silver at the CWG, a first for her, and now gold at the Asiad have put her back on track. Part of that realignment came from changes she made. Rather than working hard, Lovlina now works smart.

"When we play a competition, it's not a matter of one or two days of hard work; it's the

whole year. I had faith that overworking myself shouldn't be done. And the biggest thing I feel when we reach this stage, rather than pushing oneself too much, polishing oneself is more important. If you keep rubbing a diamond too much, it will get ruined," says Lovlina.

The changes she brought to her mindset were also reflected



during her semi-final match. Lovlina has been part of many multi-sport events for India, but this was the first time she won a gold medal. Usually, her campaign would end in the semi-finals or finals. But things felt different this time. "The semi-final match is very important because — either we have to be satisfied with bronze or we can try to win gold. It stays in your mind because within us, we know whether we could have done better or not. I didn't want that feeling this time," said Lovlina.

Now that the nonchalance of the end result and the juice of simply performing have come down, Lovlina has thought about all the medals she has won. All the previous World Championship medals, the Olympic bronze and now a CWG silver and Asian Games gold have been added to the collection. "When I keep it alongside all my other medals, this one is the one that shines the brightest," admits Lovlina.

